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ETHICS

AN EXPOSITION OF ETHICAL PRINCIPLES AND
THEIR APPLICATION TO THE MOST IMPORTANT
RELATIONS OF LIFE

BY

HARALD HØFFDING

FOURTH, NEWLY REVISED AND PARTLY
ALTERED EDITION

Translated from the Danish

*Etik. En Fremstilling af de etiske Principer og deres Anvendelse paa de vigtigste Livsforhold. Fjerde,
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Preface to the First Edition

When one catches sight of snow-covered mountains in the distance, they seem to float in the air. Only as one draws nearer does one see clearly that they have a firm and solid ground to stand on. So it is with ethical principles too. In the first enthusiasm one thinks one does them justice only by giving them a place raised as high as possible above actual nature and actual life. On closer reflection, and through longer and perhaps dearly bought experience, one discovers that they can guide life only when they have themselves come forth from life. My task in this book has been to show what the fundamental ethical ideas are, where they spring from, and how they find application in the most important relations of life. Practical experience and theoretical inquiry have confirmed in me more and more the conviction that ethical principles — the foundation and the standard of all judgments of good and evil — have their source in the very nature and conditions of man, independently of all authorities. This conviction I have here sought to establish and to carry through.

I have wished to give not merely an abstract doctrine of ethical principles, but also a demonstration of the applicability and the application of the principles set up. This task has demanded a large and varied material, and difficulties have constantly arisen for me, partly in finding the material, partly in limiting it. In order to compress my exposition within a frame of tolerably limited size, I have taken pains to express myself as briefly and concisely as possible. I am myself no lover of diffuse expositions, and I hope that no thoughtful reader will complain of my brevity.

Ethical discussions are frequent in our day. It becomes ever clearer that when religious, social, political and aesthetic questions stir minds so strongly, it is really the ethical side of these questions that bears the sign of contradiction. There would seem, then, to be a rightful place for an inquiry that sets out to bring to light the very foundation and standard of ethical judgments and to draw their consequences for some of the most important relations of life. Such an inquiry cannot, of course, treat exhaustively all the special fields it takes into account. It must find its justification in the light that can be thrown on the particular relations of life by setting them side by side with others

under a common illumination. But it presupposes a need to go back to the deepest-lying questions of principle, and one can politicize, aestheticize and dogmatize¹⁾ with great zeal without feeling this need. I believe it would be of great importance if this need could stir more than it does; it would give our intellectual life greater firmness and greater depth; but how far my work will be able to satisfy it is, of course, quite another matter. —

In the year 1876 I published a small work whose title was “On the Foundation of Humane Ethics.” It has often, wrongly but perhaps for brevity’s sake, been referred to as “humane ethics,” though it is not a treatment of the whole of ethics, but only of a few particular questions. In the present work some of these questions are taken up for an entirely new inquiry; on other questions (notably the doctrine of authority) I refer wholly to the older work; but the greater part of the contents of the present work is neither touched upon nor treated in the older one. —

As I now part from a work that has for a long time been the guiding thread of my reflection and my studies, I feel all too well how little I have achieved of what I had in mind, let alone of what might be demanded of a book that bears the venerable title: Ethics. I fear, too, that the book will contain a good deal that must be put down to the author’s personal account and that I have not succeeded in giving scientific form and grounding. It cannot be otherwise in a work of this nature. I must, moreover, here state something that will perhaps be a rank heresy in the eyes of eminent men of science. I wish that philosophy, and ethics in particular, may acquire as scientific a character as possible, and I have worked for that according to my ability; — but the peculiar attraction that philosophical studies have had for me from my earliest youth is nevertheless bound up with the fact that the subjects they deal with stand, after all, in a closer relation to the personality of the inquirer than do the subjects of other sciences. This does not, of course, prevent my having felt at every point the obligation to ground my views in an objective way.

So I leave the book to its fate. Could it find a circle of readers who, after going through it with attention and reflection, found that it did not wholly contradict the motto with which it ends, I should have achieved all I dare wish.

April 7, 1887.

HARALD HØFFDING.

¹⁾I ought to have added: moralize! (Later note).

Preface to the Fourth Edition

In the second edition of this book some less essential corrections and additions were made. — In the third edition a section was inserted (III, 21) in which I gave a characterization of a series of Danish works on the presuppositions of ethics. In the present fourth edition I have, besides some minor corrections in various places, added some remarks, mostly of a literary kind.

October 25, 1913.

HARALD HØFFDING.

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[1]

ETHICAL PRESUPPOSITIONS

I.

POSITIVE MORALITY AND SCIENTIFIC ETHICS.

1. Ethical judgments contain valuations of human actions. When in actual life we call an action good or evil, we do not thereby explain how the action came about, but we declare what value it has in our eyes. Every such valuation presupposes, on the one hand, that there is a need, a feeling, that drives us to judge the action (whether the judgment is merely passed in our own thoughts or also in words addressed to others), — and, on the other, that we have a standard, an ideal, with which the action can be compared and by which it can be tested. *The motive of ethical valuation* I call the *foundation* of our ethics, or its *motive of valuation*. Its character is essentially determined by the *fundamental value* on which the highest end of our life, and with it the standard of our ethical valuation, depend. *The standard of ethical valuation* becomes determinative for the content of our ethics, since it decides which actions, directions of life and forms of life can be called ethically good.

The character of an ethical view depends on what foundation it presupposes, what standard it applies, and what relation holds between its foundation and its standard.

But ethical judgments are for the most part not passed with an express and clear consciousness of the principles they presuppose. Such a consciousness, as it develops [4] further, leads to *scientific* ethics. But it awakens only when reflection and doubt make themselves felt. The question then naturally arises here, what justification and what significance the conscious bringing forward and discussion of ethical principles has at all.

2. Not only are ethical judgments, judgments of good and evil, passed before thinking proper and scientific inquiry awaken; but ethical judgments that are to have personal truth and practical significance must always spring from a living feeling and impulse that gives us no rest until we have spoken out. It is the condition of a sound and able life that we do not fetch the principles of our most important decisions from afar and by laborious reflection, but that the decision springs from what has become flesh and blood in us. In our ethical judgments we display our personality; they must therefore be determined by our whole nature and not merely by reasonings that we may carry on in our idle hours, if we have any. Life, besides, does not always give us time to think things over, but demands that judgment be pronounced on the instant.

And even if we have the time and the ability for reflection, will not our feelings and our impulses be so strong that through and through — without our noticing it

ourselves — they determine our thinking and lead it instead of being led by it? Is it not a prejudice, long since overthrown by psychology, that reason should be the sovereign authority within us, and has it not often enough been shown that what came forward as the utterance of reason was in reality an outbreak of the heart's need? In logic and mathematics pure reason may perhaps speak through our judgments; but its voice is too weak where the most concrete, the most personal thing of all is in question, namely human actions.

Will not reflection and criticism here even be questionable, if not positively harmful? Reflection always has a certain dissolving influence; it robs us of the instinctive certainty and security with which we begin our life. It weakens our strength even where it does not paralyze us by the doubts it awakens. We no longer act with concentrated energy [5] and no longer pronounce our judgments with force and confidence; indeed we may in the end become inclined to withhold our judgments, because it seems to us impossible to reach any sure decision. But then life dries up and in the end comes wholly to a standstill. For ethical judgments are not mere theoretical curiosities. They are not merely the expression of feeling, but also exert a determining influence both on the feeling and action of the one who judges and on those of others. They are not merely *motivated*, but are themselves in turn *motives*, practical forces of the greatest significance.

The misgiving becomes greater still when we extend our view beyond the single individual. The feelings and impulses of the individual are determined by the whole *nature, conditions of life and traditions of the race*. The individual receives some of his most far-reaching abilities and instincts as an inheritance from the race. He is then led, by developing and being brought up as a member of the family, the tribe and the state, into a certain spiritual atmosphere, in which habits of life, ideas, incitements and tasks present themselves to him, not as something that can be made the object of his deliberation and choice, but as something he involuntarily takes into himself. As he has sprung from the womb of the race, so he drinks in the traditions of the race with his mother's milk. His way of thinking, feeling and acting is an unconscious inheritance from earlier generations. Through instincts of race and traditions, through involuntary imitation and practice, the individual's ethics is founded for him before his conscious reflection can intervene. The will is involuntarily led into definite courses, and the involuntarily formed direction of the will determines the interests and ends of life, and these in turn the judgments of good and evil. The virtues come into being — as JACOBI says somewhere — before they get names and before they are made into demands: "The book of life must be written before the index to it can be drawn up; our theories of

morals are such indexes, drawn up afterwards.” And — Jacobi adds — they are as a rule drawn up by people who understand nothing of the book itself! In any case the book is more important than the index, and the index cannot replace the book. For in ethical judgments, the strong outbursts of feeling in which a valuation of human actions is expressed, we have not merely the disposition of the single individual expressed, but it [6] is *the result of the experiences of the race* that displays itself in them. The individual does not make his ethics himself, does not “hit upon” it, does not construct it absolutely from the beginning. And it is only so that it gets its proper strength. The ethics living in the race is a condition of the health and strength of human life. He who by his reflection and criticism would dissolve what nature has joined together has not only an enormous resistance to overcome, but must also know well what he is doing, lest he end in a quagmire and drag others down with him.

This actual ethics of the race, at work in life, has been called *positive morality*. It appears in *current judgments and maxims*, which are often clothed in the form of the proverb, and which may either be lasting expressions of the practical wisdom of a nation, a tribe or a religious community, or have a more short-lived existence as the “public opinion” of a century or an age. It appears also in the *personal exemplars* (founders of religions, heroes, lawgivers, etc.) to whom a single generation, or generation after generation, looks up as the highest expression of what is truly human. It appears, finally, in the way in which the human *relations and forms of life* (the family, civil society, the state, the church) are ordered. Positive legislation always contains a certain part of positive morality. Common to all forms of positive morality is that an action that conflicts with them becomes the object of a reaction on the part of society. A violation of the prevailing maxims, exemplars or forms of life brings with it an outburst called forth by offense or indignation, the judgment of public opinion, on which the agent’s future honor depends. Or it does not stop at this moral censure, but the agent must make amends and perhaps through pain or even death atone for what he has done and appease the indignation he has aroused. This assertion of positive morality through social influence is denoted by the expression *sanction*. It need not be felt by the individual as something merely external; by virtue of his original, involuntary growing into positive morality, the individual may feel its power in his inmost self as one with the power of his own conscience, — if one is to speak of conscience here at all; conscience does not [7] really exist here at all as a purely individual factor.

Positive morality is a bed into which the stream of human life has been led and which it has deepened more and more, and which the stream goes on following as long as

new channels or dams do not prevent it. But will it be possible to intervene here with conscious thought? And if it is possible, will it not bring with it a harmful weakening of the force with which the stream hurries on?

3. Against such well-founded and very significant objections I shall try to show that scientific ethics is so far from being either impossible, or harmful, or unnecessary, that it develops out of positive morality itself, acts back on it as a clarifying and liberating force, and solves tasks that could not otherwise be solved.

First of all it is clear that one cannot defend positive morality and maintain its significance as a condition of the health and strength of human life without having a standard by which one judges it. This standard one cannot, unless one is willing to move in a circle, fetch from positive morality itself. One must then try to make clear to oneself what principle one lays at the basis of one's valuation, — but then one has already entered on the road that leads to scientific ethics. As soon as one establishes that health and strength are better than sickness and faintness, one has already established a principle of valuation. The question will then naturally arise whether positive morality really satisfies the demands of this principle everywhere, — whether there are not other principles that must be laid at the basis of valuation, — and the discussion is then in full swing!

It is self-contradictory to come forward as defender of positive morality if one sees a danger in all reflection and criticism. Toward what is to act with the power of the unconscious, silence is best. A serious doubt can be met only with decisive counter-reasons, or by showing that there are questions that can be left unanswered without [8] life suffering from it. It belongs to the noblest needs of man to ask "why?", and the suppression of such questioning easily becomes a suppression of spiritual life as a whole. In questioning and doubt, too, the health and strength of life can show themselves.

Life leads by its own road to questioning. Only where the horizon is narrow and the tasks are limited is there full security. But with growing experience there begins the comparison between the various laws, the various ideals, the various institutions that one comes to know among various peoples at various times. Or the new experiences and situations set tasks that cannot be solved according to the inherited ethics. Or one seeks to put in order the great multitude of ethical judgments that one passes and hears others pass, so that the more significant can be distinguished from the less. Ethical judgments are, to be sure, from the beginning involuntary outbursts of feeling, and "there is no disputing about feelings"; *but one can dispute about the validity of the ideas to which the feelings are attached, and about the value of the actions to which the feelings lead.*

It is certainly a difficult point in spiritual development when reflection and criticism awaken in the single individual or in the people. Instinct and impulse lose their immediate strength and certainty, and the great question is whether a substitute can be won for this loss¹⁾. But where it is life itself that puts the questions into our mouths, they must either be answered, or it must be decided why they cannot be answered. And it must be well noted that certainty and strength are not absolute goods. The sleepwalker walks more surely than the waking man could; but we wake him or stop him nevertheless, to keep him from coming near the abyss. The greatest strength may display itself in a most pernicious direction. When one then seeks to diminish this strength, one diminishes its pernicious effects too. And one must then try to procure for the better insight that is won all the energy that formerly stood in the service of immediate instinct. All sound spiritual development consists, after all, in energy being transferred from narrower to larger ends. Nothing is produced from nothing.

Scientific ethics will not and cannot put itself in the place of positive morality. It [9] will only ground, develop and widen it. In scientific ethics we seek only to understand ourselves, to become clear about the principles by which we lead our life, and to bring these principles to greater clarity and mutual harmony. In human spiritual life there takes place a constant interaction between the conscious and the unconscious, as well as between knowledge, feeling and will among themselves. What is gained in one field can benefit all other spiritual fields.

4. Two tasks of scientific ethics must be distinguished. It is partly a historical, partly a philosophical science. *Historical or comparative ethics* seeks to present positive morality as it appears in a given people at a given time, to show what development it undergoes under different conditions, and to compare the different forms it may take among different peoples and at different times. It seeks to find the causes of these different stages of development and forms in definite physical, psychological and historical conditions. *Philosophical ethics* has as its task not the description and explanation of given ethical phenomena, but their *valuation*. By valuation is meant an inquiry into whether an action or an ordering of human relations of life agrees with the end that we presuppose for all human striving, and so also with the *fundamental value*, the value to which we trace back all other values. Scientific ethics may rightly be called a practical science, since it presupposes an end that is to be realized through human actions. Every ethical judgment presupposes such an end, for feeling is set in motion by the sight or the thought of an action only when this action either furthers or hinders something whose existence and

¹⁾Cf. my *Psykologi* VII B, 3.

progress lie close to our heart. An ethical judgment presupposes an interest of life that is either favored or injured by a human action or by an ordering of human relations.

- What has developed historically is not, as a matter of course, ethically justified.
- [10] We can understand how positive morality has developed into the form it has taken in our country and in our time, and yet we may condemn it to a greater or lesser extent. Historical ethics can teach us only what actually exists and how it has come to exist; but unless one assumes that the actual as such is one with the rational, there still remains a valuation of it to be made. Philosophical ethics is a valuation systematically carried through on a definite foundation given in human nature and according to the standard that answers to this foundation. Such an inquiry, carried through, may lead to the condemnation of certain actions and forms of life and to the approval of others. It may be that *inconsistencies are shown* within positive morality, and since the presupposition that all ethical judgments must agree with one another must necessarily lie at the basis, the task becomes to develop positive morality so that the contradiction disappears. It may further appear, from *the comparative consideration* of various forms of positive morality, that the one form has the advantage over the other; this presupposes a definite standard on which the comparison is grounded, and it may lead one to seek means of developing the type of positive morality recognized as standing lower in the direction of the one recognized as standing higher. Finally, it may often happen that the original motives of certain actions and institutions can no longer be acknowledged, without these actions and institutions themselves therefore losing their value and significance. Under the changed conditions, and by being seen from another side than before, they may bring with them effects that were formerly unknown. Traits of character such as knightly courage, chastity and self-control, which were developed under raw and barbarous conditions, may be taken into the service of quite other tasks than the original ones. Private property arose historically under the influence of the lust for power and the acquisitive impulse and has been recognized by the power of society in the interest of peace. But in the ethical discussion of its lasting significance and justification, quite other considerations come to be taken into account. It is here as when, in a town, the old ramparts that were originally built for defense are turned into promenades and
- [11] pleasure grounds. There takes place in such cases a *displacement* in the ethical field, whereby the old motives and values fall away and new motives and values take their place, while actions, habits and institutions remain the same. It becomes evident from this that the historical explanation of an ethical phenomenon is not, as a matter of course, decisive for its valuation, since the possibility of such a displacement always stands open.

Philosophical ethics respects nothing existing merely because it exists; but in seeking to lead beyond what exists, it seeks to show how what has developed historically can be applied and turned into new forms.

While historical and philosophical ethics, seen from this side, have a very different character, seen from another side it will prove difficult to keep them sharply apart. — The historical ethicist will not be able to free himself from certain ethical presuppositions, which may come to influence the light in which he sees the past. He must even have an eye for, and practice in, making a systematic valuation, if he is to grasp the inner coherence (or want of coherence) in the ethical views and customs of other times and peoples. And — as has already been suggested — as soon as he makes a valuing comparison between different forms of positive morality and calls some lower, others higher, he presupposes a definite standard (and a definite fundamental value) and has thus already entered the field of philosophical ethics. — The philosophical ethicist will of course always be a child of his time and his people, and the positive morality prevailing in these will in many ways come to influence his results. But this means only that the work of philosophical ethics must always be taken up anew. We must separate out and test whatever in the work of our predecessors is due only to passing conditions and influences. In Kant's ethics, for example, one notices clearly that he is a German, that he was brought up under pietist influence, and that as a mature man he lived in the age of rationalism. Some of the merits and some of the faults of his ethics are to be explained by these causes. But such a dependence on people and time¹⁾ does not prevent the great philosophical [12] ethicist from uttering thoughts that are valid for many generations. Philosophical ethics is made impossible by historical limitation only if it wishes to be a pure science of reason, an exposition of eternal truths. It is, and can never become anything other than, the systematic carrying through of a historically given standpoint, and it can construct ideals and norms only for certain definite conditions of life; it is in its way — like positive morality — a means in the struggle for existence: a means of maintaining a stage of life attained and of attaining a new stage of life that may deserve the name of a higher one. Its scientific character depends on the clarity with which its foundation and its standard are fixed, and on the consistency with which its principles are carried through in particulars. Its practical significance depends on the degree to which the thoughts and results so won can pass into the flesh and blood of larger or smaller circles of mankind, find points

¹⁾An interesting example of how the national direction of mind determines the work and results of individual thinkers is offered by the history of Italian philosophy, especially as regards ethics. Cf. Luigi Ferri: *National Character and Classicism in Italian Ethics*. (International Journal of Ethics 1895). — Cf., for ancient Greece: Leopold Schmidt: *The Unity of the Ethics of ancient Greece*. (ibid. 1894).

of attachment in strong feelings and habits, and become guiding in the ordering of the various relations of life. Experience shows that there may often be a long and intricate road from the general ethical thought to its practical realization. —

(1913). In recent times the French sociological school, whose most important representatives are *Durkheim* and *Levy Bruhl*, has with great energy stressed the significance of the historical study of positive morality at different times. They expect that on the basis of such a comparative ethics there will one day be developed a “moral art” that stands in the same relation to the “science of morals” (*la science des mœurs*) as the art of medicine stands to medical science. When science has settled how every obligation of conscience has come into being, has been strengthened and recognized, — what effects it has produced and what function it performs in social life, — then we shall also know to what degree it is possible and beneficial to change it. Then a moral art can be practiced. In the meantime one neither can nor should sit with folded hands, but must follow the best knowledge that our science makes possible at a given time.¹⁾ Besides, it is only in appearance that there is so great a conflict between the ethical theories of the philosophers. They are in reality different points of view on the fundamental moral fact (*le fait moral*): social life, which stands at once as authority over against the individuals and as the source of the highest goods to which they have access.²⁾

This significant direction of ethical inquiry, too, comes, partly against its will, to acknowledge the difference between historical and philosophical ethics and the interaction between them. It is not content to point out “morality” as a fact (*le fait moral*), but at once attributes value to this fact. And it suggests that every obligation is to be valued according to its effects and its significance for social life; but this at once presupposes a standard distinct from the facts themselves. And the ethical problem concerns precisely the possibility and the grounding of such a standard.

II.

THEOLOGICAL AND PHILOSOPHICAL ETHICS.

1. Theological ethics stands in definite opposition both to historical ethics and to philosophical ethics. — It builds on tradition, on truth as given, on the ideal as historically revealed. To that extent it does, to be sure, fall under historical ethics: just as positive jurisprudence sets out the system of the rules and commands laid down in a certain country’s juridical laws, so every theological ethics sets out the system of the ethical

¹⁾*Levy Bruhl: La Morale et la Science des Mœurs.* p. 150. 223.

²⁾*Durkheim in Bulletin de la Société Française de Philosophie.* 1906. p. 113—139.

judgments that follow from a certain ecclesiastical community's confession of faith. But theological ethics does not acknowledge the method of scientific historical research, since the revelation on which it builds is supposed to be due to a breaking through of supernatural powers that cannot be explained by the physical, psychological and social laws on which historical science relies. It demands a special position for its historical foundation and asserts that this must be regarded in an entirely different way from the rest of history. — It approaches philosophical ethics insofar as, like the latter, it undertakes a valuation of historically given actions and forms of life. But it does not undertake this valuation according to principles that can be shown to have their source in human nature. It takes its point of departure not in human nature but above it, in the supernatural revelation of an ideal. It builds on the absolute principle of authority.¹⁾

Authority means the standing to command, and such standing can make itself felt in very different ways. It can be grounded in physical power, so that it works through the fear it inspires. It can be grounded in superiority of insight and ability, and work by furnishing a model for others, which they seek in admiration to imitate. It can be grounded in the ability and the will to help and protect, so that it works not merely by calling forth fear and admiration but by awakening gratitude, trust and love. Human life cannot do without such authorities. The older generation is the educator and the model of the younger. Parents are the authorities of their children, teachers of their pupils; everywhere the one who has advanced further is an authority for the one who is not so far along the road. The relation of authority is an important element in positive morality.

It is always due, however, to a certain reflection, a beginning of thought, when the [15] principle of authority is expressly laid down and taken as unconditional. Men involuntarily follow what seems to them great and eminent, and need no special command to do so. From the instinct of imitation and from habit they follow even the insignificant and the indifferent, provided only that it works by the power of repetition and that there are precedents. Only in times when criticism has awakened, and when doubt replaces the secure resting in the half-unconscious, does one consciously set up the principle of authority in its absolute form as the ultimate foundation of all ethics. When one question calls forth another, so that it seems as if nothing stands fast, the need is awakened for an absolute fixed point that is not drawn into the whirl. Human feeling and thought seem an uncertain foundation for the ethical. The greatest question of human life: "what is good and what is evil?" seems to need the strongest foundation, and what foundation can be stronger than the will of an almighty being? When one can appeal to such a will,

¹⁾On the concept of authority cf. my work *Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik*. Copenhagen 1876. Chap. III.

all discussion must cease, and the clamorous doubts fall silent before the unconditional authority.

The good, then, becomes what agrees with God's will, and it is good only because it agrees with God's will (*bonum est, quia deus vult*). This was the doctrine that PLATO had already had occasion to combat (in the dialogue *Euthyphro*), but which was first properly formulated towards the close of the Middle Ages by DUNS SCOTUS, who even stated outright that if God had commanded murder, murder would be no sin. In so crude a form probably only few would acknowledge this doctrine, but every theological standpoint contains an approximation to it. The unconditional principle of authority is contained in the dogma of the infallibility of the Pope and in the narrow literalism of Protestant orthodoxy. Through the living word of the head of the Church, or through the written word of the books handed down by the Church, it is made known what is good or evil according to God's will, and those to whom the word is addressed have only to receive it and follow it in unconditional obedience.

[16] Let us try to place ourselves at this standpoint, in order to see whether its presuppositions do not bring with them inner contradictions and insuperable difficulties.

2. We ask first how one knows that something is God's will, and what guarantees one has of it. It is of no use that I know that *if* something is God's will it is good, when I do not know with unconditional certainty *what* is God's will in the particular case. This certainty must, by the nature of the matter, be the most important thing to me at this standpoint. The faith on which theological ethics builds therefore consistently becomes a faith in the Church, the bearer of religious revelation and tradition. The Church guarantees me that its head is the rightful successor of the Church's founder, or that the biblical books contain the true revelation. In the Catholic dogma of infallibility, therefore, theological ethics finds its consistent conclusion. — If, on the other hand, I wish to learn God's will immediately, I must hold to the testimony of the Spirit within myself; but how can I distinguish definitely between the divine voice and my own natural feelings and thoughts? What standard have I for drawing the boundary between the divine and the human? Here we lose the absolute firmness that was supposed to be precisely the advantage of the principle of authority. We slide over from the theological standpoint to the psychological.

"Yes," it is said, "we cling to the principle of authority precisely because we feel that we need it. It is our own powerlessness and doubt that cast us into the arms of the unconditional authority." — But by stressing this personal need one raises a psychological problem in place of the purely theological problem. Not authority itself but *my need* of

it then becomes the real foundation. I justify my submission to authority by my need; but can this need itself, then, be justified? Is it good to satisfy this need? How do I distinguish which of my many wishes and wants it is good to satisfy, and which are to be suppressed? If, to decide this, one appeals to authority, one goes round in a circle.

One comes to a similar circle in one's thinking when, as some theologians attempt, one wishes to combine the two propositions: "the good is good because God wills it," [17] and: "God wills it because it is good." — If the good is what agrees with God's will, what does it mean, then, that God wills it because it is good? It can evidently mean only that he wills it because it is his will. So by this we get no further. — If, on the other hand, God first recognizes something as good and then wills it, then there is a law and rule to which his will bows, and his will is therefore not in and for itself the cause of the good's being good. Even those who credit themselves with the most intimate acquaintance with the psychology of the Godhead would yet become somewhat uneasy at the dividedness thereby posited in the essence of the Godhead. Consistent theological thinkers have also seen that at the standpoint of the principle of authority there can be no question of good or evil as regards the Godhead itself. God can have neither conscience nor duty. Every transference of ethical ideas from men to God leads to contradictions, and the only way out is to stop at the appeal to the divine will and to bow to it in obedience. Otherwise one gives up the theological principle itself. As soon as one acknowledges that there are other sources of knowledge of the good than the certainty itself of what God's will is, one has really passed over from theological ethics to philosophical. The good is recognized — that becomes the main proposition; and that the good so recognized is God's will becomes an inference, — an inference of great practical importance, to be sure, since a supernatural sanction thereby becomes possible, but an inference grounded on entirely different presuppositions from the main proposition, and which could therefore very well fall away without the main proposition falling away. —

The unconditional authority utters a multitude of commands and prohibitions. As soon as reflection awakens, we naturally try to bring connection and agreement among the particular pronouncements of the authority. But this can be done only by our applying the fundamental law of our reason to them and assuming that one pronouncement cannot conflict with another. But if we have the right to apply this law of reason, why should other laws of our natural knowledge be excluded? And have we not, by that very [18] application, already broken with the unconditional principle of authority?

3. It is not, however, merely these inner contradictions that keep philosophical ethics from taking theological presuppositions as its basis.

What called philosophical ethics forth in the first place, and ever anew awakens interest in it, is the conviction that the ultimate ground of the ethical must lie in human nature itself. For all that man is to be able to acknowledge as true and good, as beautiful and great, the standard must in the end lie in himself. The principles of all understanding and all valuation, of all theoretical and practical activity, must be found within him. However high the ideals stand above him, and however mightily the majesty of the law makes itself known to his conscience, they are still ideal and law *for him* only through his free acknowledgment, through the assent he gives them by virtue of his nature. Socrates therefore became the founder of ethics through his command: Know thyself! He thereby set up the *principle of personality*, or the principle of subjectivity, at once the principle of free inquiry and of free conscience. Blind obedience as an abiding condition conflicts with this principle; one thereby divests oneself of one's free personality and makes oneself an impersonal machine.

Next, another motive also cooperates in the effort to develop a philosophical ethics, namely the wish to make the ethical as *independent* as possible of disputable presuppositions. Precisely because judgments of good and evil intervene so powerfully in human life and condition the sharpest oppositions within its domain, it is of great importance that no other disputed questions be mixed up with the ethical ones. Ethical questions must therefore as far as possible be made independent of religious and metaphysical problems. If ethics had to wait until agreement arose on dogmatic questions, it would have to wait a long time. It is worth the trouble, then, to try whether agreement in the ethical domain might not be greater than in the religious and metaphysical domain. And since it is precisely the *ethical* significance of the religious and metaphysical problems [19] that is to give them their great interest, it lies in the nature of the matter that one must have a foundation and a standard for the ethical which — to a certain degree at least — must be independent of religious and metaphysical assumptions¹⁾. For in attributing an ethical significance to such assumptions one *values* them, and the question must then be asked on what foundation one takes one's stand in this valuation, and what standard

¹⁾A theological critic (in the journal *Vidar* 1888) has found "a weakness" in my standpoint, expressed in the phrases: "as independent *as possible* of disputable presuppositions" and "to a *certain degree* at least," which occur in this passage. I chose these expressions deliberately, being convinced that here there can be question only of an endeavor to reduce the disputable presuppositions to the least possible, an endeavor that no single person can carry through completely. Every thinker has his limitation and must know that he unconsciously operates with presuppositions that can perhaps only later be brought out and tested. I have thus used those phrases out of scientific caution. They do not shake the principle: that the ethical is to be investigated by itself alone and not *derived from* religious or metaphysical assumptions. This does not, of course, exclude that the ethical thinker may set up ideas that one might perhaps call religious or metaphysical (cf. IV, 5 and XXXI, 3), provided only that he does not make use of them in the *grounding* of the ethical.

one applies.

The general scientific maxim that principles must not be multiplied without necessity thus has a practical significance here as well. In seeking to place itself outside the conflict between the various religious confessions and between the various metaphysical theories (spiritualism, materialism, etc.), philosophical ethics will not only attain a surer foundation for the ethical, but will also work for the good of tolerance, freedom of religion and freedom of teaching. It will counteract the hateful manner of discussion that consists in deriving immoral consequences from an opponent's views.

The ethical problem therefore holds a very self-standing and independent position within philosophy in relation to the other main philosophical problems. There is of course a connection between the theory of knowledge, which investigates the foundation, presuppositions and limits of our knowledge, metaphysics, which seeks to form a world-view, a general theory of the nature of existence, and ethics¹⁾. But the connection is [20] not so direct and immediate as has often been assumed. And it will in any case be of importance to keep the various problems apart from one another as much as possible; this does not exclude that they may throw light on one another in many ways.

Philosophical ethics, which is to be a scientific doctrine of ethical valuation, must take its stand on the same foundation as all other science. It does not seek to shake the principles, results and hypotheses that other sciences have arrived at. It demands no special position. If it were to set up presuppositions that conflicted with those on which other sciences build, it would come into the domain of the disputable. It will go most surely when it builds on the common presuppositions. It is, however, still a frequent assumption that ethics, at least at one point, namely in the question of the application of the law of causality to the life of the will, should be compelled to set up presuppositions that not merely deviate from, but directly conflict with, the general scientific presuppositions. This question will be treated specially later on.

4. When theological ethics has been spoken of in the foregoing, it must be well noted that *Christian* ethics is not a theological ethics in all its forms and at all its stages of development. Christianity did not begin with a theological system, any more than it began with an ecclesiastical organization. Here, as everywhere where development takes place, a more indeterminate form of life precedes system and organization. The ethics proclaimed in the first three Gospels is in great part a doctrine of love of mankind. It is supported by theological ideas, and reference is made to reward and punishment in a world beyond. But the God to whose requiring power reference is made appears

¹⁾On the inner connection between the great problems cf. *Den menneskelige Tanke, dens Former og Opgaver* (1910). p. 246–254.

nevertheless chiefly as the ideal of perfection, which here, according to the context [21] (Matth. V. 43–48),²⁾ means: the ideal of love of mankind. Jesus founds the messianic kingdom, to which access stands open for those who are pure in heart, who hunger and thirst after righteousness, who are peaceable and love others as themselves. The spirit and the conditions of the new kingdom were entirely different from those of the proud world-empires that history had hitherto known, and from those which the Jewish people had imagined in its national fantasies.

What is significant in the oldest Christian ethics is the widening and inward deepening of love of mankind that it inaugurates. Only through the dogmatic development of Christianity, founded chiefly by Paul, did theological doctrines become of decisive importance for Christian ethics. Christianity then received two principles, faith and love, which it has not succeeded in bringing into complete harmony with one another. Differences of faith became barriers to love of mankind. The most decisive standard of a human being's worth was now not whether he had an inward and loving mind, was pure in heart and sought the truth, but whether he had the right faith. Only where differences of faith are treated as Christianity itself had treated national differences and other external differences, only there has the great ethical idea that was uttered in the oldest Christianity attained its full development¹⁾.

Yet for a right understanding of the ethics of primitive Christianity it must be well noted that its deepest motive was nevertheless not love of mankind itself, but the living, enthusiastic assurance that the kingdom of heaven was at hand and that the end of all earthly things was drawing near. Before this great hope all human ends and tasks lost their weight. There could be no question of coherent ethical striving, and even the idea of love of mankind was not allowed to unfold its consequences. Only when the Church pushed that expectation into the background did Christianity become a cultural [22] power. And the idea of love of mankind (which, incidentally, was not first conceived by primitive Christianity) has shown that it has vitality beyond the limits both of that ecstatic expectation and of the ecclesiastical dogmas¹⁾.

III.

THE PRINCIPLES AND METHOD OF ETHICS.

²⁾In the parallel passage, Luke VI. 36, mercy stands in place of perfection.

¹⁾Cf. *Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik*. p. 70 f. — In that work, in my discussion of this point, I did not take sufficient account of the oldest Christianity, which lies before the more definite theological shaping.

¹⁾Cf. my essay: *Hedenske Sandhedssøgere* (in "Mindre Arbejder" I) and the concluding section of my book *Søren Kierkegaard som Filosof* (1892).

1. Ethical judgments, judgments of good and evil, arise in the first instance without grounds. Just as before a work of art or before nature we may relieve our heart by exclaiming: "That is beautiful!", so before a human action we may relieve our heart by exclaiming: "That is good!" We are guided by an immediate feeling that is awakened by the sight or the memory of the action. Which actions we call good (or evil) will for the individual depend in the first instance on what "positive morality" (cf. I, 2) he has grown into. An ethical problem first arises when this positive morality does not speak clearly, or when it proves to contain self-contradictions. Then *principles* are needed, *guiding thoughts*, that can determine the choice between the possibilities at hand.

One might doubt the possibility of setting up *grounded* ethical judgments, and so the possibility of a *philosophical* ethics. Ethical judgments, after all, contain a demand; they state *what ought to be*, not merely *what is*. Even when they pronounce praise or blame of an action actually performed, they really mean a demand that such actions shall be performed or left undone in the future. But does not all science aim at explaining, at finding the causes of what is? Can there be a science of that which is not, but ought to be? Philosophical ethics goes a step further still: it wishes to be a doctrine of *what ethical judgments we ought to pass!* How is such a science possible? Add to this that judgments of good and evil spring from feeling, — but "there is no disputing about feelings." And experience shows, too, that discussions of ethical questions frequently end with each appealing to his own feeling. [23]

To throw light on this problem it must first be remarked that ethical judgments aim at stating the means and ways of attaining *something that has value for us*, and which we therefore more or less consciously make our *end*. Ethical valuation regards the particular action, the particular quality or the particular social institution in relation to an end. The more involuntarily the judging and the valuing take place, the less consciousness we have of the end; we are seized immediately and rest wholly in the thought of the object that is valued. Valuation can take place quite instinctively. But when in cases of doubt the valuation is to be grounded on definite principles, it must first be settled to what end we relate the action. The judgment on the action will depend on whether, on closer examination, it proves to further or to hinder the end presupposed. Every action will bring something about; otherwise it would be impossible and absurd. This remark is not unnecessary, for great ethical thinkers, especially IMMANUEL KANT, have held that it was a degradation of the will to lay particular weight on the effect and to grant the end a determining influence on the valuation. Against this holds SCHLEIERMACHER's apt

remark¹⁾: “Why then do I act, if I wish to bring nothing about?”

We already have firm ground under our feet once it is established that every action must have an end. For then it is possible to examine whether the action really serves this end or not. The relation between the road and the goal, between the means and the end, can be scientifically established. If the end stands fast, certain definite means must
[24] be employed. The relation between means and end is, after all, the same as that between cause and effect: what we call a means is the cause that brings about the attainment of the end. Here, then, we see the possibility of a science of what ought to be: the word ought expresses *the demand for means to a given end*. In every need or impulse lies such a demand, and what we call conscience is a deep inner need to maintain or to produce something of value in the world. — Through the necessary relation between end and means a scientific ethics becomes possible. But the end is presupposed as given — and, as will appear, the problem arises again when it is asked *which* end we presuppose as the highest, — which value is for us the fundamental value.

We arrive at the same result to which the consideration of the action in its relation to the end has led us, by a closer consideration also of the proposition that judgments of good and evil are utterances of feeling. The utterance of feeling here presupposes that the perception or the idea of an action has moved us inwardly, has furthered or hindered an involuntary striving, a conscious or unconscious interest in us. Feelings of pleasure and pain are connected — as *the biology of the life of feeling* shows — with the furthering or hindering of our life, or at any rate of a part of our life. This determines what acquires value for us and can therefore be made an end. All value depends on the conditions of life and on the stage of life. *The human life of feeling is therefore intelligible only in connection with the conditions of human life*. And only in its simplest forms and in the most violent affects is feeling wholly blind. Its definite, fully developed form it acquires only by being bound up with ideas. Joy presupposes the idea of an object that arouses pleasure, sorrow the idea of the loss of one. Hope and fear presuppose ideas of the possibility of certain events that arouse pleasure or pain.

Here too, then, we get firmer ground under our feet. “There is no disputing about feelings”; but one can dispute about the ideas to which the feelings are attached, since
[25] one can examine the relation of these ideas to experience. And one can examine the very states that prove valuable, and seek to find under what conditions they occur; from this one will then be able to draw conclusions about the way in which such valuable states can be brought about in the future.

¹⁾*Ueber den Begriff des höchsten Gutes*. Werke zur Philosophie. 2 Band. p. 452.

Not only in the relation between means and end, then, which plays a part in all human actions, but also in the relation between experience and the ideas by which the feelings that find vent in valuation are determined, we see *a possibility of grounding ethical judgments, and so of setting up a philosophical ethics*. And the two relations cannot be separated; for an end always presupposes a feeling. Only what sets our feeling in motion can we make an end.

Ethical judgments concern human actions and human ordinances of life (institutions), the latter, however, only insofar as they have proceeded from human actions and can in turn be altered by them. For the most part, now, ethics has started from the action that is to be valued, and has not examined valuation itself. It will appear that one must begin by discussing the condition of valuation itself.

2. The action has its origin within the individual, in its instincts and impulses, its thoughts and feelings. But after having developed there, it passes over as an effect into the external world. Here, then, the question arises to which part of this whole course ethical valuation is chiefly to keep.

A perfect valuation would require that the whole course of the action be taken in. The ethical characterization of an action as good or evil would then presuppose that one could trace it all the way from its first germs in the individual's inner life and through all its branching and distant effects in the surrounding world. Ethicists have not laid equal weight on all parts of the action's whole history. Some have taken their point of departure from the action's own origin, that is, from the motives, the disposition, that give birth to it. The external effects of the action, they hold, cannot be surveyed and are not wholly under the dominion of the will; it is the inner action in which the will shows itself, and therefore it alone can become the object of ethical valuation. Others, on the [26] contrary, start from the action's consequences and effects in the external world. It is these alone, they hold, that give the action practical significance. Valuation must keep to them first and foremost, especially since experience shows that actions springing from the same motives can have very different effects, and actions springing from different motives can have the same effect. Only secondarily does valuation extend to the motives and the disposition, insofar as it can be shown that certain definite motives generally lead to a certain definite manner of acting. Here, then, a distinction is made between the valuation of the actions and the valuation of the acting person; the former is primary, the latter secondary.

This opposition has played a great part in the history of ethics. One might describe it as an opposition between *subjective ethics* and *objective ethics*. In the more recent history

of ethics subjective ethics is represented by Kant, objective ethics by BENTHAM, and the debate in the field of philosophical ethics lies essentially between the tendencies that proceed from these two thinkers. A decision of the dispute must depend on a closer determination of the relation between subjective and objective ethics. Such a closer determination I seek to give in this chapter. I shall rely especially on the consideration that, even if one agrees with Bentham that an objective valuation of actions is possible only if one takes one's point of departure from their effects and consequences, *valuation* is nevertheless always a *subjective activity*, and every principle of valuation must presuppose certain subjective conditions. The dispute between the schools of Kant and of Bentham has turned all too exclusively on the relation between the motives of the action and its effects. Perhaps the problem will present itself more clearly and become easier to solve if one goes further back and asks about the motives of valuation itself, or about *the psychological presuppositions on which the very circumstance rests that a general and objective valuation of human actions is striven for*. Just as theoretical knowledge leads back by analysis to certain principles, which it is the business of the theory of knowledge [27] to point out, and which stand in close connection with the nature of the human faculty of knowledge, so too practical valuation must prove to build on principles that have their ground in the human mind, even if the question here should be somewhat more intricate than in the theoretical field. Both the theory of knowledge and ethics lead us back to subjectivity as the ultimate foundation. The task is precisely to show how, *in spite of the unavoidable subjective element in the foundation, an objective knowledge and an objective valuation* can be reached. Here, then, is a parallel between the problem of knowledge and the ethical problem to which attention has not always been paid.

Just as *the foundation (the motive of valuation)* is the subjective principle of ethics, so the standard by which actions are valued from this foundation is the objective principle of ethics and determines the content of ethics (cf. I, 1). For valuation presupposes two things: a motive that drives one to exercise the valuing activity of mind, and a criterion according to which the valuation is carried out¹⁾.

To show more fully the significance of the point of view brought forward here, I shall try to give an account of how both the subjective and the objective principle of ethics (the foundation and the content) spring from the nature and the manner of

¹⁾In my work *Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik* (1876) I did not yet sufficiently distinguish between the concepts *foundation* and *motive*, or more clearly: between *motive of valuation* and *motive of action*, whereas the separation between foundation and content is already made in the work named. — In my essay *Filosofiske Problemer* (University programme, Nov. 1902) I introduced the concept of *fundamental value* as the presupposition of the motive of valuation. Every motive presupposes experience of a value, and the motive of valuation presupposes experience of a value that for us conditions all other values.

development of ethical valuation. The more precise relation between them will thereby gain in clarity. — But since the valuation of actions and conditions of life not only takes place among different individuals and peoples on the basis of different motives and according to different standards, but is also conditioned in each single individual by composite motives, it will be necessary for us to think of the conditions as simpler than they are in reality. No human being pursues just one single end; life is varied and manifold within us as outside us, and the various ends contend for sole dominion within the consciousness of the single individual as well as within society. The single moments as well as the single interests demand their right; the individual feels itself a little world and yet a member of a larger world, or of several worlds, each of which demands its right. Therefore human conscience, the feeling that determines valuation, is as a rule a very composite product. It will then be expedient to examine particular elements of this composite whole each by itself. The following account proceeds from the simplest to the most comprehensive valuations; it is not a historical account, but orders the standpoints according to the range of the ends that become determinative for valuation. [28]

3. It is a fact that men value their own and others' actions and call them good or evil according to the outcome of this valuation. How, now, is such a valuation possible?

We think first of the simplest case, namely where it is the acting subject that judges its own action, without having any consciousness of other beings to whom regard might have to be paid. The acting and valuing subject is thus thought of as a little world by itself. We make an abstraction in order to get as simple an example as possible.

The first presupposition for an action's being valued is that it is remembered; it must not, then, have vanished from consciousness once it has passed over from resolve into reality. The image of the action must be capable of being called up again as an object of contemplation. But this is not sufficient. Such an image in memory might in and for itself stand as something wholly indifferent that did not set the mind in motion. Only if the action has in one way or another, at one stage or another of its development, intervened in the individual's whole state and thereby aroused either pleasure or pain, will the image of the action be able to arouse pleasure or pain.

Here there appears in its very simplest form the important truth, already touched upon, that *all valuation of actions presupposes a subject with the capacity to feel pleasure or pain*. Valuation presupposes that a demand is made on the actions, which they can satisfy in greater or less degree. But such a demand stands wholly *unmotivated* if the action is unable to arouse pleasure or pain. This, as already remarked, is only another expression for the fact that valuation presupposes an end by which the action can be [29]

measured. Only that can become an end which has value for us, and which does not fall to our lot immediately but can be attained only through work. Immediate value makes itself known through a feeling of pleasure, while a feeling of pain will arise when the action hinders the realization of an immediate value.

In the simple case we imagined, the feeling that conditions the end, and which is thus to be satisfied by the action, can only be the individual's own. The individual will then stamp the action as good or evil according to the way in which it has intervened in its life. What character and significance the valuation more precisely acquires will depend on whether the feelings of pleasure and pain are determined only by, and answer to, the momentary states each by itself, or whether they are determined by regard to the individual's life as a whole and to the conditions under which it develops.

4. The lower the life of consciousness, the more isolated and self-standing are the single moments in relation to one another, and the smaller the part played by memory and by the thought of the self as a whole that comprises the single moments of life with all their content. It is then only a half-unconscious instinct that keeps the individual from being wholly absorbed in the single moment. The impulse of self-preservation leads the individual, in the single present moment, to take regard also of the future and to make use of the experiences of the past. But the more the individual is absorbed in the single moments, the less possibility there is of a valuation, since no comparison and interaction between the different states can take place. The action itself is perhaps forgotten at the [30] moment when its effect makes itself felt in consciousness. Each moment is filled in its own way, with its own state of feeling, which has no influence on the other moments. The single moment stands as an absolute egoist over against the other moments, and will not give up its claim to satisfaction for their benefit.

Here there appears the possibility of a standpoint at which all valuation falls away, because, though feelings of pleasure and pain stir, they answer merely to the state of the moment, not to life as a whole. No end is set up; even the instincts with their unconscious ends are pushed back; and when every regard to an end falls away, valuation becomes impossible. It is a childlike standpoint; but it is possible to attempt to make it the definitive standpoint. In the history of ethics this has been attempted by Aristippus of Cyrene¹⁾. It is the principle of *the sovereignty of the moment* that he maintains. This is the most radical ethical standpoint that can be conceived. It has the fewest possible presuppositions, so few that all valuation falls away. For the good, for Aristippus, was the purely momentary feeling of pleasure. Why — so the thought runs — should one

¹⁾On the relation between Aristippus's standpoint and Søren Kierkegaard's "aesthetic stage" see my book *S. Kierkegaard som Filosof*, p. 84. Note.

moment be sacrificed or subordinated to another? The one has in and for itself just as much right to be as the other. — At this standpoint — and only at this — the good coincides wholly with the feeling of pleasure, evil with the feeling of pain. — It follows of itself that such a standpoint cannot be a wholly primitive and naive standpoint. It will be carefree and thoughtless, as the child is, — but the very express willing of it shows that it is only an imitation of the childlike standpoint. A certain art and self-control are needed to check the involuntary craving beyond the present moment. The instincts themselves already establish a connection between the single moments that the carrying through of the standpoint of the moment on principle cannot bear. Herein lies precisely a great difficulty for the practical maintenance of this standpoint. But it is of great significance [31] for us to see that its justification has been maintained in theory. By the nature of the case this could happen only within an advanced culture. The simplest standpoints are by no means always those that appear earliest in history. But there is a natural tendency to seek out limiting cases, to see how our concepts are formed when we take up the extreme points of life; and the attempts at an ethics of the moment that exist are very instructive. Perhaps still more perfect expositions of this standpoint could be given than exist historically.

Such a standpoint does not lack justification. It might be objected that it abolishes all ethics, since it excludes valuation, and since all ethical endeavor presupposes that a more limited regard is subordinated to a more comprehensive one. Of such a subordination there can be no question here, since life is thought of as consisting of absolutely sovereign moments! — But to this it must be answered that ethics must itself prove its justification for setting up the demand that a satisfaction be given up in one moment for the benefit of other moments. The possibility presents itself that every moment might be filled by an immediate value of one and the same degree, or that there might at any rate be a harmony between the values that fill the single moments. The burden of proof lies on him who demands sacrifice and resignation. This can be denied only by an absolutely ascetic view, i.e. a view for which asceticism is an end, not merely a means. Every moment has a natural right to be, and has as well, if one may so put it, its instinct of self-preservation, since the need for full satisfaction in the moment yields to other promptings only under a certain resistance. Even at a purely instinctive stage of life this resistance is felt.

5. If the principle of the sovereignty of the moment could be carried through in practice, no reasoning could overthrow it. But there is hardly any conscious individual in whom there do not stir instincts *and impulses* that lead beyond the moment. And in human individuals *memory and expectation* will constantly assert themselves and

become points of attachment for feelings of pleasure and pain that are determined by
 [32] the individual's lasting or constantly recurring conditions. In every reflection on himself and his conduct the individual will rise above the single moments in their diversity and isolation, and his feeling will (in the moments of reflection at least) answer to the way in which *the whole of life*, and not the single moment, stands before consciousness. A *real* self first forms when there is a circle of feelings and ideas that make up a firm core in consciousness, even if they do not assert themselves at every moment. This firm core is made up above all of the values the individual knows, the ends it sets itself. These values and ends govern its whole life, make up the interest that gathers life into a whole and lets it stand as more than a series of isolated moments. Every strong feeling has a tendency to spread and to govern the whole life of consciousness, to color all that makes up the content of consciousness. Through this expansion of feeling, not only can a mood awakened at a moment extend its effects over several moments, but a real self can also form, a ruling fundamental mood that marks the level of the individual life of feeling as against the momentary fluctuations.

Now where the state of feeling of the single moment, regarded as the effect of the individual's own action, collides in consciousness with the state of feeling determined by the idea of the whole of life, there will arise a new feeling, determined by the relation between them, a relation that may be either harmonious or disharmonious. In this feeling of the relation between the momentary state and the state determined by regard to the whole of life consists *valuation*. It expresses the relation between two values. The capacity for such valuation is conscience, as it might be thought to express itself in a wholly isolated individual. In the widest sense conscience is a *feeling of relation*, and presupposes only that there asserts itself in consciousness a relation between something central and something peripheral, something more and something less comprehensive. The single moment, and the single action that has given it its character, are valued — at the standpoint here presupposed — according to the way in which they can be fitted in as
 [33] members of the whole of the individual life. Here there is at work not only the tendency of the real self and the ruling ends to determine everything in consciousness, but also a natural need, deeply grounded in the general nature of consciousness, for unity and coherence in the states of the soul. We wish our life to be a whole, not only because only so can our highest interest in life prevail, but also because unity and coherence are goods in and for themselves. It is *the formal side of personality* that expresses itself in the need to will one thing, so that everything else we desire besides this one thing is only a means to it. It is a spiritual impulse of self-preservation that can never be wholly

lacking, and rarely as one finds full consistency in reality, it is just as impossible that an endeavor to be consistent can ever be wholly lacking¹⁾.

Here the task presents itself to the individual of bringing about harmony between the single parts of its life. It is a task that is hardly solved involuntarily, without any conscious striving, in any human being. Here, therefore, the valuation of earlier actions according to the way they have contributed to the solution of this task also acquires significance for the individual. Valuation is thus not only *made possible* by the central feeling that answers to the whole of life, but is also *motivated* by it. A fine and developed sense for what serves the individual life, whose single members the moments are, is a condition of its existence and development. It is a kind of higher instinct of self-preservation and need not confine itself merely to what the existence of physical life requires, but can comprise ideal needs no less than physical ones. — In the ethics of PLATO and ARISTOTLE this harmonious individualism has found its most characteristic expression. Ethical virtue is regarded by them as a spiritual health and harmony. ARISTOTLE's definition of virtue (as the mean determined by the nature of each single individual) is of particular interest in this respect. Yet the whole ethics of the thinkers named is not exhausted by this individualistic doctrine.

To designate this standpoint I use the word "individualism" and not "egoism," since by [34] the latter word one should preferably think of a conscious setting aside and subordination of others' welfare to one's own. The individualist need not be an egoist, but he can become one.

6. At such an individualistic standpoint the task will be not only to determine how *much* energy must be spent in the single moments, but also to employ the energy at one's disposal in as *varied and diverse* a way as is compatible with the interest of the whole of life. By a psychological law of nature the life and freshness of the feelings are conditioned by the different states standing in a certain relation of contrast to one another, while uniformity and repetition have a damping or dulling effect. — Besides, the natural course of life will also bring with it that the individual is gradually no longer absorbed merely in physical self-preservation, but acquires needs of a more ideal and more composite character. The individual's life will attain the greater fullness, the more different directions it can spread into, the richer and more manifold a content it can comprise, without its unity and collected strength being thereby weakened.

Since the individual is here thought of as having set itself ends that point beyond the moment and beyond the satisfaction of a single side of its nature, there can be question

¹⁾With regard to the psychological ideas and laws used here cf. my *Psychologi* V B, 5; VI E, 1 and F, 4.

of a demand, an “ought,” a law, and the single moments and the single actions are valued according to how far they serve the end set up. It might, for example, be intellectual or aesthetic enjoyment and development that is set as the end, and with that the demand will be given that is to be made on the single moments and actions.

The *ethical law* at the standpoint of individualism is found by formulating what the harmonious relation between the interest of the whole of life and the need of the single moments requires. It will consist of two main commands, a negative and a positive: 1) the single moment must not have greater independence than answers to its significance within the whole of life; 2) but on the other hand one is to live in the single moment as [35] richly and fully as is compatible with the preservation of the whole of life and with the attainment of the end that stands as the highest.

Good, then, here becomes the action that preserves the whole of life and gives the content of life fullness and life; evil becomes the one that has a more or less marked tendency to burst or to narrow the whole of life and its content. Thus the single moment and the single impulse are evil in their rebellious isolation from the rest of life; and evil will lie all the deeper and become the object of all the stronger rejection in the valuing feeling, the more it is willed, i.e. has come about as the fruit of deliberation and choice, not merely of momentary prompting. The strength with which valuation asserts itself will depend on the strength with which the interests of the whole of life assert themselves in the individual’s central feelings.

7. What held of the sovereignty of the moment holds of individualism, or the principle of the *sovereignty* of the individual: it cannot be overthrown by reasoning. An absolute individualist or egoist would be absolutely unassailable. When the assertion of his own life, its existence, its fullness, is the only end he acknowledges, there is no *logical* transition from this standpoint to another. With sufficient consistency and self-control, and with sufficient power over circumstances, an individual will then be able to carry through the maxim: Thou shalt act so that thou thyself always standest as the only end, as the absolute center of the world. — If a change is to take place, the feeling that determines the fundamental value, and with it the valuation, must be altered by being attached to a more comprehensive circle of ideas than the one that concerns only the individual’s own life. Until that has happened it is of no use either to appeal to conscience; for this is, as we have seen, a feeling of relation, the expression of the relation between the central and the peripheral in the individual’s life of feeling, and is thus itself determined by what the central is.

Philosophical ethics has often, especially in earlier times, believed that it must lay

claim to being a pure science of reason that appealed to no presuppositions other than those lying in the nature of human reason. But this conflicts with the character of ethics [36] as a practical science. Action can be valued only according to ends, and the fixing of an end presupposes *feeling of pleasure and pain* in the subject that fixes it. Apart from a consciousness with the capacity to feel pleasure or pain, therefore, ethical valuation has no meaning. But on the other hand the mere capacity to feel pleasure and pain as yet implies nothing about *how comprehensive the circle of ideas is to which the feeling of pleasure and pain is attached*.

From the standpoint of the moment to the individualistic standpoint the transition took place through the forming in consciousness of feelings that were determined by the interests of the whole of life, and which could therefore become strong links between the changing moments. Supported by them the individual feels its unity in spite of the constant change. If there is a wider standpoint than that of individualism, there must be feelings that, by stirring in the single individual, can bind him to a more comprehensive whole in a way similar to that in which the single moments and promptings in him are bound to the whole of the individual life. There must be a power that binds the single individuals to one another and abolishes the isolation between them.

8. Only approximately can individualism be carried through in practice. The sovereignty of the individual, the conception of the individual as a closed and wholly independent whole, proves to rest on a violent and artificial abstraction. The individual comes into being out of the race and lives its whole life as a part of the life of the race, with an organization in which it inherits the consequences of earlier generations' doing and suffering, under conditions of life and in a spiritual atmosphere that the development of the race has brought about. And just as the instinct of self-preservation abolishes the isolation of the single moments of life and thereby becomes the foundation of feelings determined by the interests of the whole of life, so in *the sympathetic instincts* there stir forces that abolish the isolation of the single individuals and assert the conditions of life of the race within them. In the most primitive form the sympathetic instincts appear in the founding of the family relation. However much the forms and institutions of the family relation vary among different peoples and at different times, and however loose and arbitrary in particular the relation between the two sexes often proves to be, there is [37] yet one relation that by the nature of the case cannot be abolished or essentially altered, namely the relation between mother and child. In this relation sympathetic feeling grows immediately out of natural instinct. It forms the firm core by which the higher forms of family life become possible. Here the ground is laid for a community of life within

which the feelings of sympathy can be cultivated and attain such strength that they can gradually comprise larger circles. Mother-love nevertheless continues always to stand as the model and standard of all sympathy, both as regards strength and purity. It is a reminder that the family relation is the constant source of the sympathetic feelings, when the general love of mankind finds its most striking expression in the proposition that all men are brothers.

This is not the place to enter upon a closer psychological inquiry into the nature of the sympathetic feelings and into their different character according to the elements of which they consist and the range in which they express themselves (cf. on this my [38] *Psykologi* VI C)¹). Where sympathy has attained its full purity, it is a feeling of pleasure or pain determined merely by other beings' feeling pleasure or pain. As regards its range, the most significant point in the history of its development was when it widened from merely comprising family, nation and race to holding for the whole of mankind. Greek philosophy already (the Peripatetic and the Stoic schools) led to the idea of a general love of mankind, grounded on all men's natural belonging together in one great community¹). But this idea first acquired greater historical significance by becoming, as

¹)As may be seen not only from the text here but also from my *Psykologi* (VI C), I use the word *sympathy* in the sense of a fellow-feeling in which one immediately makes others' pleasure or pain one's own, or, as one may also put it, puts oneself in others' place and feels life in the way they must feel it. The word is used in this sense not only in the older Danish psychology (*Treschow: Om den menneskelige Natur*. Copenhagen 1812. p. 355. F. C. *Sibbern: Psykologisk Pathologie*. Copenhagen 1828. p. 27), but also in later works on the psychology of feeling (*Domrich: Die psychischen Zustände*. Jena 1849. p. 218. *Bain: Emotions and Will*. 3. ed. London 1875. p. 111) and in ethical works (Hume, A. *Smith*, and in our day *Wundt: Ethik*¹ I. p. 208). — Apart from this sense the word sympathy is used in three other senses. — It can denote a passive, reflex-like mirroring of others' states. The sight of others' enjoyment or suffering makes us ourselves involuntarily attuned in a similar way, so that we may even, for example, feel pain in our own leg when we see another's leg maimed. Suffering here as a rule works more strongly than enjoyment. — It can next denote a capacity for imagining others' feelings, whether we share them or not. Here *tact and inference* play a larger part than an immediate feeling of unity. The one with whom we sympathize in this way still continues to stand as an object. — Finally it can mean a feeling of *satisfaction in finding again* in others feelings of pleasure or pain that we ourselves would have in similar cases. It is a strengthening, a self-confirmation, that we thereby experience. — It is idle to dispute about which of all these senses is the "right" one. — Sympathy in the three last senses of the word can come into opposition to sympathy in the first sense of the word. But the different kinds of sympathy are related, and in particular the three last kinds (the reflex, the intellectual and the interested sympathy) can pave the way for the first through psychical transitions and displacements.

¹)Cicero: *De finibus* V, 65 cf. *De officiis* I, 16–17; III, 6. — Cf. my essay: *Hedenske Sandhedssøgere* (Mindre Arbejder I. p. 159 f.; 167–174). — Several theological critics have complained that it is not shown whence the sympathetic feelings arise. From my *Psykologi* they could have seen that I assume a physiological point of departure and a psychological-sociological course of development for these feelings. As regards degree, kind and range they are subject to definite conditions, which I have indicated briefly. It is remarkable how frequent is the opinion that self-love is the only natural feeling. This opinion is found especially at two opposite standpoints: on the one side among skeptics and blasé men of the world, who appeal here to their supposed experiences, and on the other side among orthodox theologians, according to whom all true love comes from a supernatural source. Indeed, even an enlightened and critical theologian such as *Adolf Harnack* denies that love of mankind can be a "product of nature," and holds that only self-love is

a chief command of Christianity, one of the guiding thoughts of a great world religion.

9. Ethically regarded, the great significance of this is that the horizon has been widened, so that the feeling of pleasure and pain is now determined not merely by the individual's own fate, but by *the conditions of life of a community of which the individual is only a single member*. When such feelings come to prevail, actions will be valued according to the relation in which the states they produce stand to the interests of this community, the larger whole. The standard is now not taken merely from the individual's isolated life; this stands as belonging to a larger order of the world, and the question is whether the actions hinder or further that order. [39]

It would not be correct to say that at this standpoint sympathy becomes one with the ethical feeling or conscience. Conscience appears here too as a feeling of relation, determined by the relation between what is the prevailing or central feeling in the individual and the results of the actions. The difference between this standpoint and the individualistic one is that the foundation is more comprehensive; the valuation may therefore turn out differently: one and the same action may be called good from the individualistic standpoint, evil from that of the race. When the individual immediately feels its own personal interests as subordinate to regard for the welfare of the great whole, of which in sympathy it feels itself a single member, the ethical feeling appears as *the feeling of duty*. Even at the standpoint of individualism one could speak of duty. For the concept of duty need contain only the formal relation between a more limited and a more comprehensive regard, that the latter is to have precedence over the former. The individual can in the single moment feel itself bound by regard for the whole of its own life. The feeling of duty springs — where duty is more than something imposed from without — from within the personality, and is conditioned by the demand for, and the need of, preserving the coherence of one's life through the assertion of the highest ends and interests of life in the single moments and under the special circumstances, — of finding oneself again, according to one's central nature, in the single state or action. In duty, then, a fundamental will expresses itself: we *ought* because in our inmost ground we *will*. Our central willing becomes an "ought" because peripheral tendencies of will can rise up in opposition to it, and because we nevertheless wish to remain "true to ourselves and to our best striving." But at the standpoint we are now describing, regard for the individual's whole of life will itself again be subordinate to regard for the whole of life of the race, and likewise the sympathy that has a narrower community as its object will be subordinate to the sympathy directed toward a more comprehensive community. [40]

natural. "Enlightenment left to itself" leads in his opinion to egoism and "general dissolution." See his lecture at the Evangelical-Social Congress in Frankfurt a. M., 17 May 1894.

Or rather: the individual has here made the interest of life of society or of the race its own highest interest of life, the object of its own central willing.

Seen from another side, the ethical feeling appears in its further development as *the feeling of justice*. For the sympathy that lies at the foundation will, when it is more than a blind instinct, be guided in its manner of expression (as regards both kind and degree) by regard for the peculiarity of the beings to which it applies. And when its range is widened to all beings with the capacity to feel pleasure and pain, it must in each single case express itself in such a way that the single being to which it is attached is satisfied according to its peculiarity, without other beings being thereby injured in their equally marked peculiarities. Every difference and inequality that is made to count must be grounded in what the welfare of the realm to which both the individual himself and the other beings belong requires. Sympathy, regarded from the active side, is a need to impart; this imparting must, if it is not to happen blindly, be determined by principles, and these must be taken from the nature of sympathy itself. When sympathy is universal, the difference it makes in the distribution of its goods can be due only to the reason that these goods, if distributed in another way, would not really, or not in so high a degree, be goods for those to whom they fell, or would not make for so great an advance of all the interests of life. On the ground of sympathy the ethical feeling thus develops into a feeling for distributive justice. Just as the individual feels itself as one among many, so it also regards every other individual as one among many, insofar as no special reasons motivate special regards. — At the standpoint of individualism an analogy to [41] distributive justice could be found, since the relation between the different moments and promptings corresponds to the relation between the different individual beings at the standpoint we are speaking of here. PLATO used the expression justice precisely of the harmonious relation between the different sides or parts of the single individual's life of consciousness.

It is this logical character of the ethical feeling, the strictness with which it demands grounds for every difference and inequality that is laid down, that has chiefly led people to think that the ethical law is an expression of pure reason. What KANT formulated as the content of the categorical imperative expresses in reality only the impartiality, the disregard of irrelevant and accidental considerations, which the ethical feeling built on sympathy demands. Kant demanded that in valuing an action one should take one's stand at a universal standpoint, and he held that every other standpoint contained a contradiction. But for such a contradiction to come forth, quite definite psychological conditions must be present; a collision between two interests must be felt. It holds here

again that conscience presupposes a relation in which neither of the terms is vanishingly small. That demand is thus by no means self-evident. It came forth, after all, only at a definite stage of historical development. In Kant himself the idea of this demand arose under the influence of an inquiry into the development of human social life¹⁾, an inquiry in which, however, he overlooked precisely the development of the sympathetic feelings under the influence of social life, which is why the categorical imperative too came to stand as a mystical power in human nature. Kant regarded all feeling of pleasure and pain (sympathetic feeling too) as egoistic, and thereby cut himself off from the possibility of understanding how interests and ends can develop in man that lie beyond his own existence and enjoyment. The ethical law therefore comes, in Kant, in a mysterious way, [42] as a proclamation from another world, into man's empirically given nature.

10. An *ethical* law comes into being when the conditions of life of a more comprehensive whole are formulated in definite thoughts. At the standpoint we have before us here, *the standpoint of the ethics of humanity*, its content can be nothing other than the maxim that actions are to lead to *as great welfare and progress for as many conscious beings as possible*. And this in turn comprises two main commands, a negative and a positive: 1) to no single individual ought more to be allotted than is its due according to the place that, by its peculiarity, it occupies within the race; 2) but on the other hand the faculties and impulses of every individual are to be developed and satisfied as fully and richly as is compatible with what the life of the race as a whole requires. These two commands follow with logical necessity from the concept of society as a multiplicity of conscious beings bound into a unity. It conflicts with the unity of society that a single individual or single individuals be arbitrarily preferred or set aside in favor of others: every special position must be grounded in what the common conditions of life require; but on the other hand a society is the more perfect the more freely and independently its single members move, the more different possibilities they realize, while at the same time the unity is preserved and acquires an ever more inward character and a higher validity.

When the ethical feeling on the basis of sympathy develops into the feeling of duty and of justice, it will be the principle stated in this law that is in the end the standard for the ethical judgments that are passed¹⁾. At this standpoint it also follows of itself

¹⁾Cf. my work: *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², II p. 72—76 and my essay: *Rousseaus Indflydelse paa den definitive Form for Kants Etik* (Oversigt over det kgl. danske Videnskabernes Selskabs Forhandlinger 1896).

¹⁾Whereas I have here gone from the concept of welfare to the concept of justice, I take the opposite road in an outline of lectures from 1901 which is reprinted under the name "Human Etik" in *Mindre Arbejder, Tredie Række*. There I set up the hypothesis that justice is the supreme ethical quality of character ("virtue"), and then examine — after having given a description of it — how far and in what way such an

that ethical judgments concern not merely the individual's own actions but also those
 [43] of other individuals, and that the standard must be the same. Only, with regard to its own actions the individual will be better able to follow the action back to its origin, and will thus be able to value longer stretches of its history than when it stands before the actions of other individuals.

An action, then, will be good when it preserves and develops the welfare of conscious beings, evil when it tends to the opposite. Evil will here, as at the standpoint of individualism, be what dissolves and isolates. When a single individual either makes itself or is made by others an absolute end, the community of conscious beings is dissolved. Evil is therefore egoism in its various degrees and under its various forms. And the judgment on it becomes the sterner the more conscious it is; for the deeper and firmer the root the action has in the whole disposition, and the harder it is to remedy the isolation and dissolution. The stern *valuation* itself finds its motivation and its limitation in the wish for such a restoration. It is therefore *more than an aesthetic judgment; it has a definite end, — the same end as that by which the action is valued.*

11. The objective principle, the principle for determining the content of ethics and for valuing human actions, thus becomes here the principle of *the general welfare*. According to it no action, and no institution or ordinance of life founded by action, has value except insofar as it serves to further the life and happiness of conscious beings. There are many other things besides human actions that work to further or to harm these. Through the very course of unconscious natural life things work for or against the welfare of conscious beings; but the valuation of such effects has no ethical character, because they do not spring from any consciousness and so cannot be influenced by any judgment. The judgment on what happens outside the domain of human actions acquires an aesthetic or religious character, that is, it has the character of an outburst of mood before what must essentially be taken as it is. The ethical judgment, on the other hand, can itself be motivated by the principle according to which it is passed, and must serve the definite
 [44] end of bringing about greater welfare. Therefore it can concern only such events as can be motivated by a judgment, that is, actions. This comes out most clearly where the valuing individual is the same as the acting one, or where the ethical judgment is acknowledged by the acting individual; in other cases it will be a special task how the acting individual can be brought to acknowledge the judgment, a task of a psychological-pedagogical nature. But it follows also that ethical valuation can itself be valued — and that according to its own principle. If ethical judgments can be motivated only by their

practical influence on the acting beings they concern, it is clear that in the end they must be regarded as pedagogical means. Of the two concepts, valuation and education, education is the higher, the more comprehensive. A valuation that could not itself serve as a means in the service of the end that forms the foundation of the valuation itself would be a palpable inconsistency. In this way, as the following inquiries too will often show in particulars, ethics by its own principle points beyond itself.

I use the word *welfare* rather than words such as happiness or utility, because these can easily give rise, and have given rise, to misunderstandings. By the word welfare I mean everything that leads to the satisfaction of the needs of human nature in its whole range. Ethics is to take account of all the stages of life and cannot therefore start from a distinction between external and inner, lower and higher welfare. Such a distinction is, after all, already a valuation, and can thus first take place when the principle of valuation is given. The misunderstandings of which the principle of welfare (or, as its most important champion, BENTHAM, calls it: the principle of the greatest possible happiness of the greatest possible number of men)¹⁾ has been the object derive in great part from not having kept this in view. — There is, however, also another point that is more clearly designated by the word welfare than by other expressions one might [45] use. For it points to a total state. Momentary feelings of pleasure and pain are no sure criterion of life as a whole. According to a psychological hypothesis pleasure and pain are, to be sure, as a rule the expression of the advance or decline of life: pain is a sign of a beginning dissolution of life, pleasure of its normal and harmonious unfolding. (Cf. my *Psykologi* VI D, 2. 3). But from single isolated feelings of pleasure and pain nothing certain can be inferred; nor would a mere summing up of them lead to the goal. Rather, a connection must be sought between the feelings and the whole character, the real unity in consciousness to which they belong, as well as with the whole state of the organism. Likewise the feeling of pleasure or pain of single individuals must be regarded in connection with the whole social state. So-called utilitarianism, the ethical school founded chiefly by Bentham, which has the great merit of having asserted the principle of welfare with energy, has harmed its cause by taking as its basis a psychological theory that dissolves consciousness into a multitude of sensations and feelings and society into a multitude of individuals. The significance that the feeling of pleasure and pain has for lasting and comprehensive welfare cannot be exhausted by a simple sum. — It follows

¹⁾Bentham is not the author of this formula. He has himself declared that he has it either from *Priestley* or from *Beccaria*. But both these writers are in turn influenced by *Hutcheson*, in whom the formula frequently occurs. (See Den nyere Filosofis Historie² I. p. 400). Hutcheson again is influenced by his zealous study of the later Stoics, in whom the real origin of the famous principle must be sought. This has been shown by W. R. Scott: *Francis Hutcheson*. Cambridge 1900. p. 272–279. Cf. also above p. 38 Note.

of itself that the burden of proof lies on him who demands the giving up of a feeling of pleasure in the single moment or in the single individual: the interests must be shown for whose benefit the sacrifice is to take place (cf. § 4).

12. The principle of welfare by no means gives us a magic key that can open everything without more ado. It is a misunderstanding of what a principle is to think that it settles all the particular cases for us at a stroke. We look for principles precisely because [46] the particular cases can be so intricate and complex that we gain some sort of survey only by starting from certain definite presuppositions. And, as already indicated, a principle essentially has the significance of *distributing the burden of proof*. The principle of welfare demands a proof from him who would hinder life in its involuntary unfolding and who would inflict pain, while no special proof of justification is needed in cases where one furthers the development of life and procures increased happiness. And although philosophical ethics is a practical science, it nevertheless satisfies a theoretical interest as well: namely that of grounding our valuation of actions. Such a grounding becomes impossible unless — through many intermediate links perhaps — we go back from the intricate historical context in which each single action presents itself to a general principle that in and for itself contains nothing but the spirit and direction in which ethical valuation is to proceed. The principle of welfare stands in ethics as the principle of causality stands in the theory of knowledge. Neither theoretically nor practically do the general principles give us complete solutions of the special problems. The doctrine of principles is, to be sure, placed first in the synthetic or systematic exposition of a science, but that does not mean that they are found first; on the contrary, they are found in the first instance by the analysis of certain prominent phenomena and are then set up hypothetically as presuppositions of the special explanations.

The reasoning of philosophical ethics must not be confused with the way in which, in practical deliberation, we discuss whether an action is to be undertaken. In practical deliberation we are guided by instincts and impulses, by motives that for a great part do not come fully forth in our consciousness, by thoughts and feelings whose first origin we do not discuss. We are guided by the “positive morality” into which we have grown, and which is for a great part an inheritance of the race. The ethical art precedes the ethical science; the latter seeks partly to point out, partly to correct the principles by which the former is unconsciously guided. Theoretical reflection will of course often act back on practical deliberation, correcting and purifying it; therefore complete freedom [47] of discussion of ethical questions is of such extraordinarily great importance. But only in

cases of doubt does conscious reflection come to play a direct part in ethical decisions¹⁾.

13. If regard for the greatest and most comprehensive welfare is to be the principle of all ethical grounding, it cannot of course itself be ethically grounded. If it really is the right ethical principle, that is: if it really designates the decisive standard for the valuation we make from our standpoint, — then the ethical way of looking at things first comes into force with its — conscious or unconscious — acknowledgment, and no ethical discussion can be carried on with him who denies it. Only by an *indirect* way can there be question of a grounding of the principle itself. For insofar as he who denies the validity of our principle himself sets up other principles, one may seek to show that these presuppose it and are, logically regarded, derived in relation to it. This would be the only fruitful way in which the debate could be carried on between the schools of Kant and of Bentham. This way HENRY SIDGWICK has taken with great skill in his work *The Methods of Ethics*. He goes even further there and seeks to show how the moral tradition prevailing in modern Europe finds its full explanation only when one thinks of it as having arisen under the influence of an unconscious utilitarianism. Scattered commands and decisions can be brought into connection with one another, and the doubt and indeterminacy that may prevail as to the decision of particular questions can be overcome, when one takes the principle of welfare as the basis. Likewise we thereby gain an explanation of why certain virtues have played a particularly prominent part at certain times and among certain peoples.

But against him who resolutely takes his stand at the standpoint of individualism (let alone at that of the sovereignty of the moment) this, as was said, is of no help. These standpoints are logically unassailable so long as they are consistent. The same holds against those who extend the principle of valuation only to a narrower social group, making the family, the caste, the nation, the race or the sect all in all. The narrower [48] community can thereby come to stand as an individualist or egoist in relation to the more comprehensive one. In this way we can think of as many ethical systems as there are larger or smaller wholes. The ethical world extends from the moment to mankind, but between these extremes there are many points where one can stop, and beyond which only the psychological-historical development leads, through the changes it brings about in the human life of feeling. A great example of this is the way in which, as a consequence of the development of culture after the conquests of Alexander the Great, there arose a common feeling of humanity that became the foundation of a new ethics. It becomes the business of psychology and of history to show how the different ethical

¹⁾Cf. my *Etiske Undersøgelser*. Copenhagen 1891. p. 26–29.

standpoints and motives of valuation come into being. One standpoint is replaced by another through a course of development that is subject to psychological and historical laws. There is a continuous connection between the standpoints or motives of valuation, insofar as they all spring from human nature and come into being in the course of human history¹⁾. Historical or comparative ethics (cf. I, 4), which relies precisely on history and psychology, takes hold where philosophical ethics, which seeks the grounding of ethical judgments, stops. The limit of the scientific character of philosophical ethics is thus not the limit of all scientific treatment of ethical judgments. In history the different ethical systems contend and seek by way of education and agitation to displace, or rather to absorb, one another. The way in which this education and agitation is practiced must of course consistently be determined by the individual system's own principles: one educates others not according to their points of view but according to one's own. What matters is to bring about a psychological foundation hitherto lacking, to awaken a certain definite motive of valuation. One wishes to raise the level of the others, not to lower one's own. But before the education is completed the others cannot acknowledge the principles according to which they have been educated. —

[49] In short: *every standard for the valuation of actions rests on definite psychological-historical presuppositions*. He who is to acknowledge and seriously apply the principle of the greatest possible welfare of the greatest possible number of conscious beings must not be an egoist or individualist, a fanatical patriot or sectarian, but must be able to follow human actions with disinterested and universal sympathy. This is *the subjective presupposition of the objective principle*. Apart from it, applying the principle in judgment and drawing consequences from it is merely intellectual curiosity.

It was BENTHAM's chief fault that he did not see clearly that a subjective principle formed the presupposition of the objective principle. He demanded an objective principle to control and regulate the various subjective views and assertions in the ethical field, and such a principle he found in the principle of the greatest possible happiness of as many as possible. But *the subjectivity (the conscience) that is to be regulated by the objective principle always itself lies at the foundation of this principle's acknowledgment*. An ethics that does not take this into account always acquires a dogmatic character, however excellently its principle may be suited to serve as a guide in the special discussion. *Philosophical ethics must expressly establish on what standpoint the valuing subjectivity stands*. The road to this standpoint may, historically regarded, be long and winding¹⁾. —

¹⁾Cf. *Etiske Undersøgelser*. p. 7—14.

¹⁾Cf. *Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik* (1876). Chap. III: Authority. It is there sought to show how the relation of authority is the most important source of the development of moral feeling in history. I would

A few words on how the whole conception of the significance and limitation of ethics developed in this chapter came into being will be in place here. — I started from the indubitable fact that in life ethical judgments are passed, judgments that approve or disapprove of human actions or ordinances of life, — judgments of good and evil. The first presupposition we bring to such judgments is that they must not conflict with one another. The standard applied in approval or disapproval must always be the same; the valuation must be carried through consistently from the given standpoint. It is a standard we apply to all ethical systems: there must be a necessary connection between the end taken as the basis and the means and ways employed. When Socrates laid such great weight on the command “Know thyself!” he set up a principle whose validity and applicability are independent of the real difference between ethical systems. It must be possible to agree whether, where an end of definite content and range has been set, it is consistent to pronounce a certain approval or disapproval of a given action. But formal consistency does not settle everything. What judgments are passed depends not only on the consistency of thinking, but also on what end is presupposed. When the end (and with it the foundation, the motive of valuation) is changed, the whole system of ethical judgments is changed too. Two individuals who take wholly different highest ends as the basis of their valuation can therefore continue the discussion with one another only up to a certain point. The different end brings with it a different valuation. And men are brought to set themselves new ends through practical, personal influence (education and agitation), not through mere theoretical inferences. Man grows with his greater ends, says SCHILLER. But man must already have grown in order to be able to set himself greater ends, and on such growth, therefore, it also depends what ethical propositions can come to stand as grounded¹⁾. [50]

Good and evil are concepts of relation, — as all concepts are¹⁾. They express a relation to a conscious or unconscious end and through it to a will. It sounds idealistic, but it is at bottom meaningless, to say that there is anything good or evil in and for itself — i.e. independently of every end. If one only goes back far enough, one will find an end and a will behind every ethical judgment. [51]

now, however, stress somewhat more the significance of fellow-feeling and the feeling of community in this respect.

¹⁾This whole line of thought I first developed in an essay on *Den filosofiske Etik's Principer* (Det kgl. danske Videnskabernes Selskabs Oversigter 1886), which was taken into the first edition of the present work (1887), where it made up the greater part of chap. III. Later I treated the same subject in the first chapter of *Etiske Undersøgelser* (1891) and in my Zurich lectures (*Etische Principienlehre*. Bern 1896), and in *Den menneskelige Tanke, dens Former og Opgaver* (1910) I came back to it once more (p. 346—359). The guiding thought is: how far is grounding possible in this domain? — In *Grundlaget for den humane Etik* (1876) I did not yet see this problem sharply.

¹⁾Cf. *Psykologi* V D, 5.

(1913). Quite briefly, the sting of the ethical problem can be expressed by saying that value can be measured only by value. In the end a fundamental value must be presupposed that determines the validity of all other values and their place relative to one another. Every valuation (or “revaluation”) presupposes, consciously or unconsciously, such a fundamental value. A closer examination will show that every such fundamental value is conditioned by regard for an individual or social whole and the conditions of its existence and development. The rational character of ethics depends on the possibility of finding and formulating these conditions. But ever anew the opposition and conflict between different individual and social wholes will pose the problem. The concepts of value are the most special, the richest in content and the most conditioned of all our fundamental concepts (categories)²⁾.

14. Ethical judgments, then, always point back — however much one may ground them by an objective principle of valuation — to a *subjective foundation*. They are in the end the expression of a feeling. — But there is no disputing, it is said, about feelings. This is true insofar as a feeling is a psychological fact and must be taken as such. But into every feeling there enter certain definite ideas on which its character and direction depend, and the coherence and validity of these ideas can be discussed. Such a discussion will, though slowly, act back on the foundation. Thus it will be possible to show how [52] little right the individualist has to regard himself as an isolated and unique being. It will be possible to point out the illogicality of restricting one’s love of mankind to comprise only human beings of a certain color, a certain descent or a certain faith. The complete shifting of the center of gravity, however, will first be brought about when personal and historical experiences cooperate.

Such is the position of every practical science. The significance of its propositions depends in the end on an interest of feeling that dictates the end for which the means are sought. *Political economy* presupposes the acquisitive impulse as given, and its doctrines stand and fall with the working of this impulse. It examines the ways and means by which the end set by this impulse can be reached. And insofar as other needs stir in men that come to influence their conduct, the propositions of political economy acquire an abstract and hypothetical character, hold only under a presupposition that is not completely confirmed in reality. Indeed, one must go a step further. Political economy is not a science wholly independent of ethics. It is not only a doctrine of production but also a doctrine of distribution. It does not regard the economic domain as wholly isolated, but sees it in its connection with general culture, and in the end with the ethical ends of

²⁾See on this *Den menneskelige Tanke*. p. 237–245; 346–349.

human social life. The task of political economy becomes in the end that of ordering and guiding production and distribution so that a human existence becomes attainable for as many as possible in society. Political economy is thus an ethical science, and rests in the end on the same foundation as humane ethics. The same holds of *jurisprudence*. When one distinguishes between morality and law, the essential difference is that the content of law can be carried through and realized by external force, while what is properly moral demands inner acknowledgment and the assent of the will. But only he bows to force who either acknowledges the use of force as justified or perceives his own powerlessness; and on the other hand force is used to enforce the law only where there is ability and will for it in the persons to whom it belongs. The propositions of jurisprudence therefore also acquire an abstract and hypothetical character. In general [53] jurisprudence it is even disregarded whether the means of enforcing the law are in fact present. For in the widest sense legal relations are understood to be such relations of life as are *suited* to legal ordering. One builds, then, on the idea of a society where everything suited to it is legally ordered, just as political economy in many of its propositions builds on the idea of a society where the acquisitive impulse is at work, and humane ethics on the idea of a society where love of mankind (disinterested and universal sympathy) rules and the general welfare is striven for. And in the last instance the definite difference from ethics falls away for jurisprudence too, as for political economy, for the grounding of the use of force in jurisprudence is in the end of an ethical nature, since it is sought in the necessity of forming a fixed, external order of life with definite limits to the freedom of action, so that the ethical life and the higher human endeavors may unfold under its shelter. Jurisprudence too, then, is an ethical science and rests on the same foundation as humane ethics. — In any case, by discussing the ultimate foundation of political economy and jurisprudence one comes back to problems analogous to those to which the question of the grounding of ethical judgments leads.

Both political economy and jurisprudence have, like ethics, often suffered from the misunderstanding that they were to be pure sciences of reason. They have then acquired a dogmatic and unhistorical character that conflicts with their nature as practical sciences. They presuppose a subjectivity with certain definite interests, and the possibility is not excluded that these interests may change.

15. If in ethics one wished to start only from the subjective principle, the foundation, ethics would become merely a doctrine of the ethical feeling. Since every ethics must nevertheless teach something about *what* ought to be done, one would be obliged to derive the content from the foundation. But if this is not done in such a way that an

objective principle is first sought, ethics becomes merely a series of postulates which it becomes impossible to ground even for those who stand on the same foundation.

[54] I have sought to show how the subjective and the objective principle develop together and answer to one another. A disinterested and universal sympathy cannot — without giving itself up — take any other principle as the basis of the valuation of action than the principle of the general welfare. From shortsightedness and impatience it may come to act against this principle; but it then also acts against its own fundamental value, its end, and the more it becomes conscious of this, the more it will also follow the principle of welfare in particulars. Conscience is not infallible: therefore it needs to be guided by an objective principle. At any definite moment the valuation must of course be made according to the insight at hand; there is no other tribunal than conscience as well informed as possible. But for all that the decision may nevertheless be objectively wrong; a more consistent application of the principle of welfare, built on more extended experiences, may be able to show this. Yet perhaps the greater consistency and the more extended experience themselves became possible only because the decision in the given case was made according to the insight one had. Conscience is the highest authority, but an authority that can constantly make itself more perfect. The objective principle not only makes negotiation between different consciences (on the same foundation) possible, but is also the condition of the single individual's conscience being able to judge itself.

In this way, then, the content acts back on the foundation, the objective principle on the subjective. Subjectivity controls itself by the principle contained in the end it sets itself. In a corresponding way it controls itself in the theoretical field by the principle of identity and the principle of causality, although these principles too are in the last instance posited by a subjective activity¹⁾.

16. When one considers more closely *the relation between foundation and content*, it may easily seem as if the inference from foundation to content has greater certainty than that from content to foundation. History shows us that one and the same ethical [55] content, the same maxims, commands and laws, have been set up on very different foundations. The mere circumstance that certain commands of duty recur within very different religions is enough to show this. Ethical systems on different foundations may very well present common elements, though it will appear that these elements occupy a somewhat different place in the different systems. The egoist's system, for example, does not exclude regard for family and state, though these stand there only as means. National and humane ethics may lay extraordinarily great weight on the single

¹⁾Cf. my *Psykologi* VB, 11; D, 3.

individual's self-assertion, though this is not, as in the egoist's system, the absolute end. — If we keep to the principle of welfare as the most significant example, could it not be motivated in another way than has been done here? — To this the answer is that historically regarded it does indeed seem so, but that inconsistencies and imperfections can always be pointed out when content and foundation do not answer to one another completely and reciprocally.

There are especially two ways, besides the one used in this inquiry, in which a foundation has been sought for the principle of welfare.

It has been held that the endeavor to further the general welfare is *the road by which the single individual best furthers his own welfare*, since for his own person he thereby succeeds in carrying through ends that he could otherwise not reach, at any rate not so easily and so surely. The endeavor for the general welfare thus becomes merely a detour that must be taken so that the single person may reach his own satisfaction. Every ethical command indicates such a detour, and ethics becomes the systematic doctrine of such detours. This was the conception of the foundation of ethics to which the founder of modern utilitarianism, BENTHAM, was most inclined, and which he expressed in a particularly crude way in a work published after his death (Deontology)¹⁾. In my essay "Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik" I criticized Bentham from this side, and only from [56] this side. Here I will add that it is a great and very precarious hypothesis that Bentham uses as the foundation of his ethics. It is nothing less than the bold presupposition that there is a harmony between the egoistic interests of all individuals, provided only that each of them is clear about what these really are. He who works for his own well-understood interest thus works, on this assumption, for those of all others too. Therefore no motives other than egoistic ones are really needed, and the very setting up of the principle of welfare can also be motivated egoistically. Every valuing subjectivity judges actions according to the way they further the general welfare, because the valuing individual finds itself personally best served by such actions.

It will easily be seen that this is a hypothesis that stands on very weak feet and constantly challenges doubt. It leads into very intricate inquiries that can never be concluded. It is therefore a very questionable foundation on which to erect ethics. And besides, even if one assumes this foundation, the content built on it will be only an

¹⁾In *Principles of Morals and Legislation*, which is Bentham's chief work, this doctrine does not come out so definitely. He does not there express himself clearly on the foundation of ethics. In one single passage it is said: "The dictates of utility are neither more nor less than the dictates of the most extensive and enlightened benevolence" (X, 36). But no use whatever is made of this proposition in setting up the ethical principle of valuation itself (ch. I–II). — Cf. my characterization of Bentham in *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*² II. p. 363–368.

external means, and will not immediately in and for itself answer to what lies in the foundation. The content of ethics becomes a system of concessions that the individual, who really stands at the standpoint of absolute individualism, must allow to be extorted from him. For the straight road is after all always the best, and a detour only a makeshift.

Another foundation on which the principle of welfare has appeared is *the theological*. Here too one relies on far-reaching and disputable presuppositions. Ethical valuation is thereby made dependent on the solution of the religious problems. But the endeavors to set up a philosophical ethics have proceeded precisely from the wish to make the
[57] ethical problem independent of the religious problems. If ethics is built on a theological foundation, these endeavors must be said to have failed. Besides, theologically grounded ethics is struck by an objection similar to that against the ethics built on the presupposed harmony between well-understood egoistic interests. For the whole of ethics becomes the means to the satisfaction of an interest that is in itself different from — at any rate does not wholly coincide with — the ethical interest itself. The individual's relation to what is assumed to be the will of the Godhead is a relation by itself, and it has first to be proved that there is agreement between the demands of the Godhead and those of the principle of welfare. In reality, too, every theological ethics, even if it places the principle of welfare very high, has a class of special duties that are due to the theological foundation but are not grounded by the principle of welfare, and may even come into conflict with it¹.

In setting up the principles of a science the law of parsimony should prevail. In the ethical feeling conditioned by disinterested and universal sympathy we have a foundation whose reality is indubitable, though there may be dispute as to how great a part it plays in the world. Love of mankind has, as was indicated in the foregoing, slowly worked its way forward and is still a struggling power, — must struggle for dominion both in the outer world and within the single person himself. Whether it will become the motive of valuation that will one day prevail in all, we do not know, and we need not know². It
[58] already plays such a part in the world that it is of very great interest to examine what ethical judgments consistently spring from it. And it will prove to be an extraordinarily

¹See *Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik*. p. 68–72.

²Axel Hägerström (*Undersökning af den empiristiska Etikens* möjlighet med särskild hänsyn till dess moderna hufvudformer. Upsala 1895. p. 20 f.) holds that I must assume universal sympathy to be equally great in all men, since otherwise ethics gets no universally valid foundation and thereby loses the character of a science. My opinion, however, is that universal sympathy develops both sporadically and successively, and that the same holds of any other motive of valuation one may name, — and precisely therein I see a limitation of the scientific character of ethics (not merely of my ethics, but of every ethics). — A theological critic (N. Tejsen in "Vidar" 1888) asks what philosophical ethics will do if the feeling it presupposes as the motive of valuation is lacking. Here one may answer with a counter-question: what does theological ethics do with him who believes neither in God nor in the Devil?

expedient choice to take precisely this motive of valuation as the basis. For there is hardly any other motive that in such a degree as this gives birth to an interest in following the effects of actions in their whole course, as far as is at all possible. The individualist stops his inquiry when he has made sure that the effects of an action do not touch *his* welfare; he who stands on the ground of national ethics is unconcerned so long as the effects of an action do not touch *his* people. Not even the hypothesis of a harmony between the different individual interests (of single persons or of nations) becomes of decisive importance for these standpoints. What does it matter to the individualist whether others' interests agree with his, provided only that he has the means to secure his own interest? At most he may feel a certain security at the thought of that harmony. Universal sympathy as the motive of valuation, on the contrary, leads to tracing the way in which the effects of actions intervene in the life of all personal beings, and thereby gives birth to an interest in inquiries of a scientific, psychological, historical, social and statistical kind, which can go entirely together with the scientific interest in such inquiries. By virtue of the motive of valuation chosen we are thus led beyond ethics, or ethics is led to rely on natural science, history, psychology, statistics and political economy, so that valuation can become as *objective* and as *realistic* as possible. And this transition takes place with inner consistency and in a more direct way than at other standpoints that attempt to take up and ground the principle of welfare. To universal sympathy as motive of valuation answers the principle of welfare as an objective principle for the valuation of human actions; it merely unfolds more fully the logical consequences of the psychological foundation and makes possible a consistent grounding of its single [59] expressions. The foundation and the content of ethics have here moved as close to one another as is at all possible.

Every ethical conception that starts from an authority as its foundation — whether this be supernatural or natural, consist in the will of those in power, in the attraction of models or in the compulsion of public opinion — must yet grant that as soon as the individual can immediately make the ends of the authority his own ends, the only sure and simple foundation of the ethical will thereby have been reached, and the possibility of a constant correction of the ethical at the same time most surely given. It is a detour when I enter into relation with the highest ends that my will acknowledges only through the will of an authority. In energetic and intellectually developed love of mankind we have the only foundation where the individual and the universal ends can immediately be identified. Over against a force such as this all authority can have only provisional and pedagogical significance. All authority may vanish without the abiding foundation of

the ethical vanishing with it. It is one thing that the ethical law (when we disregard the standpoint of the moment and the standpoint of absolute individualism) is the conditions of life of a comprehensive whole formulated in definite thoughts, another how these thoughts are acknowledged by the single individual. Even where those conditions of life are enjoined by external laws and by public opinion, the individual may, after all, have come to them by way of his own conviction. Perhaps the single person even has a far clearer and more far-reaching insight into the conditions of life of society than the laws and public opinion have so far been able to express, — and should then the disposition with which he follows this insight in his conduct not deserve the name of ethical, because no authority sanctions it? The motive of valuation that it will be of greatest interest to test must surely be the one that is most directly able to value every authority by the standard that all authority must satisfy in order to be regarded as justified. If one builds all ethics on authority, where then will one find a standpoint from which the ethical valuation of authorities can take place?

[60] 17. The difference between foundation and content does not coincide with the difference between *individual* and *social* ethics. To the content of ethics belong both the individual qualities of character and the social forms of life that agree with the principle of valuation; it thus comprises both individual and social ethics. The question whether individual and social ethics are independent of one another, or whether one of them is determinative for the other, must be decided according to the principle of welfare. Within special ethics an individualism may assert itself of another kind than the one spoken of earlier, since it does not build on the sovereignty of the individual but is grounded by regard for the general welfare, which requires as many independent and peculiar points of departure for action as possible. It goes in a corresponding way with the grounding of the existence and significance of the smaller communities within the larger. The general principle of welfare demands regard for all conscious beings whose feelings of pleasure and pain can be set in motion by the actions. But precisely in accordance with this regard it may become of the greatest importance that interest concentrates itself on a narrower circle. Through life in the family and in the definite activity of a calling one perhaps works in the best way for the advance of the nation, and through taking part in the national life for that of mankind. All these questions are of a more special kind than the one it is the task of this chapter to discuss.

18. As we saw in § 2, the opposition between “subjective” and “objective” ethics arose in the first instance from the different weight that was laid on the inner and on the outer side of the action. I have sought to show that this opposition goes further back and is

closely connected with the character of ethics as a practical science. I now return in conclusion to those two sides of the action in order to have occasion to determine the relation between what I have here called the ethical *foundation* or *the motive of valuation* and the *motives* of the single actions.

The history of ethics shows us that valuation first concerns *the external action and its effects*, but that it gradually widens to apply also to *the motives, the disposition, the character of the agent*. It is, after all, natural that one keeps first to what seems to lie plain to view and can become the object of sensuous observation. The spiritual eye [61] is directed to the external before it is able to apprehend the internal. At the more primitive stages, moreover, actions have essentially the character of reflex movements and expressions of instinct; the motives do not particularly come forward, and interest does not particularly dwell on them. Nor is any distinction made between morality and law, between inner and outer agreement with the prevailing law or statute. Ethical law, custom and juridical law have not yet separated out from one another. A significant side of ethical development consists precisely in these differences making themselves felt. This presupposes a capacity to understand the dependence of the action on definite motives and their tendency to work in a certain definite direction. Ethical valuation is then extended to the internal too. The great revolutions in the ethical field appear essentially as advances in the *inward deepening* of ethical valuation. Such an advance we have where ethics separates itself from jurisprudence by stressing the inner source of the action as the essential thing. What matters is not merely to perform or to refrain from the external action, but agreement between the whole inner state and the demand of the ethical law. Such an inward deepening is at the same time a *generalization*. For when a motive (e.g. egoism, hatred) is rejected, all the single actions that spring from it are rejected with it, and these need not be specially enumerated. Likewise the approval of a motive is the approval of all actions that spring from it. The transition from external to internal valuation is therefore finally a great *simplification* of the ethical law. It is not the multiplicity of commands, but the qualities of character that are to rule, and the direction in which the forms of society are to be developed, that have to be laid down.

Examples of such inward deepening, generalization and simplification we have in Christianity's break with Judaism and in Protestantism's break with Catholicism, and in general wherever a purely ethical way of looking at things separates itself from a view that relies on custom, authority and external force.

The ethical law demands the presence of the disposition that carries it in the race. [62] This is what Kant expressed in the proposition that it is a duty to have a conscience.

Since the acknowledgment of duties presupposes conscience, it might seem as if one were here going round in a circle. But this is only apparently so; for the foundation and the motive of action *need* not coincide, and it need not be an imperfection either when they do not coincide. According to the principle of welfare it may very well be necessary that motives other than the feeling of duty itself make themselves felt. It may, for example, be necessary or healthy that the instinct of self-preservation, or again immediate fellow-feeling, lead man to undertake actions for his own and others' welfare, and that conscience does not stir at every single action. It may even be a sign of perfection when actions that demand effort and sacrifice are undertaken without its happening from a feeling of duty. Spiritual practice leads, after all, to this: that what at first could be performed only through several psychological intermediate links, through express reflection and exertion of will, can at last be performed directly and without special consciousness of why one really acts so.

19. All ethics is practical idealism. It presupposes that we set ourselves ends, but an end is not something that is, but something that *is to be*. All ethics therefore presupposes an impulse, a living feeling and craving bound up with an idea of what is craved. If reality satisfied every need, there would be no ideal and therefore no ethics. But an ideal that ethics is to be able to use must not merely stand above reality; it must also have points of attachment in the given reality, so that from it at least an approximation to the ideal becomes possible. It must — subjectively regarded — be able to find acknowledgment, and it must — objectively regarded — be capable of being carried through more and more in the world of experience. It is real men who are to will and act, and a real world that is the scene of their willing and acting. What ethics demands must be physically, psychologically and historically possible, must not conflict with the laws of the real world. He who rejects all ethics because it sets up ideals can only mean by this that its ideals lack points of attachment in reality. He will not be able to avoid setting up ideals himself, so that he overthrows ethics by a new ethics. When, for example, he demands that one be honest enough to admit that ethics is an impossibility, or when he perhaps even rejects ethics because all the misfortunes of human life derive from "morality," he speaks in the name of honesty or of love of mankind, and so appears as an ethical idealist. The discussion can turn only on which ideals one is to set up. No one escapes ideals, however he twists and turns. But ideals can be of very different worth, and it is about the worth that there is dispute.

Theoretical science, too, always has an idealistic character. It operates with principles and presuppositions so simple that real experience never completely covers them. All

coherent, constructive thinking becomes possible only by our holding fast a single side, a single element of the given, and drawing all the consequences from it. Thus geometry regards things merely as extended in space and derives the general laws of extension without taking account of the other properties of things. In all fields, in order to be able to think sharply, we must think of things as simpler than they are in reality. This does not exclude that the results of thinking can hold of things, provided only that it is essential and significant sides of them that we treat in our constructive thinking. Just as geometry constructs an ideal space, ethics constructs on the ground of psychology and history an ideal conscience. In reality every man's conscience is composed of different, sometimes even conflicting, elements. Imitation and tradition, egoism and ambition, regard for others' opinion and fear of punishment, reverence and love of mankind, religiosity and social feeling — these and still more motives stir within the ordinary conscience, which is not so simple a feeling as is often supposed. The different possible ethical systems characterized in the foregoing (4–13) contend not only in history and in the race but also *within* the single human being's consciousness. Everyone has — or can have — several [64] interests and ends that contend with one another as to which of them shall in the end determine the valuation a man makes of his own and others' actions. Anyone who would attempt to develop a coherent ethics must take a single motive of valuation as the basis, as ruling and determining. And in taking a single motive as the basis an idealization has already been undertaken. The history of philosophical ethics shows us how men have tried to carry through the different possible motives of valuation. Thus HOBBS and BENTHAM started from egoism or well-understood self-interest, HUTCHESON, HUME and ADAM SMITH from men's sympathy grounded in common interests, HEGEL from the idea of the state and of the cultural community. Philosophical ethics has here the significance of bringing the different ends men can set themselves to full consciousness and of drawing all the consequences from them. The different ideals are thereby so illuminated that the struggle between them can be carried on with greater clarity; it is one of the most important contributions theoretical ethics can make to practical ethical striving. The worth of the contribution will depend on how significant the motive of valuation chosen for examination is. — From the foundation chosen, all motives and tendencies are valued according to how far they lead, directly or indirectly, in the direction of the ideal that the foundation leads one to set up. The difference between theoretical and practical science is here this: that in theory our ideals are approximations to reality, which is the goal thought seeks to reach, while in practice it is reality that is to be changed and brought nearer to the ideal.

20. In three respects ethical ideals depart from what is actually given.

First, there is much in actual willing and acting that directly *conflicts with* the ethical demand. Toward this ethics takes up a *checking and negating* position, demands that it be excluded from the ethical world. In the practical life of the will there corresponds to this the checking activity by which involuntary promptings and inclinations, original or acquired, can be pushed back¹⁾.

[65] Next, actual willing and acting often presents only *weak and incomplete* realizations of what the ethical demand contains. Here what is needed is increase both in degree and in range; what is needed is potentiation and *widening*. Ethics here pronounces an Excelsior! The direction is good, but the movement lacks strength and fullness. In the practical life of the will there corresponds to this the exertion of attention, the summoning of energy, in general the will's capacity to act back on itself through its influence on ideas and feelings¹⁾. — Or the direction is good, but the *motive* cannot be acknowledged, so that an entirely different grounding is necessary if the will or the action is to become perfect. A direction of the will that has arisen from one motive can later (through *displacement*, see I, 4) perhaps be acknowledged only by virtue of an entirely different motive²⁾.

Finally, actual willing and acting may *lack coherence*, unity and harmony. Different and mutually conflicting tendencies and impulses may make themselves felt. What is needed then is *combination and concentration*, the working together and reconciling of the conflicting and scattered forces. To this there corresponds in the field of the practical life of the will the practice of composite movements and series of ideas, and the capacity to make a resolve and thereby put an end to deliberation³⁾.

In the checking, in the heightening or motive-changing, and in the uniting activity alike, the principle of welfare is the guide. Only where it is satisfied do these activities acquire value. One can just as well check something good as something evil, just as well heighten something evil as something good; the ethical value therefore lies not in these activities in and for themselves, but in the direction in which they are exercised.

The processes spoken of find application not only in the ethical development of the single individual but also in that of society and of the race. There may be individual expressions of life that conflict with the welfare of the race, though they do not conflict
[66] with the individual's own isolated welfare; they must be checked. An endeavor for social welfare may lack strength or range or right motivation; here, then, there is occasion for

¹⁾*Psykologi* II, 4 e; 6 e. — IV, 4.

¹⁾*Psykologi* VII A, 5; B, 2.

²⁾*Psykologi* VI C, 2.

³⁾*Psykologi* VII B, 1 c: 3; 5 a

potentiation or widening or displacement. Finally there may be lacking the coherence and harmony between the different expressions of life and endeavors within society and the race that is necessary if the general welfare is to be reached; what is needed then is to work together and organize the scattered activities. —

From this side, too, it appears that philosophical ethics is both conservative and radical. (Cf. I, 4). It takes its points of departure in the given. On bare ground it can accomplish nothing. But this given it then seeks to develop further in the three ways stated.

21. In more or less sharp opposition to the theory of ethical principles and of the possibility of grounding them that is put forward in this chapter, several Danish writers have sought to find what is in their opinion a more objective and rational foundation for ethics. Their endeavors aim at asserting the scientific character of ethics; some of them even think they have shown a scientific foundation for ethics for the first time. In particular their endeavors aim at freeing it from the empirical and subjective limitation to which, on my view, it is necessarily subject. Now it is not probable that every such limitation could fall away. For it appears everywhere, where one goes back to the foundation in principle of our knowledge, that grounding and limitation go together. And it cannot, after all, be otherwise, since every grounding rests on certain presuppositions. To overlook this leads to dogmatism. It has been my endeavor to point clearly and definitely to the points where a strict, rational ethics rests on psychological and historical presuppositions that do not hold everywhere and at all times. I grant, however, that the works referred to may serve to supplement my exposition by throwing light on sides of the problems that it has perhaps not allowed to come fully into their own. And since they also bear witness to the interest in ethical problems that has stirred in this country in recent years, I shall go somewhat more closely into these works as regards the decisive [67] main point.

The difficulties that make themselves felt in every attempt at a scientific ethics have their ground in the fact that all ethical concepts and propositions concern relations of value. Ethical judgments state the relation between human actions and the ends they are to serve, and the concept of end in its turn presupposes the concept of value, unless one takes the word “end” in a figurative sense. But value again can belong only to what is thought of in relation to a living being’s feeling. A subjective element thereby enters. And besides, all living beings do not necessarily know the same values, and therefore do not set themselves the same ends either. Here, then, value can stand against value, at any rate when one goes back to the fundamental values on which the special values depend.

In the foregoing I have shown how I myself stand toward these difficulties. Every ethics must, from whatever fundamental value it starts, seek means and ways to produce what is valuable in the world of reality. It must take its stand on the ground of experience, both when it is a matter of showing in what the valuable consists and when it is a matter of finding means and ways to produce it. In both respects ethics is grounded, on my view, on biology, psychology and sociology. All human values are bound up with life, the existence and unfolding of personal life and of social life, and the conditions of life must be learned from life itself. This is the fundamental thought of my ethics, and through it it becomes possible for ethics, in spite of its subjective point of departure, to become an objective science (see above § 11 and 14–16). One will, I hope, not find in my exposition a single attempt at grounding that does not rely on biology, psychology or sociology. Just as little as the subjective character of the qualities of sense makes physics impossible as an objective science, just as little does the subjectivity of values make ethics impossible as an objective science. In both cases the task is to find the objective relations to which the subjective determinations answer. But an essential difference between the [68] position of ethics and that of physics arises from this, that while the qualities of sense are tolerably the same for all, experiences of value vary among different individuals and peoples and at different times. I am too much of an empiricist and historian to be able to overlook this fact or to think I can escape it by abstract constructions. The task of scientific ethics then becomes for me to examine what special values can consistently be derived from the different fundamental values or types of value. (See § 3–13). The possibility of different ethical systems thereby appears. These will not, however, fall wholly outside one another; they may meet in particular propositions, which are then set up with different groundings. (Cf. § 13 and 19). Even if they contain the same elements, these will yet be combined in different ways, and the timbre will therefore be different. Or perhaps what stands as fundamental value in the one system will stand as derived value in the other. Such an inquiry will in any case have its significance, even if it is regarded only as a preliminary discussion (a “*Phänomenologie des Geistes*”). There is a constant development in the ethical field, both as regards single individuals and as regards the race. But we are unfortunately in the midst of this development and cannot rise above the imperfections that follow from it. The dispute still stands, and I cannot see otherwise than that the road I have taken must in any case bring greater clarity about the object of the dispute. In the long run, clarity about the consequences of the different standpoints will of course affect the course of development¹⁾.

¹⁾It has been of very great interest to me to see that the French mathematician and philosopher Henri Poincaré took up quite a similar position on the ethical problem to the one I have put forward in this

If one does not find the way in which I stand toward the difficulties named satisfactory, there will be chiefly three roads one can take.

a. One can try to reduce the concept of value, which is, after all, what causes the difficulties, to its most elementary forms. About the most elementary values there will be least dispute, and they will most easily be brought into definite connection with [69] objective relations. This road is taken in our literature by Dr. STARCKE (*Samvittighedslivet*. 1894–97) and Dr. N. H. BANG (*Begrebet Moral*. 1897).

b. One can go a step further and try to eliminate the whole concept of value, strike out all psychical elements and presuppositions, and ground ethics on biology as a purely objective science. Ethical propositions then become biological deductions. Such a “biological” ethics has been maintained by Dr. S. HANSEN (*Etikens Begrundelse*. 1903).

c. Finally, one can seek to reduce the oppositions between the different fundamental values to purely logical contradictions, which fall away when one seriously conceives man as a thinking being. This road is taken by Professor KROMAN (*Begrebet “Det Ethiske”*. University programme, Nov. 1903).

It is interesting that all three roads have been tried by Danish writers. I shall now try to show that none of these three roads leads to Rome.

a. Dr. STARCKE’s conception of ethics has evidently developed under the influence of his studies of primitive forms of society, studies that have borne fruit, among other things, in his excellent critical work on the primitive family. For an inquirer who has immersed himself with great energy in such studies, it is natural to apply relations from the more primitive societies to social life as a whole. The clan, accordingly, stands in his account of “the life of conscience” as the frame that encloses the single person’s life, in that the respect and esteem of the others become the most important condition of his secure conduct of life. “The demands of morality... come to man from without... The moral requirements are now of such a kind that the power of society seeks to carry them through by force, so that he who transgresses them is punished; now they are referred to the sanction that public opinion, the good repute and kindly disposition of other men can give them... In the right of others to hold the individual responsible for his actions lies the center of gravity of morality.” (*Samvittighedslivet*. I. p. 120). This conception of the ethical consistently leads to a limiting of the content of ethics. Everything not needed to bring about the feeling of security that arises in the single person from knowing himself [70] and his conduct to be in agreement with the punishing authority and public opinion falls outside ethics. When this limit is reached, the single person can go his own ways.

chapter. See his *Dernières Pensées*. p. 236–238 (also p. 228 f.). (1913).

The whole of social life stands as merely a means for the single person to be able to feel secure. And when this end is attained, the single person can seek his happiness as he will. — The question is whether individual and society can be set over against one another in this external way. Even if the individual thinks he has settled accounts with society, the way in which he seeks his happiness may yet be of the greatest social significance. It cannot be a matter of indifference how single persons conduct their inner life, since it is in the inner, personal life that the values come into being that can later change and develop society. The single person therefore has, even in his most intimate relations, a social responsibility that only he himself can make good. Here he is himself guardian and judge. It is placed in his hand whether at this central spot in the world new values are to arise, or whether the germs of such are to perish. Dr. Starcke does in fact teach that it is the conditions of social life themselves with which the single person must feel himself in agreement in order to be able to feel secure. But if this is so, it is clear that reward and punishment, esteem and contempt — the only sanctions acknowledged in Dr. Starcke's account — can be only educative means. Why, now, should precisely the feeling of security be the motive of valuation? And may it not be a matter of indifference to the single person who has sufficient power whether the others feel secure, provided only that he does himself? The elementary life of valuation that lies at the foundation of Dr. Starcke's account does not, then, lead with necessity to the results he wishes to ground.

Dr. Bang holds that usage has already settled what morality is. "A judgment that declares an action moral or immoral states that the action, as a general practice, will further or hinder the good of society, and that it is in the interest of the general good that society, through its organs, the state or public opinion, further or hinder actions of that kind." (Begrebet Moral. p. 113). To this I remark that, however the case may stand with usage, the grounding given in this statement holds only for him who takes an interest in the general good; for anyone else it becomes merely a thought-experiment. Experience shows that men can, with greater or less approximation, make their own good, not that of society, their end; for such men a deduction from the good of society will have nothing really convincing. They may grant that certain demands must consistently be made when one starts from the good of society; but they do not themselves start from it unless they are compelled to, and compelled they cannot be if they have courage and power enough to defy the state and public opinion. And according to Dr. Bang the content of ethics does not extend beyond what can be maintained through the laws of the state and the verdicts of public opinion. Outside the relatively narrow circle of duties that these

authorities rightly demand to be fulfilled, the single person can lead his own life and seek happiness by his own ways.

Thus the application of the most elementary points of view necessarily leads to a dualism or a purely external relation between individual and society. And in Dr. Bang this dualism appears in a particularly striking way, in that he declares that “the most admirable qualities of soul, the qualities of the great man” perhaps come forth precisely in him who breaks with “morality.” “We have never asserted that moral action is the most perfect action” (p. 145). “Morality is one perfection, one virtue, among others; it is the fundamental social virtue, but not the only one, not the all-comprehensive one, and not the highest either” (p. 190). But where, then, is the standard by virtue of which “morality” is compared with other virtues? There must surely be such a standard, for otherwise it would be meaningless to speak of higher and lower qualities. Unfortunately this standard is not stated — though it must be precisely its nature that a treatment of the ethical problem ought to concern. Why is the “moral” good, and when does it cease to be good, to give place to “higher” and “highest” qualities? That is the kernel of the problem, and it is this that I have tried to bring forward.

As regards the appeal to ordinary usage, Dr. Bang really takes it back himself, since [72] he admits with regret that usage is indefinite. The word “moral” is used, after all, of purely individual rules of prudence too, and noble or meritorious action that goes beyond the minimum of what is “dutiful” is also called moral action (p. 30. 35). It seems to me that if one regards usage as an authority, one must also follow its fluctuations. Living usage is always on the move, and it may be guided by just as right an instinct when it moves as when it stands still. How right the instinct is that guides it in its variation one will discover when one lets the words go and keeps to the observation of what different ends men can set themselves, and what influence this consistently has on their valuing judgments. The questions that the scientific inquiry into valuing judgments has to treat are then how men come to set themselves ends, and how these ends determine their valuation of their own and others’ conduct. The fact that usage varies in the way spoken of shows that ordinary consciousness itself is already aware of the problem in its larger range¹⁾.

¹⁾In his book *Naturlig Ret* (1907) *Severin Christensen* has given a sketch, interesting in several respects, of an ethics confined to formulating the elementary conditions of human living together. An attempt is made here to isolate the most elementary part of ethics and to treat it by itself. It recalls Fichte’s attempt to set up a doctrine of right independent of all ethical presuppositions. (See on this below chap. XXXVII, 4). Just as little as the attempts spoken of in the text does this conception escape the difficulties that follow from the concept of value. Here again it must be asked whether it may not be a matter of indifference to the single person who has sufficient power what the conditions of living together are. He transgresses them when he can, and he observes them only when he can use them for his own ends. (1913).

b. The “biological” ethics, as Dr. S. Hansen has sought to found it, would dispense with the concept of value and thinks thereby to escape the difficulties it brings with it. It is granted, to be sure, that all ethical inquiry turns on whether a certain action is a [73] means to the attainment of an end; but about the end lying at the foundation there is here to be no doubt; it is an end given beforehand, and one that ethics does not itself set up (p. 107). The end set by nature itself is the existence and advance of the race, or the greatest possible unfolding of life (p. 24).

Now is this really an end that is absolutely necessary? Dr. Hansen himself grants that other ends *can* be set. That end is, he says, “as little arbitrarily chosen as may well be possible” (p. 28), set up “with least arbitrariness” (p. 30); another goal cannot be set up “with greater logical right,” and in any case no goal can be set up that conflicts with this one (p. 234). What becomes, then, of the logically compelling? Different ends, after all, can be set up, and no single one has beforehand the absolute “logical” right. That is in reality all I have asserted, and it is therein that for me the difficulties about the presuppositions of ethics lie. Dr. Hansen grants me (with whom on this point he thinks he is “as much at odds as may well be possible”) everything I wish. For him too several consistent ethical systems must be possible. I have come to this recognition by the way of experience, supported by what biology, psychology and sociology have taught me. And if there is anything the biology of the last half-century has impressed upon us, it is surely above all the struggle for existence — a struggle between living beings over whose life is to endure and unfold. It is a struggle between individuals among themselves and between groups of individuals. We still stand in the midst of this struggle; it is waged in the human world as well as in the rest of living nature. It is in it that ethical ideas are to prove their validity, not in the world of abstractions, not for “life in general,” but for quite definite, individually and historically formed stages of life.

According to Dr. Hansen the compelling end is really given with the definite outcome of the struggle. He grants that he uses the word “end” in a transferred sense (p. 24). It really means only a tendency of movement in a certain direction, so that one may with the same right say that the rolling avalanche has its “goal” in the valley, or the river its [74] “goal” in the sea. But can one then everywhere set down the actual result as the goal? It is precisely here that the concept of value announces itself as unavoidable. For if we could, we would stop the avalanche when it threatens to destroy the town down in the valley, and divert the river’s water when it can be used to make our fields fruitful. The unavoidable we must put up with; but it does not always stand as something that can become a goal for us. Thereby ethics becomes something other than the acknowledgment

of the right of the stronger and submission to blind, brutal facts. Here the proud word holds that was said of Cato the Younger, that the gods held with the victorious cause, Cato with the vanquished. The victorious does not always have value on its side. Experience shows us both development and dissolution. Which of them is really nature's "goal"? Mephistopheles holds that everything that comes into being is worthy to perish, and that it would therefore be best that nothing came into being. How will one be able to refute him? A consistent advocatus diaboli would in any case hardly give in before lyrical phrases such as, for example, "the eternal right of life to assert itself" (p. 111). How can there be question of right before ethics has come into force? The "biological" ethics expressly maintains, after all, that the "goal" itself cannot be grounded ethically.

When experience shows us different tendencies of movement, there is nothing else to do but to hold fast and favor the tendency that has the greatest value for us, and value is experienced through the feeling of pleasure. Here, then, we come into the subjective world, which one cannot get round, either in ethics or in logic, unless one wishes to dogmatize. But there exists no gulf between the subjective and the objective. All thinking about values leads to examining the conditions of their arising, and thereby the possibility of producing them anew and developing them further. No tendency in ethics has impressed this with greater energy than the morality of utility or of welfare. According to it ethical work consists in converting the natural energies into such forms as enable them to work toward valuable results. Human impulse and passion do not — any more than the avalanche and the river — always work in the direction of valuable "goals"; therefore ethics demands a metamorphosis of them, whereby they can — with the [75] conservation of energy — work in other directions. What is demanded is a conversion from the real to the ideal. Plato was the first to set this task in the grand style (in the "Symposium"). This conversion is to take place not in a world of fantasy but in the real world itself. That is why I have also always maintained a close connection between the problem of valuation and the other main problems. "What is for me the highest end, which determines the value I attribute to everything else, must surely be so constituted that it can be asserted and striven for within the world whose reality can be shown by the most consistent criterion I am able to apply [namely the causal connection shown by science]. Something can prove itself valuable only through the way in which it intervenes in the real world. And on the other hand this real world itself acquires greater or less value for me according as it proves to further or hinder a striving toward the end that determines my judgments of value"¹⁾.

¹⁾*Det psykologiske Grundlag for logiske Domme.* (Vid. Selsk. Skr. 6. Række) p. 65.

In all fields the setting up of a principle has first and foremost the significance of distributing the burden of proof. The significance of the causal proposition is that the burden of proof lies on him who would maintain that an event has no cause. And in an analogous way the principle of welfare means that the burden of proof lies on him who maintains that a pain is better than a feeling of pleasure. When I strike the cup out of the hand of the thirsty man, I must show that it is harmful to his health to drink, or that the water was poisonous. A pain or a disappointment may, according to the principle of welfare, be more valuable than a feeling of pleasure, if it is a necessary purgatory, or if it is a contributing element in a more valuable state. The ethical consideration here relies in the end on the biology of feeling. Therefore one may very well stress the subjective element in ethical judgments²⁾ without giving up the possibility of a grounding.

[76] c. Professor Kroman agrees with me that one cannot get round the concept of value, and that in all ethical judgments passed in real life an element of feeling of decisive significance cooperates: "The expression 'for the sake of' can be used with meaning only with regard to a feeling being" (p. 52). But he is convinced that man "in the last resort" must combine the different elements of feeling in a way free from contradiction. The right action, the one that the ideal conscience demands and acknowledges, will be "the one agreeing with man's inmost abiding nature, the one free from contradiction in the last resort" (p. 37). The ethical is no historical accident, but "something necessarily connected with man's inmost abiding nature, an outcome, constant in all essential features, of the foundation common to all individuals" (p. 44).

It is indisputable that when a contradiction makes itself felt between different interests or tendencies, a need must arise to get it out of the way, either by a choice between the opposites or by a harmonizing of them. In this way contradiction drives forward. But the great question is precisely whether the contradiction is present in the particular case, and in what *degree* it is felt. And it is here that experience, psychological and historical experience, shows us extraordinarily great differences. These differences are by no means historical accidents. They must be assumed to have their definite causes, which it is the task of psychology and history to find. One has no right to start from the assumption that all tendencies of feeling are found in every man in such a degree of development that the only thing needed now would be to unite them in a way free from contradiction. Therefore I cannot get over the different stages and standpoints as easily

²⁾It has escaped Dr. Hansen's attention that by "ethical judgments" I mean from the first (see I, 1) the judgments of good and evil that men pass in real life. The ethical problem is posed when it is asked whether such judgments can be grounded. Scientific ethics is a system of grounded ethical judgments. With the grounding a closer determination and further development will follow.

as my colleague. I have, to be sure, sought to show that Lombroso's well-known theory of the criminal man cannot be grounded by experience¹⁾; but the opposite assumption, [77] that all the elements an ideal conscience demands are present in everyone, in every race and at every time, cannot be grounded either.

Even if all the elements were present, it would still be of importance in what relation they stand to one another. For a contradiction to be present — a contradiction of such a kind that it can work as a motive (both motive of valuation and motive of action) — the different elements must each come forward with great energy. No contradiction comes forth when one element sounds only as a faint tone, a distant ring, while the opposite deafens the ear of the soul with its pealing. A certain development is thus required for the contradiction to be able to assert itself, and especially for it to become a driving and motivating force. So long as development is still going on, in the single individual and in the race, "the ideal conscience" therefore stands as an abstraction not covered by any actual standpoint. Each of us, every generation and every people, stands at a certain definite stage of development, and by this definite stage of life all values, ends, ideals and norms are determined. If one would build ethics on the foundation of experience, one cannot pass by the difficulties that lie herein. *When* are we at "the last resort"? And how long must a tendency express itself and prevail in order to deserve the predicate "abiding"? Here there is always only the possibility of approximation, in life and in thought.

For the rest, I believe that one may not regard the contradiction between the elements of human nature as the only condition of development. Often biological-psychological development takes place as a positive growth, in that an element unconsciously and involuntarily attains such a degree of development that it gains the upper hand in the soul and determines the timbre with which the whole interplay of the elements of the soul appears. Where in this way a single element becomes prevailing through expansion, contradiction plays no part. And it is perhaps the greatest things in the field of the soul that take place in this way. It is by no means so that we always first have a series of single values and ends, and then get rid of the contradiction in one way or another. There are [78] values that involuntarily come to prevail, and there are ends we set ourselves because we have grown without knowing it. Not only can it go as in the parable, that we sow the seed, and it then grows, becomes stalk and sets ear, while we sleep; but even the seed may have been sown without our suspecting it. As I have said elsewhere, it holds not only that man grows with his greater ends, but also that he must have grown in

¹⁾Cf. *Etiske Undersøgelser* (1891). p. 73–81.

order to be able to set himself greater ends. And besides this unconscious growth there may take place displacements of value and of motive whose results cannot always be foreseen. (Cf. *Psylogi* VI C and the present work XIII, 4). Nor in such transitions is contradiction the decisive thing. A psychological process is, after all, something other than a formal logical train of thought, and man is, to be sure, “a thinking being,” but his thought unfolds at each given stage under the influence of quite definite historical conditions.

The psychological-historical foundation whose consequences and special applications I examine in my ethics appeared in Stoicism in the last centuries before Christ; then for the first time the idea of a general feeling of humanity (*caritas generis humani*) was set up as the most comprehensive motive of valuation. Deepened and made inward by Christianity, and clarified through the intellectual and social development of modern times, it poses for ethical thinking the most comprehensive tasks any system can wish to treat. Among these tasks is also that of deciding how one is to stand, in thought and in life, toward those in whom that foundation is not developed, or who do not acknowledge it. A demonstration of self-contradictions may here have its significance. But man's nature is too composite and too changeable for the mere striving to be freed from self-contradiction to be able to furnish a sufficient foundation for the ethical.

[79]

IV.

THE THEORY OF CONSCIENCE.

1. In the preceding chapter (§ 5 and 9) conscience was described chiefly as a feeling. But no feeling is wholly without connection with the life of consciousness as a whole, and it is important to stress this in particular in order to understand the nature of conscience.

It is interesting that the concept of conscience is from the first closely connected with the concept of consciousness. The corresponding word (*συνείδησις*) was first used among the Greeks in the general sense of self-consciousness, the capacity to apprehend one's own inner states, before it was used in the more special sense of ethical self-valuation. And the German *Gewissen* (= *Mitwissen*) likewise first had a more general theoretical meaning before it acquired the special ethical meaning¹⁾. The expression

¹⁾Rudolf Eucken: *Geschichte der philosophischen Terminologie*. Leipzig 1879. p. 175. — The Danish “*Samvittighed*” was taken over from Low German (probably in the 14th or 15th century). The Low German *samwitticheit* had (as a translation of *conscientia*) the meaning “consciousness” and the meaning “conscience.” Older than it is Old High German *gewissen* or *gewizzida*, which meant knowing, knowledge, and only later (after the Latin *conscientia*) took on the meanings consciousness and conscience. I owe this information to colleagues in linguistics.

conscience implies that man has the capacity as it were to divide himself into two persons, one of whom is the object of the other. We are thereby referred to the general mark of consciousness: a combining activity by which the single experiences are placed in relation to one another. All life of consciousness is the expression of a need for unity and coherence, for a synthesis. And in conscience this peculiarity expresses itself in a particularly inward and concentrated way. However great the opposition may be between what man recognizes as the ideal and his own actual willing and acting, conscience [80] nevertheless leads man to own both: "That is my ideal, however much it conflicts with my conduct!" or: "That I have willed and done, however much it conflicts with my ideal!" The arising of conscience presupposes that within consciousness a difference makes itself felt between a central content, what prevails and rules, and a peripheral content, the single passing thoughts, moods and utterances of will. Where an idea of a chief end, an ideal, a model, has developed, it must — together with the feelings and impulses attached to it — belong to what is central in consciousness. Conscience is then a form or a part of the reaction of the central against the peripheral, a feeling of relation that acquires a different character according as there is a harmonious or a disharmonious relation between the central and the peripheral in the personality. There may be great resistance to overcome before the immediate holding together and comparing of the highest and the lowest that consciousness contains can come about. The descent into hell of self-knowledge, to use Kant's expression, requires the summoning of great spiritual energy. But it comes about according to general psychological laws and only expresses the general nature of consciousness in a particularly marked way. There is therefore no reason to take conscience for a special faculty or sense, implanted once for all and in all¹⁾. The possibility of conscience lies in the general nature of consciousness; but whether this possibility is developed, and in what direction it is developed, — what special content conscience thus acquires, — depends on the social conditions under which the individual comes into being and develops (see I, 2). Since the relation of contrast between the different elements plays so great a part in the arising of conscience, it is psychologically intelligible, as experience seems to show, that the "bad" conscience arises before the "good": the contrast is naturally greatest where there is present not merely a difference [81] but a sharp conflict. Personal ethical life therefore often first really comes into being through one's feeling oneself in actual conflict with what one takes to be right.

The special character of conscience will depend on what ends or interests of life are the highest for the single person and make up his real self. On this, after all, depends

¹⁾I do not know on what *Victor Cathrein* (*Philosophia moralis*, Friburgi 1895. p. 60) relies when he attributes to me the assumption of a special "sensus moralis."

also, as we have seen, the difference between the different possible ethical systems, all the way from the egoistic to the universally humane¹). But however comprehensive the interests of life to which the single person has attached himself, he nevertheless always feels himself in conscience as a harmonious or disharmonious whole. His real I is the one that lives in those interests; his outer I is the one that appears in his actual willing; and in conscience he perceives the relation between his real and his outer I, both of which, after all, belong to his personality. If he denies one of them, conscience does not come into being; but then he also deceives himself. There expresses itself in conscience, as F. C. SIBBERN has shown, a deep care for oneself, a spiritual impulse of self-preservation. And it expresses itself first and foremost in one's wishing to be honest with oneself, — even if one has not been true to oneself.

It is not always, and not from the first, that conscience has this free, personal character. It may be bound to authority, and its task is then to hold the pronouncements of authority [82] up against the individual's own willing and acting. The real self is then determined by obedience and reverence, and what matters is whether these feelings are injured or satisfied by a man's conduct. The spiritual position of power of the Catholic Church rests on its having as it were branched out through the confessionals into the personal centers of its adherents. Great firmness and boundness in certain things is thereby brought about, but at the same time great freedom in other things. For where authority does not speak clearly, I have according to Catholic ethics¹) — by virtue of the principle that an uncertain law is no law (*lex non certo promulgata non obligat*), — the right to follow whatever opinion I will, even the *least* probable — provided only it is still probable! — One reasons here: whether I drown in 10 or in 3 fathoms of water is of no consequence! Once I am outside the reliable pronouncement of authority, I need not be so particular! With boundness to authority probabilism consistently follows.

¹)Conscience, when the different fundamental values are disregarded, has a purely formal character. But even the purely formal has its value. That is why I have distinguished in *Den menneskelige Tanke* (p. 241—245) between formal and real differences of value. To the first belong the differences between elementary and ideal values, between immediate and mediate values and between potential and actual values. In its purely formal character conscience is a guardian over a harmonious relation between these opposites. To another group of differences of value belong partly the difference between biological (economic), intellectual, aesthetic, ethical and religious values, partly the difference between individual, social and cosmic values. — Cf. also my *Psykologi* VI C, 8 a. (1913).

¹)Victor Cathrein: *Philosophia moralis*. p. 152. — Alfonso de' Liguori, one of the authorities of Catholic moral theology, enjoined a certain caution in weighing the probability that a law might be the right one. He demanded that the possibilities between which the individual had free choice should not merely each have a serious ground at all, but also that on express holding together and comparing they should stand as equally or almost (sic) equally probable. This somewhat stricter doctrine is not, however, the prevailing one in the theory and practice of the Catholic confessionals. On this question see J. P. Gury, S. J.: *Compendium theologiæ moralis*⁶. Lugd. 1899. I. p. 133—140.

It is otherwise where the individual does not have the standard outside itself, but where the decision is placed in its own hand. The free conscience does not find it so easy to feel secure; it does not know the abrupt boundary between certainty and uncertainty. It has both a more inward character — since the single person is here his own judge — and a more comprehensive task — since it must constantly seek to learn from life.

It is not always that the end or interest of life with which the actual willing and acting is held up for comparison itself comes forth in consciousness. Approval or disapproval may be felt toward an action without one's being able to account for what it is that has been satisfied or injured. We have here an analogy to such cases where an effect [83] of contrast sets in against a sensation that cannot itself be shown to have been in consciousness, or that was at any rate there so briefly and fleetingly that it was not noticed and remembered¹⁾. In such cases conscience acquires a mysterious character, which is stressed especially by those who deny the natural origin of conscience and regard every attempt to explain its arising by a psychological-historical way as "materialism." The explanation lies in many cases in this, that a constant interest can, through repetition, sink beneath the threshold of consciousness, but that it does not for that reason cease to work. There is a constant relation of interaction between the conscious and the unconscious.

In such cases conscience takes on the character of an instinct. Instinctive working is everywhere characterized by serving an end that is not itself an object of consciousness. The obscure and unconditional way in which conscience often works can perhaps be explained only by the assumption that inherited elements cooperate. One may rightly speak of a conscience of the race, and the common tradition will not always be a sufficient explanation. But it must nevertheless — even if one accepts the assumption of hereditary elements in conscience — be firmly held that inherited dispositions are always indeterminate, and that the way in which they are developed will depend on the social conditions and traditions in which the individual grows up. The single individual involuntarily appropriates the positive morality and through it acquires the ends and interests of life that determine its life of conscience. The custom and usage prevailing in society are immediately felt as binding. Just as the life of feeling in general develops under the constant but quiet power of the conditions of life²⁾, so the life of conscience in the single person cannot always be traced back to quite definite and single experiences either. The mysterious character of the "unwritten laws" rests in part on this. The child [84] hears that those around it approve or disapprove of its conduct, that it is the object of

¹⁾ *Psykologi* III, 6. — *Det psyk. Grundlag for log.* Domme. p. 35–39; 47.

²⁾ Cf. *Psykologi* III, 7 and VI F, 4 c.

ethical judgments, and in its great urge to imitate it repeats these judgments on occasion and so involuntarily appears as its own judge, regards itself from the standpoint of those around it. At the same time it is led — likewise involuntarily — to imitate those around it in its conduct; it thus practices the virtues that are particularly required in the society in which it lives. It acts — as ARISTOTLE¹⁾ says — well before it becomes good, just as only by playing the cithara can one become a cithara-player. The action thus far precedes the capacity. Through both passive and active imitation the child thus grows into the practical ethics of society and thereby acquires the first form of the life of conscience. Conscience does not yet exist here as a free, individual capacity for valuation, but is an echo that — perhaps deeply and inwardly, but yet from without — resounds within the single person. As it always goes with the child, so it goes at earlier stages of culture — and everywhere where positive morality rules alone — with men in general. Their ethical ideas and their conduct of life are determined first and foremost through the social milieu. Fear and awe of the gods of the tribe, who represent, after all, the experiences of the past, respect for custom and usage and for public opinion (δήμου φάτις) determine — as the oldest history of the Greek people in particular teaches us — the judgments and actions of men at this stage. Awe of the gods, for example, holds men back from using poisoned arrows (Odys. I, 261–363), and a son who in anger would kill his father is held back from it by the thought of “the talk of the people and the many reproaches of men”: he feared to be called a parricide! (Iliad. IX, 460 f.). In its noblest form ethical conduct appears at this stage as determined by a considerateness that can rise to modesty and reverence (αἰδώς), and which is felt not only toward the aged and the mighty, but also toward equals, indeed particularly toward the poor and the suffering, where it becomes one with pity. In a characteristic way we see here sympathy as a motive of valuation [85] and of action gaining influence on positive morality and ennobling it, keeping it from becoming mere regard for what others say. The Greeks distinguished between that noble modesty and the feeling of shame (αἰσχύνη) that is only a shrinking from incurring blame. The transition to conscience proper in a free, individual form is marked by the demand that DEMOCRITUS set up: “Have modesty before thyself, and thou wilt not come to be ashamed before anyone!”¹⁾. SOCRATES’s demand for self-knowledge as the condition of all right action was the most important step toward moving the center of gravity from the outer to the inner, and the emancipation of conscience is completed by *the Stoics*, who also fixed the expression conscience in its ethical sense. — With the dissolution and

¹⁾Eth. Nic. II, 1.

¹⁾P. Natorp: *Die Ethica des Demokritos*. Marburg 1893. p. 10. 102. Cf. also the interesting inquiry into the concepts of modesty and shame in L. Schmidt: *Die Ethik der alten Griechen*. I. p. 168–186.

downfall of ancient culture this development was broken off, and with the ecclesiastical dominion of the Middle Ages the principle of authority came forward in the sharpest and most conscious form it has ever had. *Protestantism* and *modern philosophy* again asserted in practice and theory the cause of the free conscience²⁾. So long as conscience is only “the echo of the authorities,” so long there is an opposition between freedom and conscience: for so long the appeal to conscience will be one with the giving up of every attempt to ground one’s judging and acting. The peace of conscience then easily becomes a pillow to sleep on, while conscientiousness — “obedience to the inner Thou shalt!” — becomes a finer kind of bondage. If by conscience one understands only a social echo, it is consistent when it is proclaimed that “the free man of reason” must be without conscience³⁾. But, as we have seen, conscience is closely connected with the general nature of consciousness. And only when self-knowledge has awakened, so that man can become conscious of his highest ends, will a clear and thorough examination [86] of the justification of judgments and actions be possible, and not merely possible, but a spiritual necessity. In particular, as has been shown above (III, 16), the conscience whose motive of valuation is universal sympathy will necessarily be led to examine, with all the means at hand, the influence of the action or the judgment on life within us and outside us. How far the examination can be carried in the single case, nothing can of course be said beforehand. It will go here as with all knowledge: where one stops, another will perhaps be able to continue. Limited (“borné”) we all are, more or less.

The free conscience will have a tendency to develop to a higher degree of express consciousness than the instinctive conscience bound to positive morality possesses. Ideal images will involuntarily form that depart more or less from the traditional models. In place of the mere instinct that works involuntarily there then steps an impulse with an idea of an end. Experiences and reflections determine the development of the ideal images. The individual tries to assert his ideal against resistance within himself or from without; it thereby stands forth more clearly before him, but at the same time there arises the possibility of altering and reshaping it: the resistance experienced may, after all, at times be recognized as justified, or at any rate lead to renewed self-examination. And even if man from weakness is not always able to assert his ideal against the resistance, the attempt is not without effect; strength is exercised and may perhaps grow strong for the next struggle. It is through such trials that conscience gains its experiences. In particulars it unfolds by virtue of general psychological laws. Now it is by virtue of the laws of the association of ideas that thoughts and misgivings come up; now it is to an

²⁾See my work: *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². I. p. 8—74.

³⁾Bruno Wille: *Die Philosophie der Befreiung durch das reine Mittel*. Berlin 1894. p. 243 ff.

effect of contrast that the awakening of conscience is due. Through fusions of ideas and blendings of feelings, through displacements and deferments, as well as through express concentration of the will in definite directions, there forms a resultant of the individual's experiences that determines the way in which it stands toward new calls to judge and to act.

[87] Without wholly losing its instinct-like or impulse-like character, conscience can develop into what has aptly been called practical reason. A need will arise for consistency and totality in ethical ideas. Actions — not only the actual ones but also those merely thought of — are followed out in their consequences; ideas form of all the beings with the capacity to feel pleasure and pain that are touched by the actions and their effects. Here a developed historical experience will be of particular importance. With its help later Greek philosophy was led beyond the opposition between Hellenes and barbarians, and with its help modern philosophy was led to a consciousness of humanity that rose above differences of class and religion. Both historical experience and logical consistency contribute to the constant self-correction of conscience. Valuation gradually takes place more consciously and according to definite principles. A philosophical ethics is only a methodical exposition of the content of conscience as it takes shape at such a stage. What Kant depicted in the categorical imperative and in the formal and universal moral law of reason was a result of a long historical and psychological course of development.

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Where conscience works as instinct, the individual does not know what it is doing. Where it works as impulse, it has a dawning idea of it. But where it works as practical reason, there arises a clear consciousness of ideals and rules.

2. Conscience appears in the most various forms and in the most various degrees in the single individuals. Not only can it come forth now as a half-unconscious instinct, now as impulse, now as practical reason. But now immediate sympathy, now the feeling of duty, now the feeling of justice may be the chief element in it. It may express itself now predominantly negatively and checkingly, now more positively, partly heightening, partly uniting. (Cf. III, 20). It may express itself now as enthusiastic devotion, now as a more quietly and steadily working need. It may now assert with inwardness the interests of life of a small community, now be determined by a comprehensive view of the welfare of large circles. It would be impossible to depict even merely the chief forms [88] of its appearance in the single individuals. But it is of great importance to be attentive to these differences, since we still suffer from a dogmatism that cuts everyone to the same pattern. It will follow precisely from the principle of welfare that every individual ought

as far as possible to live and work according to its peculiarity, and nowhere can this hold in a higher degree than when it is a question of the ethical foundation itself. Precisely where the greatest responsibility rests on the individual, since it is to assert the highest interests it knows, the individualization of conscience will be a necessary demand: for only by virtue of it can the individual work with full strength. Where the individual has not acted according to its full peculiarity, it has (as SCHLEIERMACHER has said) not been wholly active either. And the more the individual in its most significant action can work out of its inmost peculiarity, the more it stands not merely as a means but also as an end; its own deepest satisfaction then accompanies its action. —

One must surely go a step further still. There may be men who possess no ethical feeling proper, and who do not need any either. What they can give they give with all their heart, without making any valuation of their own or others' actions. They are wholly absorbed in an activity that agrees entirely with their faculties and impulses, without ever doubting its justification and significance, and without their zeal cooling. It may be the cultivation of art or science, activity in the service of society or for the support of their family. Or they belong to the happy natures that spread light and joy about them merely by existing. Whether there are many men of that kind is not easy to say; but there is nothing to prevent there being such at all. From the heart they do the works of the law without having the law, and what should ethics have to object to that? Ethics exists for the sake of life, and not life for the sake of ethics.

There may thus be extraordinarily great differences between individuals in respect of conscience, and it would be dogmatic to lay down here one definite type as the only right one. These differences come out, of course, especially where one moves away from [89] positive morality; for this has in all its forms a tendency to regard all individuals as alike. The attempts to develop a philosophical ethics bear witness to the differences that are actually present, in that the individual philosophers each describe and set out the kind of conscience they know best. A "personal equation" makes itself felt here¹⁾, and the history of philosophical ethics has, among other things, the great significance of drawing attention to the typical differences in the ethical field. And yet most philosophers hold the assumption that the ethical demands, the content of the ethical law, must be the same for all, so that conscience can only become a formal capacity to acknowledge and fulfill the law. It might, however, be that the differences concern not merely the form, manner or degree of consciousness of conscience, but also become determinative for the

¹⁾Cf. Frank Chapman Sharp: *The personal equation in Ethics*. (Transactions of the Wisconsin Academy. 1894—1895). — Sharp applies the concept of personal equation at another point than I do in "Ethiske Undersøgelser."

content of the ethical law in both qualitative and quantitative respects.

If by an ethical law one understands a sum of demands laid down by an external authority or by absolute reason without regard to the individuals for whom they are to hold, then it is clear that individual differences cannot come to influence the content of the law. "The objectively right" is demanded — and demanded in equal degree of all. But when one acknowledges the principle of welfare, one must also hold firmly that the right ethical law cannot have been found so long as the individual's personal peculiarity does not come into its own. Neither in respect of the kind of faculties and motives nor in respect of their degree are the different individuals alike, and a law that in qualitative and quantitative respects would demand "the same" of all would thus in fact demand a most different labor, lay most different burdens on the shoulders of the single persons. If there is to be equality before the ethical law, then "the same" must not be demanded of
[90] all, and the single person's conscience must therefore make demands that in qualitative and in quantitative respect would be different from those that others' conscience makes. Now something other and more, now something other and less, is demanded.

In the qualitative respect this will most readily be granted. Every individual has — on account of its special endowment — its calling, its special direction in which it is to work. Only where a caste system in one form or another exists is the same direction of activity demanded of the most different individuals. Under freer forms of society it is recognized that man's tasks are determined not merely by general laws and external circumstances, but first and foremost by his own peculiar nature. This was something people already had an eye for in Greek antiquity. SOCRATES enjoined the necessity of knowing one's nature and one's faculties in order to find one's tasks. THE STOICS carried this thought further: he who does not follow his own nature will not be able to preserve the personal coherence and unity of his life; therefore one should do as the good actors do, who do not choose the greatest parts, but choose the parts that best suit their gifts!¹⁾ — Conscience has here to guard the individual peculiarity, but at the same time to keep self-delusion out.

It will be harder to grant that the ethical law also varies in quantity for the different individuals, and yet it is not possible to see how this consequence can be avoided if one holds firmly enough to the difference between an ethical and a juridical law. Ethically regarded, a far greater labor may have been performed, and a far greater self-control and self-sacrifice shown, by a man who nevertheless does not come up to the average level demanded from without, than by many a one who easily satisfies the "social" demand

¹⁾Cicero: *De officiis* I c. 31. — Cicero here follows the Stoic Panaetius (of the 2nd century B.C.). See Schmekel: *Die Philosophie der mittleren Stoa*. p. 41; 219.

but who has on the other hand done no work to develop his faculties beyond the average level, although there was possibility of it. And should the former, ethically regarded, then nevertheless stand below the latter? Such an absurdity every ethics falls into that [91] takes up a purely objective standpoint. The principle of welfare demands, as will be shown later, as a necessary consequence, that a personal being must at no point be treated as a mere means. But that would be the case if ethics had said its last word with the formulation of a universal law that drew a line through all personal differences. The true ethical law must individualize, must state for the single person the work he can do. The virtues and duties demanded of the single person must be means and ways to the development of *his* personal peculiarity. — Ethical laws are therefore not so easy to find as is often thought. The task must be to find out how the single person, by following his law, satisfies the general law in the best way. And this task is solved when the general law, valid for all, states only the direction in which one is to strive, the type that is to be held fast. Only with dogmatic arbitrariness and by overlooking the deepest-lying psychological and ethical problems can one fix “the quantum satis of manly will” for all at once. At any given time a society will, through its leaders or through public opinion, fix certain qualities in a certain quantity as those that can be demanded and as standing within the power of every “normal” man. What is understood in the particular cases by words such as courage, self-control, etc., is due to the average experiences one thinks one has had concerning the resistance that can be overcome. One here applies an estimate that one trusts holds for all individuals. One does not see that a personal equation holds here, which sets a limit to universally valid ethical reasoning. If men were more alike, it would be easier to be a moral philosopher. But to make the matter easier than it is surely cannot be good philosophy¹⁾. It is no solution of the problem to distinguish between valuation and imputation and to leave it to the [92] latter to take account of individual differences in disposition and faculties. This way out Alexius MEINONG has attempted: “Moral valuation in its generality cannot enter into personal particulars, while the imputation directed at the single personality can hardly be personal enough”¹⁾. This, however, is an all too juridical way of looking at things.

¹⁾Cf. *Ethiske Undersøgelser*. p. 51–83, where I have set out and illustrated in detail the individual relativity or the personal equation in ethics. — In antiquity the doctrine of the personal equation was hinted at by Aristotle, in modern times by Hutcheson, Jacobi, Schleiermacher, Beneke, and in our own literature by A. S. Ørsted (*Om Grænserne mellem Teori og Praxis i Sædelæren*. 1811. Reprinted in *Eunomia I*) and by S. Kierkegaard (*Uvidenskabelig Efterskrift*. 1846. p. 376.). (Samlede Værker VII. p. 426). (“Where is the boundary for the single individual in his concrete existence between what is lack of will and what is lack of ability, what is sluggishness and earthly selfishness and what is the limitation of finitude?”) Cf. already Holberg: *Moralske Tanker*. 1744. p. 463.

¹⁾*Psychologisch-etische Untersuchungen zur Werth-Theorie*, Graz 1894. p. 201. (Cf. my review of this work in *Göttinger gelehrte Anzeigen*. 1896. Nr. 4). — On the juridical and the theological conception cf.

Jurists have been accustomed to distinguish sharply between the general law and the individualizing treatment in punishment, and between sentence and pardon. Ordinary opinion and public opinion also apply this distinction; so too the theologians, when they distinguish between law and grace. But the law and the sentence are unjust if they do not take the agent's individual presuppositions into account, — and no less are the execution of punishment, pardon and grace indefensible if they are not the expression of a higher justice.

3. Since all ethical judgments presuppose conscience as their psychological foundation, it is *the highest authority and lawgiver*, and every other authority, of whatever kind may be named, is subordinate and derived in relation to it. To wish to go beyond one's conscience is to wish to go beyond oneself. Where I bow to another man whose judgment I trust more than my own, this is justified only if it happens by virtue of my conscience. Conscience is infallible, if by its infallibility one means this, that at every [93] single moment it is the highest judge. Conscience, to be sure, where it stirs in earnest, must lead precisely to seeking an objective decision with the help of the best grounds and the most exact experiences that can be procured; but the application of the objective criterion cannot always be carried through before the moment for action has come, and we are then compelled to act according to the best conviction we have won up to that very moment. There is thus not, as has been objected against me¹⁾, a contradiction in declaring conscience infallible and yet holding firmly that it is to be guided by an objective criterion.

But this infallibility is not of an objective kind. The highest ethical authority may itself prove to be on a false track. It would be dogmatic to assert that conscience never deceives us. By such an assertion one arbitrarily shuts one's eyes to some of the most tragic conflicts of life. The purest and most earnest conviction may rest on a complete error. We have an altogether immediate and infallible mark of truth just as little in the ethical field as in other fields²⁾. Every more serious conviction comes forward in the form of conscience; but the mere form is no guarantee of absolute truth. FICHTE grounded the assertion of the infallibility of conscience on this, that the highest goal for us is to act independently, out of our own personality; if we really do that, the perfect is reached, as it can be realized at this definite point of existence³⁾. But the tragic thing is that the most inward personal conviction may prove to have been in conflict with what an objective

my *Etiske Undersøgelser*. p. 63.

¹⁾Giacomo Laviosa: *La filosofia del diritto in Inghilterra*. I Torino 1897. p. 629—631.

²⁾On the criterion of truth in other fields cf. *Psykologi* V D, 3; VII B, 4. — *Den menneskelige Tanke*. p. 99—108.

³⁾Cf. e.g. *Appellation*. 1799. p. 32.

valuation of the circumstances enjoins. Could not those who crucified Jesus have acted according to their best conviction? Should Kant be right that an inquisitor cannot have a good conscience? Was it not in good faith that Aristotle defended the justification of [94] slavery, that Calvin, with Melancthon's approval, had Servetus go to the stake, and that Sand murdered the "traitor to his country" Kotzebue? —

No less dogmatically does one cut the knot from the opposite side. Where one regards ethics merely from the objective side, as the doctrine of forms of society and external actions, one declares without more ado that subjective feeling is unjustified over against the objective relations and their demands. Ethicists of standpoints as different as HEGEL and BENTHAM meet in distrust of conscience. According to HEGEL it even stands on the very point of being the evil principle in the world, since subjective conviction can just as well aim at something objectively reprehensible as at something objectively right¹⁾. — It is easy enough, as these ethicists do, to warn against self-confidence and self-will and to require that one bow to an objective law. The law we follow must, after all, always make itself known to us in the form of conscience. The light that makes everything else clear to us must in the end be found in ourselves, and who guarantees us in the particular case that it is not a will-o'-the-wisp we let ourselves be led by?

Here there lies the possibility of a conflict between the two principles on which ethics builds, the foundation and the content (the motive of valuation and the principle of valuation). There can hardly be any other solution of it than the one already indicated, that at the moment conscience must be obeyed, since there can be no higher authority. It is presupposed, of course, that it speaks clearly and after due deliberation. But to this it must be added that conscience can control and correct itself; the later, more practiced [95] and experienced conscience judges the earlier. Precisely by following his best conviction at the moment man can make his way to a more correct conviction, which teaches him that what at the moment of resolve stood before him as the best was nevertheless wrong and pernicious¹⁾. So long as one acts according to one's best conviction, a man's inner

¹⁾Cf. *Hegel: Philosophie des Rechts*. § 139–140. — *Bentham: Principles of Morals and Legislation*. ch. II. § 11–19. — *James Mill* blamed a bad action equally severely whatever its motive had been. Praise and blame were for him motivating forces; therefore they must not be influenced by the motives of the action. (*Stuart Mill's Levned*. Danish transl. p. 52). There was in his opinion no motive that under all circumstances works in the right way; not even the social feelings; therefore it is of constant importance to calculate the effects of the action according to the principle of utility. *James Mill: Fragment on Mackintosh*. London 1835. p. 176 f).

¹⁾The appeal to a good conscience is often made in such a way that one precisely bars oneself from the possibility of such a correcting. Cf. *Albrecht Ritschl's* apt remark: "Man kann beobachten, dass wer im Falle des Streites sein Gewissen als die höchste sittliche Instanz für sich ausspielt, und sich auf keine weitere Ueberlegung sittlicher Regeln einlässt, hiebei meistens eine Gereiztheit hervorkehrt, welche kein ganz gutes Gewissen verräth." *Ueber das Gewissen*. p. 17.

being is sound, however the case may stand with the objective character of the action; and this inner soundness was the germ out of which the more correct insight could develop. Therefore, from an ethical point of view too, a pernicious action performed in the conviction that it was good can be placed above a good action performed in the conviction that it was bad. In the first case the source itself was pure, in the last it was corrupt. In the personal inwardness with which what is regarded as true and good is held fast and practiced lies the point at which one individual best understands another, one generation can best sympathize with another. In the field of external actions and forms of life the differences and oppositions are often so great that understanding is impossible.

Only he who has the courage to err can accomplish anything great. Willingness to expose oneself to such error is willingness to suffer for the truth. Nor is it, then, the cold and the narrow-hearted, but those who have enthusiasm for the true and the good, who err in this way. Nothing venture, nothing win.

But the capacity of conscience to correct itself is developed only when a *definite principle or criterion* for valuation can be found. Such a principle conscience can of course not let be prescribed to it from without; it must spring from conscience's own nature. I [96] have already sought to show (see III, 10–15) that when conscience is determined by a disinterested and universal sympathy, the principle of welfare is the only criterion that can come into question. It expresses nothing but what lies in the end that a personality animated by sympathy must set itself.

Ethical development, however, will hardly ever go forward without conflicts between subjective conviction and the objective connection of things, repeated again and again. Just as it is an infinite task that is set our theoretical science, namely to explain reality to us with the help of the principle of causality, so too it is an infinite task that is set us in the ethical field, namely to value all actions and conditions of life according to the demands of the principle of welfare.

4. In close connection with the concept of authority stands the concept of *sanction*. Authority commands or forbids, but it is the sanction that makes the command or prohibition hold good. The sanction consists in the pleasure or pain attached to the observance or transgression of the command, the reward or punishment one incurs by one's action, the heaven or the hell one draws nearer to by the action.

Only where the authority itself is an external one does the sanction stand in this external relation to the action. And in this external form it has no *immediate* ethical significance. The ethical character of the action rests, subjectively regarded, on its

springing from the inmost disposition, objectively regarded, on its agreement with the principle of welfare. What ethical significance could it have if to this there were added a pleasure or pain that did not spring from the action itself? Because I act well now, why should I then at a following moment obtain a feeling of pleasure? Because I act evilly now, why should I then at a later moment suffer a pain? There is, ethically regarded, nothing self-evident in this. The whole idea of reward and punishment belongs to pedagogy, not to ethics. It may be needful for education that reward and punishment increase the power that the feeling of the action's worth and significance does not always possess in sufficient degree. But it is no immediate ethical necessity. When it is asserted that the thought of retribution is a thought clear in itself, this is because one is guided by [97] an instinct (to revenge or to gratitude) whose ethical justification and necessity is not given from the first. The "self-evident" is very often the blind. The involuntariness of the prompting makes one not ask for grounds, and then one thinks that no grounds are needed either.

The external sanction, which consists in reward and punishment, can, as was said, only be educative. The ethical sanction must be an *inner* one. It can consist only in the agent's feeling of harmony with his own highest conviction, of agreement between his ideal (his fundamental will) and his actual willing. There thereby arises an inner peace that can be stronger than all contradiction and resistance from without. The individual may have the feeling that there prevails in it a force that could transform the world if it prevailed in all. It feels its being widened and heightened. The men it most admires it could confidently imagine as spectators of its action, even if all the motives lay uncovered before them. It is not pride that stirs here, but a quiet feeling of being, in all lowliness, akin to what is great. The counterpart to this is the feeling of forsakenness that may seize him who sees that his conduct must isolate him from all. When Richard III wakes after his dream before the battle, he is in despair because he knows that no one can love him. Not even the world of dream and of memory can for him enclose the image of anyone who approves his conduct.

Such an inner sanction is not merely the effect of the action, but consists in a feeling that may already be present before the action is performed. It is then only the continuation and full development of what led to the resolve and made it possible. "Blessedness," says Spinoza, "is not the reward of virtue, but is virtue itself." It is of the same kind as the satisfaction that accompanies the fulfillment of a deep-lying need. The source of the action and the effect of the action are here closely connected.

This satisfaction can be so great and strong that everything else loses its value in

[98] relation to it. A great and beautiful moment can stand above a long but insignificant life. Self-sacrifice thereby becomes psychologically intelligible. Between the satisfaction felt in performing a self-sacrificing action and every other possible feeling of pleasure there may be such a distance that the latter as good as vanishes from consciousness. The image of life as it takes shape when the self-sacrificing action belongs to it may be so radiant that life as it would be without this action loses all value. This is only a single example of a well-known psychological law. Already in the old Buddhist didactic poem *Dhammapada* it is said (v. 111–112): “Better than to live a hundred years in blindness and distraction is it to live a single day in understanding and enthusiasm. Better than to live a hundred years in torpor and feebleness of will is it to live a single day in the unfolding of strength of will.” ARISTOTLE too has seen this. “The good man,” he says¹⁾, “will do much for his friends and for his country; if it is necessary, he will even die for them. He will sacrifice goods and honors, and in general all the contested goods, in gaining for himself the beautiful; for he will rather feel a great joy for a short time than a slight joy for a long time, rather live one year beautifully²⁾ than many years in an indifferent way, rather perform one great and beautiful action than many small ones. So, surely, it goes with those who die for others: they win for themselves something very beautiful.” — IMMANUEL KANT expresses a related thought in the following words³⁾: “Is not an upright man, in the greatest misfortune of his life, which he could have avoided if only he had been able to set himself above his duty, held up by the consciousness that he has upheld humanity in his person in its dignity and has honored it, so that he has no cause to be ashamed before himself and to shun the inner gaze of self-examination?”

[99] 5. How great a part this inner sanction plays in actual life is beside the point here. There are perhaps very few human actions that need no support other than it. But it is of importance to hold firmly that it can be sufficient to carry the ethical life. On this fact depends the independence of ethics over against dogmatics and metaphysics, and through it ethics becomes independent of postulates of faith and of hypotheses.

From an ethical standpoint one must have great misgivings about the way in which the ethical is so often made dependent on certain definite religious or speculative assumptions. In the first place the consideration then lies near that he who no longer holds these dogmas has thereby also emancipated himself from the ethical, and will perhaps even act consistently when he follows the principle: “Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we shall

¹⁾Eth. Nic. IX, 9.

²⁾By the beautiful Aristotle understands that which we will for its own sake, not as a means to something else.

³⁾*Kritik der praktischen Vernunft*. Kehrbach's ed. p. 106 f.

die!” But next, one robs the action of its proper ethical character by turning attention to what lies outside the nature and source of the action, and declaring regard for reward or punishment a necessary motive.

There are those who cannot hold fast to the validity of the ethical except with the help of faith in a higher order of things, where everything is perfect and complete that in the reality we know is imperfect and fragmentary. But the need to live in such a faith must not be regarded as a universal human necessity, even if it is a need that has stirred in some of the most excellent men who have lived.

Not even to faith in a progress *within* the world of experience ought one to attribute an absolute value for ethics. Such a faith may, theoretically regarded, have its difficulty in being maintained. But *even if* it should not stand its test, *even if* the victorious tendency in the course of the world went against ethics, the ethical principles would not therefore be shaken. The tasks would become different. There would be greater occasion for pity and resignation; but where the ethical disposition was present, one would hold with the vanquished cause, though the gods held with the victors. Ethical value does not rest on mere power. He who follows his conscience can of course do so only because it is the strongest thing in himself; but he does not do so because it is the strongest thing in [100] the world. The legend of Christopher, who wished to serve the strongest, is therefore unethical, as so many legends are. Whether the development of the world ends (if it ends at all) as a tragedy or as a comedy, we can know nothing about, and in any case he who obeys the law of conscience does not on that account change anything in his part. Our ethics is the ethics of wayfarers (*Ethica viatorum*). We see the road open before us, but its end we do not know. We do know, on the other hand, that we can get further, even if we should not be able to go it to the end; and we know that standing still is decline and death.

In the very fact that conscience has arisen and developed within the human world we have, however, a testimony that valuable forces are at work in existence. Here, even if it is in a vanishing corner of the universe, a power has come into being that can carry life and is not afraid to pronounce its judgment on it. We therefore live not merely “on possibilities,” but on a real foundation, which we seek to make ever broader and stronger. The ethical life is a struggle for a kingdom that is coming into being, that can grow, and whose fate stands in the closest connection with everything that gives life value and significance. To this consideration ethics withdraws, and lets the dogmatic and speculative discussions go their own way.

6. The hour of the birth of conscience is the moment when a feeling arises that is

determined by the difference between ideal and reality. It arises as every instinct and every impulse arises. The hour of its death would be the moment when this difference fell away for good. By the nature of the case this can happen in two ways, either by reality getting the better of the ideal, or by the ideal getting the better of reality.

If for the present we keep to the first possibility, there may here again be different ways in which reality can, so to speak, stifle the ideal. This may happen through spiritual enfeeblement, through blasé indifference or through surrender to purely animal impulses. But such cases have an individual and special character and belong to special ethics. Here, where we are discussing the general presuppositions of ethics, we ask, on the other [101] hand, whether there might not be *such a scientific conception of reality that there would no longer be any room for the ideal*.

Such a conception is present, in the opinion of many, in *the modern hypothesis of evolution*. According to it there prevails, after all, throughout nature, the human world included, an inexorable law of selection, by virtue of which what cannot adapt itself to the given conditions perishes, and only what suits the circumstances endures. Physical force, then, seems to be set on the throne, and dominion in the world to be handed over to brutality. Can our ideals then become more than pious wishes and sighs that change nothing in the course of things? Through natural selection and in the struggle for existence even the noblest and best is trampled down, after all, if it cannot or will not meet force with force!

It is not the business of ethics to teach us to know reality. That it leaves to other sciences. It is able neither to confirm nor to refute any of the hypotheses that have proved justified and grounded on purely theoretical grounds. But it naturally has a great interest in examining whether such a hypothesis can be reconciled with the ethical principles.

If we now look more closely at the hypothesis of evolution, it rests, when applied to human life, on a fundamental thought that is so far from conflicting with the presuppositions of ethics that it must be said to be precisely one of them, the thought, namely, that human development, as soon as it is more than mere physical growth, becomes possible only through the awakening of definite wishes and impulses that can work as moving forces. The greatest hindrance to development, indeed even to mere existence, is torpor and indifference. In the purely elementary forms of human development it is need that drives forward: but in the course of development needs arise that are directed toward more than mere self-preservation. Only where no need, no impulse stirs, and where none can be awakened, is hope gone. Only he who strives can be saved. This truth, which idealistic conceptions have so often proclaimed in more or less vague forms,

has by the modern hypothesis of evolution only been impressed on us more closely and more urgently — more brutally, if you will. [102]

It is not a matter of indifference whether or not we work along with development consciously and willingly. The very impulse to ethical valuing and ethical acting is one of the forces that cooperate in determining the course and direction of development. Precisely when we assume that this impulse has developed according to definite laws of nature, it must be clear to us that it is not in conflict with the hypothesis of evolution. It has, to be sure, awakened late in its freer and higher forms and has not yet exerted its full influence. It is in the process of becoming, but precisely therefore it has the future before it.

Although the modern hypothesis of evolution has so strongly stressed the influence of external circumstances, it nevertheless also maintains that this influence is in each single case more closely determined and limited by the inner conditions with which every being steps out into the struggle for existence. The higher a living being stands, the more it is able to intervene *actively* in this struggle. And the hypothesis of evolution even leads directly over into ethics by showing us how the struggle for existence becomes at higher stages a *common* struggle for the preservation and development of human life.

When the struggle for existence is spoken of, one is inclined to think only of the most elementary and brutal forms. But life has many forms and stages, and the struggle for existence therefore also acquires in particulars a very different character. He who works in the service of science and art, or he who struggles to keep himself up and not to deny what he holds to be right, struggles for life just as much as he who clings to bare existence and follows the physical instinct of self-preservation¹⁾. It is the business of special ethics to show what value the different stages and forms of life have in relation to one another.

7. The hypothesis of evolution not only leads *over into* ethics; with some of its most optimistic representatives it even leads beyond ethics. According to SPENCER the ethical feeling has its place only in an intermediate period of mankind's development, an intermediate period that we are of course far from having passed through. All practice brings it about that actions can be performed with less and less resistance and difficulty and with less and less express attention and exertion of will. If this is applied to the ethical life, we are compelled to assume that so much "organic morality," or involuntary capacity and need for right action, gradually accumulates in human nature that a special ethical feeling no longer makes itself felt and will no longer be necessary either, because [103]

¹⁾Cf. *Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik*. p. 30–32. — *Ethiske Undersøgelser*, p. 17–23.

harmony will have been brought about between man's instincts and what regard for the welfare of the race demands. What formerly had to be made the object of an express command of duty is now practiced instinctively and without deliberation being needed¹⁾. Actual human nature would then have acquired so ideal a character that the time of conscience would be past.

Ethics in and for itself can have nothing to object to the assumption that its time will one day be past. If it dies a happy death, that is, is replaced by a perfect and harmonious state, that is, after all, a sign that it has done its work. Perfect beings have no ethics and can have none, since ideal and reality coincide. Just as the relation of authority (in its various shapes) is replaced by the free conscience, so this in turn can be thought of as replaced by an immediate living in the good and the right. There are (as mentioned earlier) perhaps already now some natures of whom this may be said to have happened.

But even if this possibility must be granted, we are in reality so far removed from such a state that it becomes a matter of faith or a purely speculative concern whether one will assume that it ever wholly sets in, and ethics, which is loath to enter into far-reaching speculations, cannot lay great weight on it. So long as we are still in "the hobbledehoy [104] age," if not in "the embryonic state" (to use Sibbern's expression), one must not weaken attention to the great obstacles that hinder progress by such fantasies of the future. We can strengthen our hope and courage by the thought that human nature is undergoing a slow but constant change, and that there may be ground for believing that this change is an advance. But this assumption will not be able to gain any essential influence on the manner of treating ethics.

We must surely even assume that progress itself will bring with it new ideals and new tasks. Just as, by comparing the ethics of civilized man with the ethics of the savage, we find that there are great fields that in the former have been drawn under the ethical point of view while in the latter they still lie wholly unheeded, so it will probably go with our present ethics when it can one day be compared with a higher stage of development. There will surely present themselves many relations whose ethical significance we have not yet gained an eye for on account of our thick-skinnedness, our ignorance and our egoism. The ideal will rise anew each time we think we have reached the end.

SPENCER assumes (like KANT) that the feeling of duty is necessarily bound up with a feeling of compulsion and therefore of pain. But the concept of duty need imply, as remarked earlier (III, 9), only that a more limited regard is subordinated to a more comprehensive one, without this difference or opposition between a "lower" and a

¹⁾*Data of Ethics*, p. 128. 275.

“higher” *needing* to be felt as compulsion. The feeling of compulsion may fall away without the time of the feeling of duty being thereby past.

8. Can one do more than one’s duty? Can one earn merit by exceeding the demand that can ethically be made? — This question can be answered yes only from a standpoint that thinks of the ethical demand as made on man from without, either from a supernatural authority or from other men; such an external demand or expectation one can exceed, but not the inner demand of conscience. Catholicism answers yes. It distinguishes between commandments and counsels. By not only obeying the commandments but also following the counsels, man earns a special, surplus merit¹⁾. Popular ethics, which is [105] inclined to think of the ethical law in greater or less likeness to a juridical law, likewise holds fast to the difference between the dutiful and the meritorious. And the same is the case with such ethicists as are inclined to make the ethical demand one with what society or public opinion can demand (Mill and Bain)²⁾.

It is not easy to see how, if one does not stop at such an external conception of the ethical law, one will be able to hold fast to the difference between duty and merit. He in whom conscience is sufficiently developed must feel it his duty to do everything he can to further welfare in the world, and when he goes beyond the goal that others or even he himself had set, this is only a sign that the goal was not set high enough. One must not confuse what certain men expect or demand with what can really be reached. Even the highest sacrifice a man can make is his simple duty when under the [106] circumstances at hand it is really beneficial and possible. Popular ethics keeps to a certain customary average, is glad when it is reached, and admires what goes beyond it. It may be pedagogically right to attach special approval (“merit”) to actions that go beyond the usual; but he who performs such an action has nevertheless the right disposition only when he feels that he has merely done his duty, and that he stood as one who could not do otherwise. To the external spectator who comes with his average it may be admirable

¹⁾The grounding of the difference between *praeceptum* and *consilium* is, however, sometimes carried out in a way that leads precisely to the opposite result from the one intended. That it is nobler (*nobilius*) to sacrifice temporal happiness is grounded by *Cathrein* (Philos. mor. p. 208) thus: “The giving up of external goods not only removes many hindrances and dangers to salvation, but also affords constant occasion for perfect exercise in virtue.” — And it should not be a *duty* to make such a sacrifice, when one is able to? It must be a duty to realize everything of value that one is able to think and will. *It must be a duty to earn merit*, when one is able to. When one can avert “hindrances and dangers” of essential significance for oneself or for others, it would conflict with a developed feeling of duty to omit doing so. One of my hearers, a Catholic who has studied at a theological institution abroad, told me that his teacher of moral theology added to his exposition of the difference between commandment and counsel an exhortation not to make use of this distinction in practice. — Saint Teresa found no rest in her soul until she had earned all the “merit” she was able: it was her “duty” to earn “merit”! — Cf. my remarks in *Göttinger gelehrte Anzeigen*. 1896. p. 305.

²⁾Cf. my work: *Den engelske Filosofi i vor Tid*. Copenhagen 1874. p. 82 f.

to see an action that shoots far beyond it. But such an action may for all that very well have proceeded from the feeling of duty in the agent himself. The level from which the different individuals start in their judging and acting does not always lie at the same height; and from a highly developed feeling of duty and from a nature endowed with great possibilities actions may proceed that for other natures stand as more than duty. — On this point too it is the acknowledgment of the great personal differences that decides the dispute.

Even if for pedagogical reasons one would hold fast to that difference between commandment and counsel, the difference will always be relative: what at a lower stage of development stands as something that is counseled but not demanded is perhaps at a higher stage of development one of the most elementary ethical demands. For the savage it may be a meritorious action to spare the vanquished and disarmed enemy; but it belongs to the elementary commandments in the ethics of civilized nations.

V.

THE FREEDOM OF THE WILL.

1. Ethical valuation arises in the first instance as an outburst of feeling. But it has [107] its abiding significance through its motivating, will-determining force. It thereby itself becomes a contributing cause of development toward the highest welfare. It is of great importance to hold firmly to this, that conscience is itself a cause. For one thereby takes up the right standpoint toward the so often discussed question whether ethics can consent to acknowledge the validity of the law of causality for the human life of the will. One will then be able to see that ethics not only need not demand any restriction of the validity of the law of causality, but that such a restriction would be harmful to ethics itself, indeed would even make it impossible.

It is, after all, a frequent assertion that all true ethics stands and falls with the assumption that the human will is not, or at any rate not through and through, subject to the law of causality. There can, it is held, be question of moral responsibility only if man can begin a causal series absolutely afresh, i.e. can be a cause without being an effect. It is such an absolute beginning that is meant by the infelicitous expression “freedom of the will.” This expression is infelicitous already for the reason that it can be, and is, used in a whole series of different meanings, which are often confused with one another.

2. Applied to the human will the word “freedom”¹⁾ is used in at least 6 (six) different meanings.

¹⁾This word is now used predominantly in a negative sense, so that as soon as one hears it one must

a. The meaning of the word freedom with which alone the debate about “freedom of the will” is concerned is the one according to which a “free” will is not subject to the law of causality, is not a member of the causal series like other phenomena, but is a cause without being an effect. One might call freedom in this meaning of the word “freedom from causation.” It is about this that the dispute stands, determinism denying it, indeterminism assuming it. What one is free from, then, is here: everything. To will [108] freely is to will *without cause*, independently of everything that has gone before.

b. Freedom can next mean merely *the absence of external compulsion*. Here, then, not all causes are excluded, but only those that lie outside the willing personality. He is free whose resolve is not hindered by external force from passing over into action. It is thus freedom of action rather than freedom of will that is in question here. I have freedom to go out of my room when I have the key in my pocket and the door is not barred; in the opposite case I am unfree and must stay where I am.

c. Freedom can also be a *freedom from internal compulsion*. One often calls unfree the willing that springs from pain or from fear, as opposed to the willing that springs from pleasure or hope. Even if the door stands open, I perhaps do not go out, because I fear being attacked by a lurking enemy. In such cases I do not do what I have a mind to; I feel a hindrance that makes me not act with the whole and full assent of my mind. “You build yourself a house,” says Augustine, “because otherwise you would have no dwelling. It is then necessity, not your free will, that makes you will.” The “free” will in this sense we often call in daily speech our “good” will. That I do not do something with my “good” will means that I do it reluctantly, do it, but with a strong feeling of pain, do it because I prefer a lesser evil to a greater evil. He who hands over his money to the robber who threatens his life does it deliberately and by a conscious act of will; but he can say: “I have willed it — but under compulsion” (*coactus volui*, as an old Roman jurist already aptly expressed it)¹⁾.

d. In the fourth place the “freedom” of the will can mean the will’s *ability, strength and competence*. The question here is *how much* the will can accomplish, not whether it is dependent on or independent of what has gone before. One can be an indeterminist, that is, hold that the will is not conditioned by anything preceding, and yet assume that this causeless will plays a very small part in the world. And one can be a determinist, [109] that is, hold that the will is through and through conditioned by what goes before, and

ask: “Freedom from what?” This negative sense is, however, hardly the original one. *Steinthal (Allgemeine Ethik*. Berlin 1885. p. 356 f.) remarks of the word “frei”: “It comes from a root that means to tend, to spare, to show affection, to love and to make oneself loved. Free, then, is dear.” The word is related to words such as *Freund*, *Freude*, *Friede*.

¹⁾Cf. *Jhering: Der Zweck im Recht*. I. 2. Aufl. p. 17.

yet assume that this causally determined will plays an extraordinarily great part in the world. In the famous dispute between AUGUSTINE and PELAGIUS the question was rather of the strength and competence of the will (the natural human will)¹⁾ than of the will's relation to the proposition that everything has its cause. The question was, after all, to decide whether man needed supernatural help in order to act well, — that is, whether human nature had *sufficient* motives at its disposal, not whether motives were needed *at all*. The same point of dispute was taken up again, as is well known, at the time of the Reformation. In the Augsburg Confession (I, 18), accordingly, the words strength or ability (*vis*) and freedom (*libertas*) are used as synonymous. — How easily one can confuse this meaning of the word with the first-named (freedom from causation) is seen from the use indeterminists frequently make of the word “ability.” They then speak of freedom as the ability to begin absolutely afresh. But if they distinguish between the actual beginning itself and the ability to begin, then the will, the actual willing, becomes dependent after all, namely on its “ability.” According to the strict indeterministic line of thought nothing may go before the “free” willing, not even the ability. For if any meaning is to be attached to the word ability, it means the conditions in our nature that must be present for us to be able to perform a certain activity. Ability to will can [110] reasonably mean, after all, only the inner conditions for a willing to be able to occur.

e. Very frequently by the “freedom” of the will one understands *freedom of choice*, the ability to choose. A choice by no means presupposes the invalidity of the law of causality. It presupposes only that one has ideas of different possible actions which one deliberates, that is to say, *compares* with one another. The decision as to which of the actions is to be performed then depends not on momentary prompting or isolated affects, but is determined through an inner debate between a multiplicity of ideas and feelings. “Freedom” here means not the opposite of necessity, but *the opposite of blindness*. Through freedom of choice a deeper, more composite necessity shows itself than in the action called forth by momentary affects and impulses. The “free” will here means the mature, self-conscious will, which yet in the moment of choice says: “I can do no other!” To the external spectator it may look as if man at such a moment could “just as well”

¹⁾Augustine maintained that the human will is at variance with itself and is not able to let itself be lifted up by the truth. “The soul commands itself to will, and it would not command it if it did not already will! And yet what it commands does not happen; but neither does it will with its whole being (*ex toto*), and therefore it does not command with its whole being either. . . . If the will were complete (*plena*), it would not command that it should be, for then it would already be! It is a sickness of the soul; for the soul does not rise in its wholeness: it is supported by truth, to be sure, but it is weighed down by habit. There are, then, two wills, since neither of them is complete; what the one has, the other lacks. . . . It was I myself who willed, and it was I myself who did not will, and I was torn asunder in my inmost being.” *Confessiones*. VIII, 9–10.

have willed the opposite, — as if, for example, Luther at Worms could “just as well” have pronounced a retraction. But for one who knew Luther’s character and everything that moved within him, it must have stood as an impossibility that he could have willed otherwise than he did. The external spectator does not know the inner conditions that turn the scale. And it is in a purely external way that the popular conception as a rule regards the will.

He who knows only one possibility cannot choose, “has no choice.” The cause of his knowing only one possibility may be very various. It may be limited experience, neglect to use the experiences he has had, momentary indisposition, passion, enfeeblement, or downright insanity. By such causes it can also be explained when the different possibilities do not present themselves in deliberation with the degree of clearness they would otherwise have. But all this precedes the choice. Whether a choice can take place depends, then, on what has gone before. Freedom of choice does not conflict with determinism, and it is not about it that the dispute stands.

f. Finally the word freedom can designate the will as the will that is guided by ethical [111] motives. In this meaning of the word only the good man is free. What is presupposed here is such a spiritual development and practice that conscience can come to play a decisive part in every deliberation and resolve. But this obviously presupposes in its turn that there exists a psychological causal connection. On a call or occasion for action, conscience must then — by virtue of the laws of the connection of ideas with one another and with the feelings — be capable of being awakened. Freedom here means that certain thoughts and feelings have become dominant and have displaced others. Freedom here stands *in opposition to bondage under the dominion of sensuous and egoistic impulses and passions*. This is sometimes called the true or the higher freedom. This meaning of the word is the oldest; it derives from Socrates (or Antisthenes?) and is used by Augustine, Spinoza and others. It has nothing whatever to do with the dispute between determinism and indeterminism.

It is only the first-named meaning that we have use for in this connection, however significant the others may also be in other respects.

3. It is now granted, I suppose, by most that it is not theoretical but practical-ethical motives that lead to the assertion that our will is not subject to the law of causality. If one regarded the will merely as a psychologist or historian, one would hardly hit upon setting up such an assertion. There would always be many utterances of will for which one could find no explanation; but this would contain no ground for asserting that they had no cause. On the other hand it is held that such an assertion is a necessary presupposition

of ethics. Should this really be the case? Should we be obliged to acknowledge such a disharmony between our intellectual and our ethical nature that, in order not to deny the validity of the ethical, we must deny the principle by virtue of which alone existence can become intelligible to us? — We must at least look carefully before we enter upon so desperate a conception. It is not everyone who finds it so very easy to push aside the
 [112] postulate of causality and set up other postulates in its place, much as one takes off one's everyday coat to put on an evening dress.

I shall then try to show the untenability of indeterminism¹⁾ and to show that determinism is even an indispensable presupposition of ethics.

a. Indeterminism tears apart the bond between the individual and the race, indeed between the individual and the whole of the rest of existence. The individual no longer stands as a peculiar member of the great connection of existence, but is torn out of it precisely at the most decisive points. It therefore becomes impossible for indeterminism to conceive existence as a whole. Every deeper-going philosophical or religious view becomes impossible. The only religious view compatible with indeterminism is polytheism; for every being that can absolutely begin a causal series is a little god (or a little devil), an absolute being, and we thus get as many gods as there are "free" men. Perhaps one does not care so very much about such a comprehensive view either. But the consideration put forward here has its significance nevertheless, especially when determinism is attacked
 [113] as a godless or antireligious doctrine. If one conceives the Godhead as an absolute and almighty being, the assumption of a causeless will in finite beings becomes downright self-contradictory. And if one protests against this and maintains that we here stand before a "mystery," then one must see to it how one can distinguish between mystery and self-contradiction¹⁾.

¹⁾In our own literature indeterminism has been defended by Heegaard (*Om Intolerance*. 1878), Wilkens (*Sociologi*. 1882), Kroman (*Vor Naturerkendelse*. 1883), H. Scharling (*Kristelig Sædelære*. 1884). — When one (like the last author) holds that there is a "higher mediation" of determinism and indeterminism, I am unable to discuss this question, simply because I cannot attach any meaning to it. *Either* the law of causality holds for the will, *or* it does not hold. What third can there be? — On Prof. Kroman's standpoint on this problem in the 2nd edition of his *Tænke- og Sjælelære* I must refer to my *Psykologiske Undersøgelser*. (Vidensk. Selsk. Skrifter 6. Række) p. 99–103. In his most recent statement on this question Prof. Kroman finds the possibility of a partly causeless willing by distinguishing between the central and the peripheral in man (or between man's "essence" and his "character"). *Begrebet "det Etske"*. (University programme. Nov. 1903.) p. 87. But here the problem comes again: Is the central or the "essence" always the same? Did "I myself" produce it in the first place? Can it be released into activity equally easily at every moment? And is it always good if it is released?

¹⁾It is hardly historically correct when Kroman (*Vor Naturerkendelse*. p. 256) holds that antireligious feeling has as a rule taken the side of determinism. One might rather assert the opposite; at least the rationalistic tendencies have usually taken the side of indeterminism (cf. Pelagius against Augustine, Erasmus against Luther, the Arminians against the orthodox Calvinists). When Kroman himself declares that a mathematical world-formula is impossible if man has free will (p. 257), he must also grant that it is self-contradictory at once to believe in an omniscient God and to assume the will's freedom from

b. Indeterminists commit a significant confusion of two different meanings of the word freedom when they express themselves now so that the will has *no cause*, now so that we ourselves are the cause of our acts of will. The second, fourth and fifth meanings are here mixed up with the first. For when “we ourselves” are the cause of our acts of will, our will is not free from causation, but has its cause in our nature. “We ourselves” are at every moment not something “abstract,” but something quite definite, namely the definite thoughts and feelings, dispositions, instincts and impulses that stir in us; in them, then, the origin of the acts of will must be sought. The two concepts, self-determination and freedom from causation, which are often regarded as identical, in reality cancel one another as soon as one attaches a definite meaning to the word “self.”

The indeterminist perhaps answers to this: “I mean precisely that in the causal series we must stop at man himself. If we go further, and let his will [and nature?] too have a cause, then the last cause of his resolve comes to lie far beyond himself; therefore he himself is not the cause.” To this one need only answer that in this way there would be no causes at all in the world. It would then not be the lightning that killed the man, [114] but the causes (the electricity of the air, etc.) that called forth the lightning; but these again would not really be causes of the lightning — and so on in an infinite series. This consideration has its interest; but why does one apply it only to the will? — Every thing and every being in the world is both effect and cause. The more peculiar and the more richly endowed a being is, the more conditions it presupposes, and the more effects can proceed from it. It will appear that ethics can very well, indeed that it must, adopt this way of looking at things.

When self-determination is set in particular opposition to inertia, it must be well noted that precisely the most significant acts of will of all are performed in enthusiasm, in devotion, in absorption in great ideas, and in immersion in thoughts that the individual has not itself consciously produced, at any rate not at the very moment when the act of will takes place. It is, after all, never the naked and abstract self that wills something. The self that wills has been torn out of its state of equilibrium by something that finds points of attachment in it, to be sure, but of whose working the self is not the only cause.

c. If the act of will, or a part of it, is not subject to the law of causality, it stands as something *isolated and accidental* in relation to the whole personality. It does not become flesh of its flesh, blood of its blood. It is not only existence that indeterminism cannot conceive as a whole; in the single personality either the coherence cannot be preserved. It is a strange fate that indeterminism here suffers. It thinks it is asserting the dignity of

causation. For the omniscient God must be summus mathematicus and be able to foretell everything with absolute exactness.

man against determinism, which according to its assertion makes man a mere machine, — and then it comes itself to make man into something far meaner than a machine, into something incoherent and accidental. When one and the same motive, without any change having taken place in the inner or outer circumstances under which one acts, is followed now by one resolve, now by another, in what then does this “freedom” really differ from capriciousness and chance? What value will one be able to attribute to it at [115] all? And how can one, under such presuppositions, go on speaking of a man’s having a certain character?

d. The ethical judgment on my conduct builds on the action’s really being my action. Therefore the ethical judgment is clear and definite only where the psychological connection between motives and resolve lies plain to view. The less my action can be understood from knowledge of my character and my circumstances, the sooner shall I be regarded as not accountable, and the less shall I be able to hold myself responsible. By giving up the causal connection in the life of the will I give up precisely the mark of accountability!

The juridical way of looking at things agrees here with the ethical. The penal code regards agitated state of mind and lack of premeditation as extenuating circumstances, repetition, relapse and clear premeditation as aggravating circumstances. At the basis of this way of looking at things lies the conception that a criminal act of will must be punished the more severely, the greater the connection in which it proves to stand with the man’s whole character. Although the juridical judgment is concerned essentially with the external action, not with the inner disposition, it is nevertheless necessary for the judge to gain insight into the motives and origin of the action. And that not only in order to be able to determine the degree of the punishment, but also in order to be able to have a completely sure conviction that the action has really been committed. The better the judge understands how the action sprang necessarily from the inner and outer circumstances at hand, the more sure he can be that the individual has really committed the action¹⁾.

e. When several recent writers (Heegaard, Kroman) hold that the postulate of freedom from causation can be restricted to the least possible, to “a very small quantity, a trifle,” it is not easy to understand what significance it can have that so small a part of the act of will is free from causation, since it is, after all, *the act of will as a whole* that [116] the ethical judgment concerns. One sees that indeterminism, which first dissolves the

¹⁾Cf. my *Psykologi* VII B, 4. — Anselm v. Feuerbach (*Aktenmässige Darstellung merkwürdiger Verbrechen*. Giessen 1829. II. p. 502 f.) maintains that a judge ought not to pass a sentence of death when he has not understood *how* the action came into being.

coherence of existence and next the coherence of the personality, ends by not even conceiving the single act of will as a whole. Certain per cent of its elements are to be causally determined, others free from causation. We are not told whether the causeless component is equally large in all acts of will of the same individual and in acts of will of different individuals, nor how he who holds himself responsible, let alone he who is to judge others, can discover how large the component is, and whether it is there in the single case. But even apart from this the assumption stands as something most strange.

If, as has been said¹⁾, it is “the Achilles’ heel of determinism” that the individual after every base action would have the right to say: “It was necessary, therefore it is not my fault!” — then it is not easy to see how the indeterminism that assumes only an insignificant part of the action to be free from causation (and which to that extent can also be called, and calls itself, a relative determinism) can avoid being struck by the same difficulty, if indeed it is present at all. The individual will then rightly say: “Only a *thousandth* of my action am I to blame for, since only so much of it is free from causation! Why, then, am I held responsible for the *whole* action? I have committed no murder, but only the thousandth part of a murder!” — The most consistent thing, however, would be to admit the impossibility of determining how far a man was accountable for a single definite action. This consequence KANT draws in one passage, where he declares that “how *large a part* of our character is the pure effect of freedom, and how large a part can be ascribed to mere nature and to the unmerited faults or fortunate constitution of temperament, no one can fathom”; therefore “the real morality of actions remains wholly hidden from us.” (*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*¹ p. 551). —

That modest indeterminism is prevented precisely by its modesty from attaining what it wishes to attain, and it attempts the impossible thing of making a weight of a [117] hundredweight hang from a cobweb. If responsibility really stands and falls with freedom from causation, then we must assume that the agent could just as well have omitted the *whole* act of will, the whole action.

That kind of modesty usually enters into the history of theories at the point where their vitality and self-confidence have vanished, and where the enemy has already been let into one’s own camp without one’s being conscious of it. The old assertions then hold on for a time still, like rudimentary organs; but it is an illusion to think that they really perform any function.

f. The words *responsibility*, *guilt* and *accountability* are, like so many other ethical expressions, carried over from the juridical to the ethical field, or rather, derive from

¹⁾Kroman: *Vor Naturerkendelse*. p. 246.

a time when the difference between these two fields did not yet properly make itself felt. That I am held responsible or regarded as accountable for an action means that I stand as the one to whom reward or punishment for the action is allotted. *Why* the action is rewarded or punished is a question by itself. It is, as already shown (IV, 4), not at all self-evident that an action is to be rewarded or punished. But even if we accept the theory of retribution and regard it as self-evident, it is not at all necessary that the will held responsible should be the *absolutely first* cause, should begin a causal series absolutely afresh. Retribution demands only that there be *someone to lay hold of*, and there is, once the origin of the action in a human will has been established. The primitive instinct of retribution does not even go so far back; it is satisfied if only a man of the same family or tribe as the perpetrator suffers for the action, and it demands satisfaction whether there is present a really *willed* action or not. The idea of individual guilt and individual accountability has slowly worked its way forward. But the demand that the individual will shall have no cause derives from a metaphysical speculation into which neither the primitive instinct nor the ethical feeling of guilt enters.

[118] Why, then, do we not in our ethical feeling of guilt go further back than to the will? Why does ethics stop here and leave everything that goes before to psychology? — This question is here to be answered from a purely ethical standpoint. Juridical responsibility can first be treated when, in the doctrine of the state, we come to the grounding of the punitive authority of the state.

Ethically regarded, the feeling of guilt, responsibility or accountability can mean only that I feel my action subject to the judgment of conscience. The inner sanction (IV, 4) comes into force. The presupposition of this is that I am conscious of having really willed the action. I impute it to myself because it is nothing foreign to me, but would not be in the world without my resolve. I bear the guilt because I have willed. When I now perceive the conflict between the act of will I own and what I recognize as right, there arises *the feeling of remorse*, a feeling of inner disharmony, unworthiness and self-contempt, which can rise to the highest spiritual pain. It arises as a feeling of contrast, called forth by the opposition between my actual willing and my acknowledgment of the ideal. This feeling arises under the conditions indicated with psychological necessity.

From a deterministic standpoint too one may very well define remorse as “dissatisfaction with oneself at not having acted otherwise”¹⁾. Such dissatisfaction is only another form of the lively wish, arising in the moment of remorse, that one had after all acted otherwise, a wish that, as I shall show directly, has its great practical significance. Such

¹⁾Kroman: *Vor Naturerkendelse*. p. 243.

a wish arises naturally when in *the moment of reflection* one submits one's willing and acting to a serious test and finds that it cannot stand it. But from this wish and the dissatisfaction it awakens one cannot infer that in *the moment of action* one could just as well have acted quite otherwise than one actually did. In many perhaps this illusion arises; but they then merely date the dearly bought experience they have gained through error and remorse back to an earlier moment²⁾.

But with the psychological explanation of remorse its ethical value and grounding [119] are not yet given. Remorse is a feeling of pain, and it is only from an absolutely ascetic standpoint that pain is in and for itself something good. Why should I not seek as quickly as possible to forget my reprehensible action, just as I naturally seek to keep unpleasant memories away? When Hamlet has awakened his mother's conscience, she says: "O Hamlet, thou hast cleft my heart in twain!" And he answers:

O, throw away the worser part of it,
And live the purer with the other half!

Why does ethics hold that it cannot go so briskly as Hamlet thinks, but that the pain of remorse has its great significance?

It is not because it holds the principle "like for like," or "an eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth." The doctrine of retribution is no ethical doctrine. Ethics cannot see in remorse "God's terrible and unspeakable wrath," as MELANCHTHON calls it, nor, with the Catholics, see a penance or atonement in it. — A more thorough criticism of the doctrine of retribution than is contained in the remarks already put forward will find a better occasion in the inquiry into the punitive authority of the state. Here I shall confine myself to a single point that is of particular interest in this connection. — According to the doctrine of retribution, remorse (where it is the only punishment) would have to be strongest in him who has committed the greatest crime. But in fact it is not, and this finds its psychological explanation in the fact that remorse rests on a relation of contrast between the ideal and the actual willing, a relation of contrast that of course cannot come into being except where the idea of the ideal becomes living. The more living and developed this idea is, the more actions will be regarded in its light, and the more sharply they will be judged. Therefore the feeling of remorse is often strongest in the purest and best characters. There is a psychological truth in the tale of Queen Dagmar, who found no rest in death because she had laced her sleeves on a Sunday. Against a snow-white background spots are seen that would otherwise not be noticed.

²⁾Psykologi VII B, 5 b (conclusion). — A more detailed demonstration of the ways in which the idea of a causeless willing can arise I have given in my *Psykologiske Undersøgelser*, p. 92—99.

[120] Psychologically regarded, remorse appears — like duty, seen from another side (III, 9) — as the expression of the personality's striving to preserve its unity and coherence. Remorse presupposes that consciousness of the good has been awakened, which it perhaps was not at the moment of action, or else that it has been heightened in kind or range or both, a higher ethical stage having been reached. Pity is felt for the victim of the action, and one feels the value of the interests that have been injured. Remorse is thus already a sign that the good is about to prevail in man. But the pain of remorse is caused by the consciousness of the actual willing and acting standing in the sharpest conflict with the consciousness of the ideal. Therefore DANTE says (*Purgatorio* XXXI) that Beatrice, i.e. the ideal thought, was the cause of the pain that "the nettles of remorse" caused him. In spite of this painful inner opposition, which shows man his own soul in an entirely different light from before, he strives to preserve the connection with his past. He can neither let go of the new I nor deny the old I: both together make up his own I. He recognizes — in spite of the new I — honestly and without reserve himself as the cause of the earlier acting. Through this constant striving to identify himself with himself and to make the old and the new I cover one another by trying to think them together, the contrast is felt all the more strongly. Only in the form of pain can the personality here assert its unity. But the attempts at covering may lead to a purification, a fusion, whereby the new I prevails, but is at the same time enriched by the experience man has had of his limit. The consciousness of the ideal becomes all the more inward as the oppositions of life have been tried at a depth to which those whose development runs more in a straight and unbroken line do not reach down¹⁾. What is acquired through such a purgatory has a firmness that is not easily won in any other way. The energy that blindness formerly took into its service may now, through a metamorphosis, come to

[121] work in an entirely different direction. In this way remorse bears witness to the causality of the personality and to the conservation of psychic energy. Already BRÖCHNER has (in his work *Det Religiøse i dets Enhed med det Humane*. 1869. p. 157. 172) expressed this conception of remorse: "The preceding life is joined together through remorse with the present into a continuous, intensive whole of life." "In the transformation of force, here as in the domain of the physical, the sum of force is abiding."¹⁾

Only in the express consciousness of the character of the earlier state does one have the sign that one is beyond it. If the will to bear the opposition between the old and the new slackens, the metamorphosis and the firm founding of the new character do

¹⁾This development is illustrated by the laws of the connection and fusion of feelings developed in my *Psykologi* VI B, 2 d and e, and might itself have been cited there as an example.

¹⁾Cf. already *Giordano Bruno* (*Den nyere Filosofis Historie*² I. p. 141 f.).

not take place. He who cannot bear to think of his earlier conduct, — he who cannot pass through the purgatory of self-knowledge, — is still entangled in his past, just as the insane man is not fully cured if he will not admit that he has been insane. There is of course question here only of the judgment the single person holds within himself; it is not said that anyone else has the right to settle his accounts for him. — Where the boundary lies between the necessary self-knowledge and morbid brooding over what cannot be otherwise belongs to the very hardest questions in life; no general formula can instruct us about it. Melancholy natures easily come — by virtue of the expansion of feeling²⁾ — to regard themselves as more guilty than they are. Activity is thereby paralyzed, and the impulse to progress is cowed³⁾.

For the ethical significance of the penetrating consciousness of the reprehensibility [122] of the action, which the pain of remorse partly presupposes, partly awakens, is that of acting as a spur and driving forward. An attention is called forth for things one formerly passed by blind and hard. There rises an impulse to reach a higher stage, a craving that springs naturally from the painful contradiction that is felt. Only by being a *motive* is remorse of an ethical nature. It is a means for future development. Ethics looks forward, not back, or rather, it looks back only in order to be able to look forward all the better. Ethical judgments are, as has been remarked several times in the foregoing, in the first instance outbursts of feeling at the sight or memory of an action. This they continue to be, however well they are grounded. But the pronouncing of such a judgment is justified only where it can be a cause, a motive to continued or changed willing. Neither toward ourselves nor toward others have we the right to judge when the judgment cannot act as a motive. A great part of the difficulties many find in reconciling ethics and determinism derives from the Old Testament way in which they conceive concepts such as responsibility and accountability. Only he ought to be held responsible in whom the settling of accounts can become a motive — a deterring or an encouraging motive. If the popular conception means something else by the words remorse, responsibility, accountability, etc., then they are untenable concepts that it has formed.

In the wish to have acted otherwise and in the pain of not having done so one perhaps acknowledges something that in its time made itself felt during deliberation, but could not

²⁾Psychologi VI F, 4.

³⁾There is often an egoistic sentimentality in brooding remorse and petty self-accusation. *Goethe* tells (in one of his conversations with Eckermann) of a little boy who could not be calmed over a little fault he had committed. "It was disagreeable to me," says Goethe, "to notice this; for it testifies to an all too tender conscience, which values its own self so highly that it will not forgive it anything. Such a conscience produces hypochondriac men if it is not counterbalanced by a great activity." In *Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre* (IV, 12) it is said: "Die Eigenliebe lässt uns sowohl unsere Tugenden als unsere Fehler viel bedeutender, als sie sind, erscheinen." — Cf. also my remarks in *Rousseau og hans Filosofi*, p. 13 f. —

then gain power. We see here the great significance of the inner debate before the resolve. Even if the impulses and promptings that had right on their side had to succumb, this struggle has perhaps not been in vain. They may have made the equilibrium less stable, [123] even if they could not wholly overcome the resistance to movement in the direction in which they point. But the work they have done need not go to waste. They rise again when the mind has become calmer, and by contrast they may now perhaps gain the power they formerly lacked, or they get help and supplementing from new promptings and impulses that on their side would not alone be able to determine the will.

g. If the law of causality did not hold in the spiritual domain, ethical striving would be hopeless. Only where conformity to law prevails can my will intervene in such a way that something is accomplished. That we can intervene in external nature and make it obey our ends is made possible by our knowing the laws of nature and knowing what conditions we must procure in order to attain what we will. We stand in a similar way toward human nature. Only if conformity to law prevails can we change it at the points where it conflicts with our ideals. What matters is to procure motives of the right kind and strength, and this must happen by virtue of the psychological laws of nature. But what would every possible effort avail if one and the same motive under the same circumstances were followed now by one resolve, now by quite another? *What has no cause, I cannot prepare*; toward it I stand as toward the accidental and capricious. I have command of my future willing only if there is a causal relation between my present and my future willing. Then what I now sow as a seed may grow into a vigorous plant.

We now understand why responsibility does not go further back in the causal series than to the will. It is because it is the will that is to be changed. What lies before the act of will interests us, ethically regarded, only insofar as it has influence on the will. Only indirectly, therefore, are we held responsible for our thoughts and feelings, namely insofar as they are will-determining forces. The extent to which they are to be drawn in will of course be very different in the different cases.

Out of nothing comes nothing. This proposition ethics must for its own sake let hold. What matters is to awaken and nourish wishes and impulses of the right kind in myself [124] and others. How far the single person can get in the single case, only experience and trial can convince him.

h. A few words should still be given to throwing light on the strange assertion that the determinist must consistently stand as a mere spectator of life, both of his own and of others' life. As if one cannot feel joy or sorrow at life and desire to intervene in it because one assumes that it is subject to definite laws! If my responsibility gives me no time at all

to think, I cannot of course be a determinist. But then I cannot be an indeterminist either. For one becomes that, too, only by thinking. Indeterminism is just as much a theory as determinism, and there are those for whom it demands the greatest intellectual effort to make out what indeterminism really means. If I am at every moment absorbed in practice, I cannot theorize. The tiller of the soil gets no time to study chemistry when he is to plow and harrow without interruption. It is not, of course, everyone whose lot it is to study psychology and history. There may be natures in whom the constant interest in finding the causes of their own and others' actions can weaken the practical interest. But then it is only the general opposition between theoretical and practical natures that we stand before. Everyone must here see to how much room he gives theory in his spiritual household. It is of course unethical to appear as a mere inquirer where action is called for. Who, however zealous a physicist he may be, would study the nature of the effects of light while he stood at the deathbed of one of his dear ones? But will one therefore say that physics and love exclude one another? I cannot (whether I am an indeterminist or a determinist) study the psychology of the will at the same moment as I am to act; but because I cannot do two different things at the same time, these two things need not therefore logically conflict with one another. I cannot at one and the same time stand on my feet and on my head; but I can (perhaps) do the one first, the other later.

One presupposition, to be sure, lies at the basis of the whole ethical consideration, whether it is deterministic or indeterministic, namely that existence is not completed, finished or perfect, but that there is a work to be done for human willing. The human will must be one of the causes on which the development of the world depends. What weight it has in relation to other causes only experience can teach; but it must not be nil if an ethics is to be possible. Every ethics that stands on the ground of reality is a doctrine of how tendencies of development that express themselves in more elementary forms in the external life of nature can be carried further in the human mind. The course of the world must in part take place through human willing, and every attempt at a conclusive world-view must also take this factor into account¹⁾. [125]

VI.

ETHICAL EVIL.

1. What ethical evil follows already from what has been developed earlier (III, 6; 10; 20). It consists in a more or less conscious isolation of the single moment from the whole

¹⁾Cf. below VII, 1 and 4 and XXXI, 3, as well as my *Filosofiske Problemer* (University programme Nov. 1902). III, 5 and IV, 2.

of the individual's life, and of the single individual from the whole of the life of the race. From this there follows not merely a resistance to what the welfare of the individual or of the race requires, but also a slackening of energy and a dissolution of coherence in the individual or in the race. — We shall here go a little more closely into the psychological causes of this isolation.

Two causes explain the tragic disproportion that is designated by the concept of evil. First, *the sporadic character of development*, which consists in this, that the single faculties in the single personality and the single individuals within the race do not develop simultaneously, nor equally strongly and quickly, but in such a way that now [126] the one element, now the other, comes forward with the greatest energy; thereby the possibility arises that they do not come to fit harmoniously into the larger whole, but even offer definite resistance to it. This disharmony can arise in two forms. It may be that the single element (the single faculty in the individual, the single individual in the race) carries on with energy a tendency that has developed beforehand. By virtue of a kind of inertia it goes on existing and working as before, although other demands must now be made on it from the side of the whole than before. Or it may be that the single element involuntarily varies, strikes into new directions, precisely because life stirs in it so vigorously that it must have a more ample outlet than before, — but that no possibility now appears of finding a connection into which the new might enter and gain value. What at first seemed to make an entirely new stage of life possible now becomes a break in the coherence of life, something twisted and distorted. — Neither the conserving nor the varying tendency can be done without; but both contain the possibility of a break with the coherence of life and of an injury to the fundamental will that valuation presupposes. They are forces that involuntarily will the good, but often work evil. They can lead to isolation, so that the part sets itself in the place of the whole, because it will not change its state — whether this be essentially continuation or constant variation.

The second cause lies in this, that *the involuntary precedes the voluntary*, the unconscious or dimly conscious precedes the clearly conscious. The thought that can guide must first be won, and is often won only through error. One often becomes wise only through harm. Zeus, says Aeschylus, has laid down the law that wisdom is won only through suffering (πάθει μάθος). The individual weaves itself into life without knowing into what connection it is entering. And the first thought itself arises involuntarily: the transition from the involuntary to the voluntary must of course take place involuntarily. The first ends man sets himself he sets without deliberation:

[127] How the first knowledge comes to be awakened

No man can tell, nor know whence it wells up,
 Nor how his desires first came to life.
 As the honey-making urge shows itself in a bee,
 So came they to him; that *first thought of the will*
 Deserves no praise, and no blame either.
 (Dante: *Purgatorio* XVIII).

And yet this “first thought” can become decisive for the direction of the whole of life. It becomes the point of departure of the life of thought, the first center of association, which determines the course and kind of the following thoughts. But there is no certainty that the direction thereby given agrees with the highest interests of life.

Isolation and blindness, then, are the two features that evil presents, when we regard it in its possibility. Evil is the inertia that will not change its state, the heaviness that will not let itself be lifted, the narrowness that will not let itself be widened. It is the full opposite of the motive of valuation that was presupposed in the foregoing: for sympathy is a need to impart, to make oneself one with others, to open oneself to the world. — Greek ethics laid most weight on the blindness that awakens arrogance and insolence (ὕβρις). HOMER and THE TRAGEDIANS conceived the origin of sin as infatuation (ἄτη), SOCRATES downright as ignorance. The ethics of modern times stresses most the isolation proceeding from inertia. So SPINOZA and J. G. FICHTE. The latter thinker shows in his interesting psychological development¹⁾ how out of inertia, as resistance to going beyond the given state and direction, there can arise cowardice and falseness, since one would rather give up one’s freedom than take up the struggle, and since one, when there must nevertheless be a struggle, would rather use cunning than honest [128] weapons. For both thinkers ethical evil is the opposite of spiritual strength and freedom. This spiritual freedom was for them closely connected with social life, and thereby evil became indirectly also a break in social harmony, an injury to the common striving for freedom. But at the standpoint on which we have here taken our stand (III, 8–11), ethical evil must be characterized directly by its antisocial character, by the absence of the motives and qualities that make spiritual community possible, not merely of those that make spiritual freedom possible.

When the consciousness of the opposition to a higher stage of life arises (which,

¹⁾J. G. Fichte: *Sittenlehre*. 1798. p. 262 ff. See my book *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². II. p. 150 f. — For Spinoza sin was a spiritual impotence (*Tract. polit.* II, 7. 11. 20), which formed the opposite of the way in which the impulse of self-assertion is able to carry man’s development forward from lower to higher forms (*Ethica*. III, 6 ff.). See *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². I. p. 325–327. — F. C. Sibbern has in his *Psychologie* (1856) p. 119 and in his *Moralfilosofi* (1878) p. 7–11 applied his doctrine of the sporadic course of all development to the problem of evil.

however, one of course does not acknowledge as higher), and the stage once entered upon is nevertheless held fast, inertia rises to *defiance*. The contrast here works to fix and to provoke, and increases the resistance. The standpoint is shaped into a system that can be held fast with strict consistency. When such an isolating stage is called evil, this valuation is made from another ethical system than the one acknowledged by him who stands at that stage. Every standpoint asserts its right to be, sets its valuation against every other valuation. Here, then, we have in the sharpest form the struggle between ethical systems that we earlier (III, 13) considered from a purely theoretical point of view. It is the great struggle in the world, in which what on one side is stamped as inertia, isolation, blindness and defiance is declared on the other side to be the outcome of natural and justified self-assertion, or perhaps even the germs of new advances. In this struggle it is not merely thought that stands against thought, but passion against passion, and will against will. At the foundation of all ethical valuation there lies, after all, a fundamental will, an activity that sets ends. Where valuation stands against valuation, it is the most fundamental forces of spiritual life that have risen up against one another.

Philosophical ethics stands toward this struggle otherwise than theological ethics does. It learns from psychology and history how standpoints and systems come into being, and how they successively unfold out of elements that have their justified place in [129] the connection of life. This successive unfolding of the standpoints that are rejected and are to be overcome, consistent theological ethics cannot accept. It does not acknowledge the simple truth that the involuntary precedes the voluntary, and that the parts do not always join together into a whole. Sin is for it *pride*, — just as obedience is the sum of all virtue. When man isolates himself, tears himself loose from the source of all good, the cause is to be sought in his arrogance. Whence arrogance and pride in turn arise we are not told; but from Augustine¹⁾ onward they stand at the head of all vices. While the development of sin according to the philosophical conception proceeds from the unconscious and involuntary to the conscious and voluntary, as experience shows it to us in all development of the soul, it becomes the task of theological ethics to show how the less conscious and voluntary forms of evil develop out of the most conscious

¹⁾*De civitate dei*. XIV, 12–13. (Malæ voluntatis initium quæ potest esse nisi superbia?) *De moribus eccl. cath.* c. 12. — See *Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik*. p. 137–141. — Beside the strong stress on pride as the origin of the evil will there goes in Augustine the strong emphasis on sensual desire (concupiscentia), which reveals itself especially in the sexual impulse. Since this stirs independently of the will, it is clear that nature is corrupt, and since the propagation of the race takes place precisely through the act of generation accomplished with sensual desire, it is no wonder that mankind has become a chaos of sin (massa peccati). Cf. A. Harnack: *Lehrbuch der Dogmengeschichte*.³ II. p. 29. But it is nevertheless Augustine's express doctrine that it is the proud will that has corrupted nature, so that evil thereafter arises involuntarily and rules the will. *De civ. dei* XIV, 3–6.

and voluntary. In medieval ethics an attempt was made to explain the seven capital sins genetically, so that out of pride there successively develop envy, hatred, sloth (*acedia*), avarice, intemperance and lust²⁾. Even if interesting observations are woven into this account, it is nevertheless built on a psychological impossibility. F. C. SIBBERN has [130] rightly said that theological ethics derives evil from the highest evil. That is to turn the matter upside down. Only through a series of stages of development does unconscious inertia, which may be beneficial, rise to a conscious rejection of every attempt to draw the individual out of its isolation. Only at the culmination of the resistance begun by inertia does the individual make everything else a means to its enjoyment or its feeling of power. Instead of being one among several, it has now attempted to make itself an absolute end. In particulars it is so far from being the case that only one single series of development can be run through here, that a great multiplicity of ways presents itself to psychological inquiry.

The more special forms of evil will depend on the general dispositions of feeling or temperaments that the single individuals bring with them from the first. The dark temperament leads, in passive natures, to dejection, despondency and unreceptiveness. The individual withdraws from everything that would lay claim to it, especially also from enlivening and awakening influences. In active natures, given this temperament, there arise malice and envy, harshness and cruelty. One feels others' pleasure and happiness as a jarring disharmony, or regards it as the expression of stupidity and shortsightedness. There is an inclination to be touched by everything in a painful way, and the frequency of the feelings of pain easily produces egoism through the attention [131] the individual is compelled to direct upon itself. Pain hinders it from devotion, hinders it from forgetting itself. — The bright temperament leads, in the form of passivity, to a craving for enjoyment, to seeking satisfaction for the wishes and impulses rising at the moment, or to wallowing in radiant fantasies and thereby losing the capacity to work at the tasks life sets. In active natures it leads to reckless urge for activity and craving

²⁾Hugo a St. Victore derives *acedia* from the first three sins, which lead man to disgust with himself; out of *acedia* in turn spring the last three sins, since man, having lost inner joy, turns outward to find comfort (*Liebner: Hugo von St. Victor. Leipzig 1832. p. 278–280*). — In *Dante* the same course of development is hinted at: *Purgatorio. XVII. Cf. Ozanam: Dante et la philosophie catholique au 13e siècle. Paris 1843. p. 94*. — *Andreas Suneson: Hexaëmeron. ed. Gertz. p. 153* has the same order (which seems to derive from St. Gregory). — According to Thomas Aquinas all seven capital sins can be the point of departure (*radix*); but since at the foundation of them all there lies a craving for one's own eminence and loftiness, pride (*superbia*), the unbridled impulse to selfish loftiness (*inordinatus amor propriæ excellentiæ*), may rightly be called the beginning of all sin, just as it is the queen of all sins. Thomas sets up the following order, which, however, he does not regard as the only possible one: pride (*superbia*), avarice (*avaritia*), lust (*luxuria*), envy (*invidia*), gluttony (*gula*), wrath (*ira*), sloth (*acedia*). A parallelism between the capital sins and the cardinal virtues Thomas does not regard as possible. *Summa theologiae. Pars II. Qvæstio 84, 2–4*.

for independence, to lust for power or fanaticism. Here too harshness and cruelty can develop, especially when one's own capacity to suffer pain is slight. Great sacrifice and effort may often be shown here in order to satisfy the need to feel one's powers, the egoistic lust for power. This becomes the heroic form of evil. — Under such different forms the individual entrenches itself in itself, makes itself the center and makes full devotion impossible. Still more forms will be found when one takes account of the manifold displacements of motive that become possible from the original disposition, and also of the way in which the general psychological elements appear under the different historical and social conditions. Evil is not merely a psychological but also a sociological phenomenon.

That evil can thus appear in many different forms is of great practical importance. When the one does not have his imperfection where the other has his, mutual criticism and ethical influence can become possible. The single person can become a model in certain respects, even if he cannot become so in all respects. If such a diversity — differentiation or "division of labor" — did not take place, the possibilities of development and progress would be far smaller than they are.

2. I shall go a little more closely into the question: how high a degree of consciousness can be present in the states now depicted? — — The predicate "evil" is pronounced from a standpoint that he to whom it is applied does not share. The man of the moment, after all, does not share the standpoint of the individualist, and the individualist does not share the view of him who takes his stand at the standpoint of the family, the tribe, [132] the state or the whole race. If he who stands at the narrower or lower standpoint had complete and clear consciousness of the validity of the predicate and of its applicability to himself, then the corresponding feelings and impulses must also be set in motion, and his conduct would have to become different. There must always be ignorance and blindness in evil: ignorance, insofar as the ideas are not clear and complete; blindness, insofar as it is certain ruling feelings and passions that hinder the right development of the ideas. There may be an idea of another stage of life, but this idea is heard only as a distant voice, gains no power, awakens no strong feeling, does not enter into the real self. SOCRATES was in the main right that sin is ignorance, if only by ignorance one thinks of more than a lack of enlightenment of the understanding, or if to ignorance one adds blindness, in order to express that not only is right knowledge lacking, but there are also positive hindrances to its being able to develop and gain power over the mind. Those who act evilly "know not what they do." The reason they do not know it lies, to be sure, deeper than SOCRATES supposed, or at any rate deeper than he knew how to

express. But the self-knowledge that Socrates demanded would, if carried through, also bring to light the hidden foundation of the whole standpoint. All ethics must therefore in the end agree with Socrates.

But surely a real act of will requires that one be clearly conscious of what one is doing! — Here, therefore, a distinction must be made between consciousness of the actual circumstances that the action concerns and consciousness of the ethical character of the action. Ignorance and blindness need not concern the actual circumstances. I can know definitely what I am doing, as, for example, the inquisitor knows what he is doing when he passes the sentence of death on a man on account of his faith, without yet being clear that, seen from a higher ethical standpoint, it is something reprehensible. Such clarity would make the action impossible. For it is psychologically impossible to act against one's definite and full conviction when this is not obscured and displaced by other promptings. One can "have" a conviction in the sense that there is a possibility of [133] its being called forth and becoming living in consciousness when there is sufficient call or occasion for it. But the question is whether it presses forward in the mind spontaneously (or at any rate with a minimum of external occasion) at the moment of deliberation and of action; for only then is it really a definite and full conviction. Here there are infinitely many degrees and shades of clarity, and it is dogmatic to lay down the highest degree as given without more ado.

One might think that such a willing against better knowledge is nevertheless found when man seeks to obscure the ethical consciousness in himself in order to escape the discord and dividedness that arise where it cannot immediately become dominant, or when man seeks to prevent the arising of thoughts that he fears would change his whole present valuation, his present system¹⁾. But in such cases the higher ethical consciousness has, after all, not gained a firm footing; otherwise the painfulness of the divided state could not become the prevailing motive. Evil is not done with full and clear consciousness that it is evil.

It is only in the most recent times that great poets have depicted evil with a finer and deeper psychology than the one at the basis of the usual type of the devil, which even Shakespeare followed all too much in his Richard III and his Iago. In the first rank here stands the beginning of Dostoevsky's Raskolnikov. But I must also refer to a single speech in IBSEN's "Rosmersholm." The portrayal of Rebecca's character I cannot undertake to defend; but one single speech is masterly. "There are two kinds of will in a human being, I should think! I wanted to have Beata away. In the one way or in

¹⁾Cf. *Psyкологи* VI F, 2.

the other. But I never believed that it would come all the same. At every step that I ventured and risked forward, it seemed to me as if something cried out within me: Now no further! Not a step further! — And yet I *could* not let it be. I *had* to venture one tiny little bit more. Only a single one. And then one more — and always one more. — And [134] then it came. — That is the way such things happen.” A lesser poet would have depicted her as a devil who with full consciousness laid her plan and cleverly calculated the many small pinpricks that were to lead to the goal.

The theological idea of the “sin against the Holy Ghost” is likewise a psychological impossibility. LUTHER describes it in a sermon on this subject as “devil’s sin, which, though manifest and convinced, will not be convinced.” He says: “This sin I would never believe in former times, when I was still a learned doctor, to exist in the world.” Later he came to fear that the papists, who could not refute the right doctrine, would stick fast in this sin! As a learned doctor LUTHER was a better psychologist than when he had become the great agitator. If one will not be convinced, how can one then *be* convinced? So long as one will not be convinced, there must surely be a part of the mind left where conviction has not penetrated with its full effect; how otherwise could such a will arise? — Luther says: “When anyone goes so far that he will hear or see nothing, indeed will even defend his blasphemy, then he is no longer to be counseled and helped.” But he who defends himself appeals, after all, to grounds; he thus still acknowledges the power of truth, only he does not acknowledge as truth what his opponents call so. Here, then, something good is still left. The wholly devilish would be to acknowledge no truth at all; but that would in the end lead to complete meaninglessness and thoughtlessness and to complete impotence. Absolutely consistent wickedness would thus be absolute stupidity, and it is a right instinct that led popular belief to transform the evil devil into the stupid devil¹⁾.

[135] 3. A step further on than blindness lies obduracy. But it too is not one with conscious wickedness. Obduracy is blindness that has become fixed, has passed into flesh and blood, so that a change of character is extraordinarily difficult. It would, however, be unjustified to make such obduracy one with incorrigibility. Our art of education, both the individual and the social, is hardly so far advanced that we may declare a man absolutely incorrigible. Our art and our means are perhaps not sufficient. But in this field neither the strength nor the skill has so far been put in that mankind has applied in so many

¹⁾Already in the old Persian theology this feature appears: Ahriman in his ignorance does not suspect that Ormuzd, the good power, exists, and when he has discovered this power, he underrates it, likewise from ignorance. Edv. *Lehmann: Zarathustra. En Bog om Persernes gamle Tro.* Copenhagen 1899–1902. II. p. 161.

other fields. One has been content to put such individuals in a “house of correction” and to refer them to a hell in the other world. The art and the great, patient feeling of humanity that alone could overcome the obstacles that may be present here are still only in their becoming¹⁾.

VII.

THE THEORY OF WELFARE.

1. In the three immediately preceding chapters we have been occupied with the *foundation* of ethics. We now pass on to a closer determination and illustration of the principle of the content of ethics. To the foundation on which we have here taken our stand there answers, as shown earlier (III, 10–15), only one such principle, namely the principle of welfare. It gives the general answer to the question: *what is the good?*

From a misunderstood idealistic interest it has often been overlooked that the concept of the good is a purely *formal* concept, and a certain cult has been made of it without any closer determination of it being given. The true good, it was held, must be the good in and for itself, whose value does not depend on anything else. But what is it that has [136] its value in itself? What content satisfies this condition?

As developed earlier, this question must be answered differently at the different ethical standpoints. When a disinterested and universal sympathy is determinative for ethical valuation, only that can be good which preserves and heightens the welfare of conscious beings, increases their pleasure or diminishes their pain. Every action that works in this direction without bringing with it more remote effects in the opposite direction is thereby justified; every action of which the opposite holds is reprehensible.

Ethics here only works further on what has been begun by the hand of nature. For on the whole, feeling of pleasure is bound up with the sound and natural use of the powers and with what preserves and furthers life, feeling of pain with the opposite. Pain is a sign of a beginning dissolution of life¹⁾. When ethics values our willing and acting by the degree in which pleasure thereby comes to prevail over pain, it works — by virtue of *the close connection between pleasure and life, pain and death* — for the development of human life, of human faculties and powers, in as rich a measure and in as harmonious a way as possible. Ethical problems therefore also concern the valuation of the pleasure and pain of single moments in relation to the whole of the individual's life, and of the pleasure and pain of single individuals in relation to the whole of the life of the race.

¹⁾Cf. more fully on this my *Etiske Undersøgelser* p. 73–81

¹⁾*Psykologi* VI D.

Only so far as this valuation is possible can the valuation of acts of will and of actions be grounded, and ethical action have a definite content. Every act of will and every action is like a stone thrown into the water; the movement propagates itself in larger or smaller circles. And the valuation depends on how the action intervenes in the life and feeling of conscious beings. Just as theoretical science explains one natural phenomenon by another, so ethics values the one feeling by other feelings: the satisfaction the agent feels [137] in, or obtains by, his willing and acting is to be called unconditionally good only when the effects of the action do not intervene disturbingly in the feeling of pleasure of other beings. Every such intervention requires justification by being shown to be a necessary means to a correspondingly greater welfare for the sufferer himself or for others. So, according to the principle of welfare, the burden of proof must be distributed. It is the infliction of pain that is to be grounded, while the feeling of pleasure has its provisional justification in itself. This maxim was first set up by PLATO (*Protagoras*. Heise's transl. p. 198 f.), who taught that when sensual enjoyment is to be blamed, it is on account of its consequences, not on account of the pleasure it gives at the moment¹⁾.

Welfare expresses itself as a lasting state of the feeling of pleasure. It may perhaps be won only by a course of development that leads through pain and privation; but it is the goal for whose sake pain and privation are endured. One need not be an optimist to acknowledge welfare as the objective principle of ethics. For nothing whatever is thereby said about how easy it is to reach the goal, or in what degree it is at all possible to reach it. Should pessimism be right, should all feeling of pleasure, all happiness, be an illusion, and painful burning and need the inmost thing in us all, — the principle of welfare would not thereby be overthrown. The task would then be to bring as much relief as possible, and such relief would then be all the welfare that could be attained.

Only from an absolutely ascetic standpoint, that is, one that would maintain that pain in itself and to all eternity is to be preferred to pleasure, can the principle of welfare be disputed here. But such a standpoint cannot be carried through either; even the ascetic torments himself and others only in order to produce a greater feeling of pleasure thereby. Every ethical line of thought leads out in the end to a point where the ultimate [138] ground of the approval of an action proves to be that at some point or other in the world pleasure is produced or pain annihilated.

As already remarked earlier (III, 11), the resistance to this principle is due in part to misunderstandings that the words have caused, and I prefer to use the word "welfare"

¹⁾Among modern thinkers *Spinoza* has maintained it (*Ethica* IV, 43. 60. App. c. 30); likewise *Malebranche* (*Recherche de la vérité* IV, 10). *Arnauld*, on the other hand, in his polemic with *Malebranche*, had great misgivings about it. Cf. *Bayle's Dictionnaire*. Art. Épicure.

instead of “happiness” or “utility” in order to avoid such misunderstandings. — By “happiness” [*Lykke*] one often thinks of something accidental and external. “It is called happiness,” says P. E. MÜLLER in his “Synonymik,” “when a good befalls us that we cannot ourselves bring about.” It is in this sense that the poet speaks of “the capricious play of fortune.” Often the word happiness is also used of sated contentment, rest in what has been attained. Whichever of these meanings one takes, it is clear that there can be something better than “happiness.” But why should the word happiness not be usable of the feeling of pleasure that is grounded in and bound up with self-activity and can be held fast only by constantly continued development? — Here, then, *provisionally*, no kind or degree of feeling of pleasure is to be excluded; the order of rank among the different feelings of pleasure can be fixed only by the following more special inquiries. But in and for itself every ethics that acknowledges sympathy as the motive of valuation must also find it valuable that one confers on others goods that they cannot themselves bring about; if they could bring about these goods themselves, they would, after all, need no help. And satiety is, after all, in and for itself nothing slight, whether it follows on bodily or on spiritual hunger and thirst. — By “utility” [*Nytte*] one easily thinks only of what is a mere means to something else, and thus has no value in itself. It is a business expression and grates on many ears merely because it is not solemn enough¹. But in turning away with overstrained indignation from this plain prose, one easily comes to [139] overlook that “having value in itself” can mean nothing other than being the immediate object of a need of feeling. Value “in itself” is the same as immediate value. As the ultimate standard we always find again the pleasure and pain of one or more conscious beings. — By welfare I mean the “true” happiness or the “true” utility, leaving it to the following sections to show its conditions more closely.

2. But the general concept of welfare contains some difficulties that we must bring forward here¹.

¹For solemn use we have the old Danish word “Gavn.” The word *Nytte* came from Germany. “Since *Gavn* was more rarely heard in daily speech, it acquired a more general and more honorable meaning, and the priest used it in the pulpit” (P. E. Müller). When Jesus says: “What *gavner* it a man if he gains the whole world but suffers harm to his soul,” it would, according to P. E. Müller, not have been right to use the word “*nytter*” instead of “*gavner*”! — (Addition 1913). *Kant* would not call respect a feeling; it was to be neither pleasure nor pain. Fichte distinguished sharply between “*Genuss*” and “*Würde*.” According to Hegel the happy times are the blank pages of history, because opposites are lacking. Carlyle distinguishes sharply between “happiness” and “blessedness.” — On the other hand Rousseau maintained that there is no happiness without courage. Grønbech teaches (in his book *Lykkemand og Nidding*) that the Germanic word *Lykke* contains a potential moral valuation; *Lykke* is the will-side in man, the last and deepest expression of his being; it gathers in itself the conditions of life of the kin. And Jhering declares: “*Wohlsein ist aufgespeicherte Arbeitskraft*.” — One sees how the ceremonial of words can gain influence on the fate of theories.

¹In my *Etiske Undersøgelser*, p. 24–42, I have discussed the various objections that might be raised, or have been raised, against the principle of welfare, in part somewhat more fully and from a somewhat

Can a lasting state of the feeling of pleasure not be reached at very different stages of development and by very different roads? “True,” or rather *actual*, happiness can, after all, mean nothing other than full satisfaction of all the need that can be felt. And the need one feels conforms to the nature one happens to have. Must not, then, the welfare or happiness of the one be just as good as that of the other, since each of them can get no further than to obtain satisfaction for his need, and the one naturally does not need satisfaction for a need that not he but another has? How, then, can the principle of welfare furnish a standard for the valuation of the feelings of pleasure at the different stages and in the different beings?

[140] And second. Does the development of human faculties and powers, does the whole development of culture really lead to welfare? Through culture, to be sure, the means at the disposal of the race are increased, and faculties and skills are trained that were not present before. But are not the needs, both the material and the ideal, increased at the same time, and with them the possibilities of privation, pain and disharmony? Even the development and widening of sympathy and of the feeling of duty threaten welfare, since one thereby becomes vulnerable at far more points, makes greater demands on oneself and others, and does not so easily find peace and rest in one’s mind!

These two questions I shall examine each by itself.

3. STUART MILL has said: “It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied.” He grounds this assertion by saying that even if the pig and the fool should think the opposite, their judgment would have to be rejected, because they do not know the higher standpoint from which man and Socrates regard life, whereas man knows the needs of the pig, and Socrates sees through the fool. One must keep to the judgment of those who know both kinds of needs and can therefore make a valuation of them¹⁾.

I must, however, take the pig and the fool somewhat under my protection. The difficulty is greater than Mill supposes. Man, to be sure, knows the needs of the pig, and Socrates will have no difficulty in entering into those of the fool. But man does not have the needs of the pig, Socrates does not have those of the fool, as *sole rulers*, and it is, after all, on this that everything depends in this connection. Man cannot make himself
[141] a pig without ceasing to be man²⁾, and Socrates will hardly be able to make himself so

different side than in what follows.

¹⁾*Moral grundet paa Nytte- og Lykkeprincippet*. Danish transl. p. 10–12. — A similar line of thought is found already in *Plato* (*Statens 9de Bog*. Heise’s transl. p. 86–92). *Voltaire* too has discussed the problem. See *Histoire d’un bon brahmin*.

²⁾If it succeeded, the enjoyment would perhaps become all the greater, provided, that is, the Leipzig students in Goethe’s *Faust* are right when they sing: *Uns ist so kannibalisch wohl, als wie fünfhundert*

one with the fool that the Socratic needs wholly fall away. Now if the pig can obtain full satisfaction of all its need, is its happiness not greater than man's, who hardly gets all his wishes and all his craving fulfilled? And the fool, who has not many thoughts and makes no great demands on life, is he not happier than Socrates, who spends his whole long life learning to know himself and awakening others, only to declare at last that death is at bottom better than life?

What is in question here is, after all, not a definite sum of external goods, but goods that are really goods for this definite being. One and the same sum of money may be a great gain for the one and a sheer trifle for the other. It is a chief psychological law that the degree of a feeling is determined by the change produced in the individual's whole state.

Finally, he who has won *full* satisfaction for his need has no motive to compare his state with that of others. That the pig is not bothered by man, nor the fool by Socrates, comes of course from lack of capacity. But even where the intellectual conditions for making such a comparison are present, one will not be able to feel any sting in the comparison, any need to get beyond one's state. It will go as in DANTE's Paradise, where there are different degrees of blessedness, but where those placed on the lower degrees feel no unrest at the thought of the higher, since their "will is brought to rest, so that only in what it has it finds its joy." The poet continues:

Then it became clear to me that everywhere
in heaven, where I wander, there is Paradise,
though God lets grace rain down in different measure¹⁾.

In DANTE's Paradise, therefore, all striving and development is over. But will it not go so everywhere? And how can the principle of welfare be taken as the basis for a comparison of the states of different beings, when each of these has the character of [142] complete contentment?

Having now posed the problem that presents itself here as sharply as possible, I shall try to answer it.

Just as in external nature there is no absolute rest, but everywhere movement under different shapes, so too welfare as the absolute satisfaction of every need for every being is possible only approximately, and every approximation to it will be subject to attack. This lies in the fact that every being is subject to external and internal changes. Nature

Säuen.

¹⁾Dante: *Paradiso*. III v. 88–90. — Cf. *Augustine: De civitate dei* XXII, 30.

and life do not stand still, but go on working both in the individual and around it, and these changes will awaken new need and set new tasks.

As regards the external changes, no closer demonstration is needed. We always seek in vain to withdraw into an idyllic existence. Sooner or later the idyll is interrupted by changes in the surrounding world that make new efforts and labors necessary.

And with the external changes follow the internal. Ideas of the new and the strange will not in the long run be kept away, and they will set feeling and will in motion. If we may apply our psychological laws to the conditions in Dante's Paradise, then in the blessed, together with the ideas of the higher stages of life, there will also arise a craving and longing to attain them. — And even if new ideas do not arise and work, feeling itself will need contrast and variation in order to keep itself fresh and living. Uniformity and repetition dull and weaken. That is why the idyll as a genre of art needs as its background a hint of a larger, manifold and agitated life in order to produce its effect. Thus in GOETHE's "Hermann und Dorothea" the revolutionary war and its effects [143] form the restless background¹⁾. — Finally, when uniformity and repetition do not lead to decline and weakening, there will naturally arise a need for movement and activity. We move, after all, not merely in order to attain definite ends, but also in order to use our powers and find an outlet for accumulated energy. This need for movement will grow the more powers are accumulated, the longer the rest lasts. The activity it leads to will lead to new experiences and thereby to new struggles.

Even if these causes do not work in the single person who has reached a certain state of equilibrium, they will nevertheless work in the race after the lapse of not many generations. It will appear that, if there is no decline or dissolution, every attainment of an end will be only the beginning of a new end's being set. Welfare is therefore an illusion if by it is meant *a passive state, produced once for all*. It must consist in *activity*, in work, in development. This lies already in the word: welfare [*Velfærd*] is to *fare* well — that is, to be in movement, not at rest. When the word "fare" can also mean "to be in a certain state," this is, according to Molbech, a "figurative and improper" meaning. Welfare as rest can mean only a *provisional* conclusion, the attainment of a new level on which a new development can be begun. We need not, however, take back on that account our definition of welfare as a lasting state of the feeling of pleasure. What must

¹⁾After Schiller, in the magnificent poem "*Das Ideal und das Leben*," had depicted the transition from the heavy struggle with reality to the ideal Olympian harmony, he conceived the plan of writing an idyll, a picture of a blessed existence raised above all strife. He regarded this as the highest poetic task. But he saw the necessity that the strife and struggle of human life should yet be recalled: "The chief persons would indeed be gods, but in Hercules I can still find a point of attachment between them and mankind and bring a movement into the picture." (Briefwechsel zwischen Schiller und Wilhelm v. Humboldt. Stuttgart und Tübingen 1830. p. 328). — The plan was not carried out.

be rejected is merely the idea of a *passive* state. Activity, after all, is a state too, just as rest is. By a natural illusion we like to think of our more distant ends as states of rest. Because of the distance we cannot see the multiplicity they contain and the tasks they set. From this illusion actual experience constantly tears us. We learn to understand that only the happiness found in work for the advance of life in ourselves and others is built on firm ground.

There is here a significant parallel between the theory of welfare and the theory of [144] conscience. (Cf. IV, 3–4). Neither of them can assume any absolute conclusion, but both lead us to the thought of a course of development that cannot be surveyed. And there is also an interaction between them. For the richer an idea one has of what belongs to welfare, the more conscience is developed and exercised, since it gets the more tasks to treat. And the finer and more sharply developed conscience is, the greater the demands it makes on what (in others and in ourselves) is to deserve the name of welfare. He whose eye is dulled and whose horizon is narrow is easy to satisfy.

When great minds often judge disparagingly of the happiness that can be attained in the world, they are thinking more of the passive states that fill the intervals between the times of great activity than of the very working that has made them the great minds. It is psychologically intelligible that in the active times, when life stirred strongly in them, they did not think of their own state, but were absorbed in the work for their cause. It is always a bad sign when attention glides over from the thought of the end to the feeling of pleasure its attainment can bestow¹⁾. One thereby comes to separate what is not to be separated, and the state is thereby transformed from an active into a passive one. At the same moment that one asks oneself whether one is happy, one easily isolates oneself from the content in and for which one lives. That question does not come up at all so long as one is absorbed in this content; that it comes up points to a beginning doubt. It holds, after all, of all ethical reflection, of all knowledge of good and evil, that it *presupposes* (not, as in the old story, *brings about*) the end of the paradisaal state. Reflection can of course be awakened from without — by him who brings the serpent into Paradise. But then it is presupposed that it has been awakened in others, and it will not work where there was not a beginning disharmony beforehand. Happiness is expansion, not reflection, or — to use Ludvig FEILBERG's expression — “running straight on,” not “circling.” In a certain sense one may therefore say that we only rightly know happiness when it has vanished. The striving for happiness then becomes a striving to reproduce at a higher [145] stage what we have known at an earlier stage. And the more activity itself is bound up

¹⁾Psykologi VII, B, 1 a; 3.

with the feeling of pleasure, the less means and goal — the striving for happiness and happiness itself — fall apart, the more firmly welfare is grounded. It is by no means a matter of indifference how means and goal, cause and effect, here stand to one another, — whether they stand in a purely external connection, or whether there is an inner coherence between them, so that the end already stirs in the means, and the effect is only an unfolding of what lies in the cause. Two states may apparently be quite alike, and yet the one may, on account of its manner of coming into being, acquire greater value than the other through the hidden elements (the potential energy) it contains, namely partly the possibility of rich memory, partly the possibility of future development. The value 2 may here be greater when it is reached by $7 - 5$ than when it is reached by $1 + 1$. The welfare that is reached through pain and struggle may be greater than the apparently same welfare that is reached by quiet and gentle unfolding, — may contain more possibilities than this. — An end completely and once for all *attained* is no longer able to set the impulse to activity in motion, and the feeling attached to the idea of it can therefore not become so strong and living either as the one conditioned by the idea of an end that can constantly be realized in a higher degree and to a greater extent. The highest we can conceive is an advance in which each single step is felt as a good, because it sets our powers in motion without yet straining them beyond their capacity.

We are thereby led over to the second of the questions raised, that of the ethical significance of the development of culture.

4. Welfare consists in activity, but it does not follow that welfare is attached to every activity. By this simple proposition the relation between *ethics* and *culture* is provisionally designated. Culture is the wider concept, ethics the narrower. All ethical striving is cultural activity, but not all cultural activity is ethical.

[146] By culture we understand the working up of the material given by the hand of nature. Yet no fixed boundaries can be drawn between nature and culture. What is culture seen from one point of view is nature seen from another. For what the one generation laboriously produces is a given foundation for the following ones. Not even in the animal world do we always find pure and bare natural life. The bird has its nest, which it has built itself, and the fox its den, which it has dug out itself. And besides, every generation has in its nature an inheritance from the experience and activity of earlier generations.

The concept of culture is in and for itself a purely formal concept. Working up and activity tell us nothing about whether the work and activity are for benefit and advance. The so-called consciousness of culture can often be a heartless joy at seeing the many wheels in motion, the many threads crossing one another that are knotted together into

an ingenious web. One then does not think of what is attained by the whole, or of those who are crushed under the rolling wheels. What value, really, has the whole restless labor continued from generation to generation? Our skills and our needs rise; but would it not be better to be spared these new skills and these new needs, if welfare could be attained on simpler and easier terms? — By this question we are led back again to the first difficulty that lay in the concept of welfare. The two difficulties into which this concept leads us are so closely connected that the overcoming of the second forms the continuation of the overcoming of the first. From welfare as a passive state we had to pass on to welfare as activity; but here it appears again that a closer limitation is necessary.

This limitation is given by the general theory of *the connection of the feeling of pleasure with the sound, natural and life-developing use of the powers*. Activity ceases to be welfare when it either overstrains the powers, or when the powers are scattered and split up, or when the use of power takes place one-sidedly in a single direction at the expense of other important directions. Where the *resistance* is greater than is necessary for the unfolding of the powers, pain and suffering will arise; and such a painful activity [147] can be justified only as a transition to a state in which a more harmonious relation has been brought about between the external and the internal conditions. Where the powers are not in the end gathered toward a common goal, life dissolves into fragments, and no collected feeling of life becomes possible. And finally, where some powers are exercised at the expense of others, a disproportion between the inner and the outer will sooner or later appear; the *one-sidedly* developed inner powers will not answer to the many-sided demands that the external conditions of life make. In these three respects the development of culture can go astray. It has a tendency to strike into every new direction of activity that offers itself, being guided by the momentary satisfaction that can thereby be won. There is something blind and reckless in cultural activity that is connected both with its merits and its faults. It is loath to leave any possibility whatever untried; it has its feelers out in all directions; thereby the significant experiences are made; but thereby it can also lead to disharmony and suffering for the single individuals and for the race.

Culture is not an object of choice. It is the continuation of the development of nature and can just as little be stopped as this. The need for restless development, for trying new ways and for training specialties and producing diverse forms, is the great means in the hand of nature for making possible the continued existence of living beings when these increase greatly within a relatively small area. Differentiation and restlessness

spring from the density of population¹⁾. But because the development of culture, as it actually takes place, is a necessity of nature, it is not said that it is admirable. Ethics feels no special admiration for an order of the world under which development is often not possible without overstraining of the powers and without one-sidedness and dispersion [148] in the use of the faculties. It is not so thick-skinned that over the apparent brilliance of the external results it can forget the anguish and the pain, the sweat and the blood, that they cost. Therefore it demands that the heavy burdens be lightened, that the split powers be gathered, and that all valuable faculties be developed. The demands it thus makes on the development of culture are related to those it makes on human willing and acting in general (III, 20). Through insight into the conditions of the development of culture it seeks to find means to alter, to mitigate and to humanize, so that culture and welfare may be brought into as close a connection as possible. It is not sentimental and shortsighted, so that it should forget that advance can take place only through effort and suffering. Only in taking part in the work of culture does it find a real task and a real content for the life of the will. And in particular it sees that only through the development of culture and the differentiation this brings with it do personal peculiarities come to be unfolded and employed. Each single person is, to be sure, made more dependent on the others; but with this mutual dependence follows a mutual supplementing and a more inward union than is possible so long as the division of labor has not come into force. Both the multiplicity and the coherence can now become greater and firmer. This culture can bring about — but it has side effects that prevent it from unfolding all its happiness-bringing effects.

The chief ethical task with regard to culture is to enjoin that life is not to be made a mere means to the solution of impersonal tasks. Culture is to reach its completion in personality, so that this itself comes to stand as the highest culture. Personal life must neither be wasted in fruitless struggle against insuperable resistance nor be scattered and narrowed by too great multiplicity or one-sidedness. Culture contains a possibility that men may come to set themselves higher ends and to grow with their higher ends; it is this possibility that ethics demands be used. Enthusiasm for the state of nature is unethical when it leads to giving up work. A meager content is easy enough to order; where [149] there are no differences and oppositions, it is easy enough to keep spiritual disharmony away. Often, no doubt, a restriction of needs may be the only possibility of winning victory over the obstacles. But often precisely the feeling of privation and want may awaken new powers and thereby make possible a satisfaction that would otherwise not

¹⁾Cf. Ch. Darwin: *The Variation of Animals and Plants under Domestication*. London 1868. I. p. 5–7. — E. Durkheim: *De la division du travail social*. Paris 1893. p. 282–294.

have been possible. Neither of the two assertions, neither that needs are to be restricted nor that they are to be increased in order that welfare may be attained, is therefore unconditionally true.

This finds its application when the question arises with what right one abolishes the harmony and happiness that are present in order to lead men into new ways in the field of spiritual or material culture. So when savage nations are torn out of their “state of nature,” — when one robs the child of its illusions or awakens new needs in it, — when one awakens doubt where a blind but secure faith reigned before. The decision in such cases can be made only with the help of the principle of welfare. If one is sure that by the new road a new harmony, a new satisfaction, can be won that has a firmer ground and richer content than the earlier one, then it is justified to intervene. And it becomes a duty where one stands before a sleepwalker’s state that may end in misfortune for the sleeping individual himself and for others. A man’s idyll may bring harm and pain to others, or at any rate diminish their happiness. There may be unused powers that the race needs, although the individual has so far felt no need to use them. Even if they should be awakened by a painful shock, it may be a duty to administer it. It may in the single case be extraordinarily difficult to decide whether such a painful shock is to be administered. The ethical calculus will never be able to lead to full certainty: one must *venture*, and a leap must be made out into the dark. The principle of welfare can here serve only as a guiding point of view. It does not conflict with venturing; but it conflicts with venturing the leap into the dark when one has no hope that there is light on the other side of the dark. The relation may be illuminated by an analogy that is, however, more than an analogy. It does not conflict with the method of empirical science to set up hypotheses, provided only one holds fast to the endeavor to win the confirmation of [150] experience for these hypotheses. Every hypothesis is a venture, but the history of science shows us that without such ventures our knowledge would not have advanced. So too it will be a consequence of the principle of welfare that one must venture, that one cannot always wait until full guarantee of happiness-bringing effects has been attained. The principle of welfare must expressly lead to misgivings about letting reflection and the weighing of grounds for and against play too great a part, since energetic and resolute action, which in fact proves to be of such great significance, is thereby excluded. PAUL HENSEL¹⁾ says in his criticism of utilitarianism: “The cautious utilitarian must in any case take a dismissive attitude toward an attempt to lead society into new and untried ways; for every such attempt undoubtedly disturbs much happiness, and it is problematic

¹⁾*Ethisches Wissen und ethisches Handeln*. Ein Beitrag zur Methodenlehre der Ethik. Freiburg i. Br. 1889. p. 31.

whether it is able to create new happiness.” But precisely the principle of welfare leads one not to be all too cautious. Caution is a burgomaster’s virtue, but it would not agree with the principle of welfare if we were all burgomasters, and even burgomasters can be too cautious. The adherents of utilitarianism, especially in earlier times, often — like the empiricists in general — underestimated the significance of the venture, of the hypothesis. But that was a decided inconsistency on their part, and no decisive objection to the principle of welfare can be built on it. When Hensel declares besides: “Where great ideas enter into struggle with one another, at the turning points of history, where a new time comes into the world in thousandfold throes, there utilitarianism must fall silent,” — he overlooks that the great ideas in history have always pointed precisely to a higher stage of life, a kingdom of personalities of a more perfect kind than the existing societies made possible, and that it was only in confidence in the greater value of the goods this kingdom would bring that the struggle was ventured. But he also overlooks [151] that history in fact reaches its results neither by the shortest nor by the cleanest roads, and that one need not approve of these roads because one holds fast to the value of what has been attained, through many displacements, by following them. The result does not sanctify the method.

If we would always direct our conduct by the need and the wants that men had at the moment, we would thereby lower the level of human life and human culture. The principle of welfare demands that we do not shun the struggle against prejudice and inertia. The best one can do for others is often simply to let them feel that in their wishes and wants they still stand too low and do not make great enough demands. Thus — to take a single example — the great artist often goes his lonely way, not understood or even misjudged by the great multitude. And yet he follows the principle of welfare, perhaps without thinking of it, by strictly asserting the demands of art. He increases the spiritual capital of the race and bestows on it a power that may in the future come to work in large circles. Only a shortsighted conception and application of the principle of welfare keeps to the need prevailing at the moment, instead of looking to the lasting conditions of life of the race and to the constant sources of new life and new activity. GOETHE said (in a conversation with Eckermann): “In my calling as an author I have never asked: what does the great mass want, and how can I benefit the whole? I have always striven only to make myself more insightful and better, to raise the worth of my own personality, and then always to utter only what I had recognized as good and true.” Had he wished to conform to the taste and capacities of the public, he could have made a greater momentary effect, but his works would then also have had a shorter life, and he

would not have become the great teacher of many generations. — How large a horizon is to be applied in the single case in discussing the value of an action or an endeavor, nothing can be said in general. With a vigorous conviction of having the conditions for accomplishing something there is as a rule bound up a more or less conscious and confident appeal to the judgment of the future. One must venture every time something [152] is to be put into the great connection of the world, which we cannot survey. And even as regards the subsequent confirmation by experience, which historically decides the value of the venture, it holds that it can never be wholly concluded so long as historical development lasts. There will always be room for a revaluation. Nietzsche has even demanded a “revaluation of all values.” That is to take one’s mouth rather full; but a limit to how far the revaluation that constantly goes on, and must go on, is to be extended cannot be set beforehand. It will therefore be impossible to form an absolutely concluded ethical system. Every science that holds fast to the necessity of confirmation by experience (verification) must at every time bear the stamp of incompleteness. It is therefore no decisive objection to the conception of ethics put forward here that it leads only to “empirical certainty”¹⁾. Just as human motives of valuation are in constant development, so a more extended application of the principles of valuation will always be possible. We are constantly on the way — and not we alone: the world, existence as a whole, is perhaps not finished either, but in constant development. The ethical striving itself is, after all, a sign that the world is not finished. There is a part of the world’s work that only men can do. A part of the development of the world takes place through human action itself.

5. The roads that human action follows in order to reach its ends are by no means indifferent. As we have seen, it is, according to the principle of welfare, an imperfection when road and goal, cause and effect, stand in an external relation to one another. These roads will be the more perfect the more the means employed are in the spirit of the end itself, or, as BRUNO WILLE has expressed it, are *pure means*. The well-known proposition that the end sanctifies the means starts from a purely external relation between means and end. The more the means is in the spirit of the end, and thus is “holy” in itself, the [153] more the end is already attained, although we are still on the way: it is attained in the disposition that leads to working in the spirit of the end and is thus an anticipation of the end. The proposition that the end sanctifies the means may for that matter have its justification. There may be cases in which in the service of an end we do, and must do, things we would not otherwise do — not because they are bad, but because they

¹⁾Axel Hägerström: *Undersökning af den empiristiska etikens möjlighet*. Upsala 1895. p. 16. 129.

are indifferent: what under other circumstances has no value for us now acquires value as a means. Modern Jesuit ethics restricts the proposition to such cases¹⁾. But to these must be added such cases in which a lesser evil must be inflicted in order that a greater evil may be avoided. When a man who is dying of hunger smashes a pane in a baker's shop and takes a piece of bread, he performs an action that is sanctified only by the intention. Here belongs also all education through suffering punishment. According to the principle of welfare, after all, the infliction of pain is justified and necessary when it is the only means to an indispensable good; but that is also the only ground that can make the infliction of pain permissible. The decisive thing will then of course be whether the end itself is really "holy"; if it is not, it cannot sanctify the means. If, then, it is egoistic ends or party ends (ecclesiastical, political, literary, etc.) that lie at the basis, the proposition becomes questionable. And even if the end is really valuable, it is not said that it is able to sanctify the means. The employment of a means may bring with it side effects that cause greater corruption than giving up the good intention would. He who would murder with a noble intention would surely, by such a breach of the elementary laws of human living together, produce a greater evil than he could remedy by attaining his intention. Assassinations as a rule strike only the external consequences or symptoms of a bad social state, not the real cause, and they often help to make bad worse. Significant ends require a long course of development for their realization and are [154] often made possible precisely only when there is no breach of the elementary ethical laws that one thinks oneself entitled to break in the consciousness of one's good intention. Better social conditions are attained by working on the character and way of thinking of the people, by developing its powers and resources. Finally, it stands as a psychological problem how the noble intention and the crude or cruel means can dwell side by side in the same soul. It can perhaps be explained only by the deep indignation that resistance to the great end breeds: but actions that come into being in this way are rather to be conceived as symptoms, as outcomes of an unhappy social state and of the tormented mood such a state has awakened in idealistic natures, than as utterances of will that could have an exemplary character and lay claim to "holiness." And precisely here side effects lie so extraordinarily near: through displacement of motive what was at first only reluctantly chosen as a means can spread in the soul and at last become the chief end. What was begun in a purely ideal form can, through increasing bitterness, end in blind hatefulness and lust for destruction. It is a dangerous road one treads when one begins to choose means that must first be "sanctified." The history of coups d'état and

¹⁾Cathrein: *Philosophia moralis*. p. 80.

assassinations bears witness to this. — Besides the involuntary displacement of motive there is also a voluntary displacement, namely when one “directs the intention” in order to be allowed to perform actions one has a mind to. It was the permissibility of this that PASCAL accused the Jesuits of teaching: although Christ forbids repaying evil with evil, we should nevertheless be allowed to persecute our enemies, provided only we do it — not in order to inflict evil on them, but — in order to assert our honor!¹⁾

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VIII.

INDIVIDUAL AND SOCIAL ETHICS.

1. There are some concepts that will unavoidably be formed whenever an ethical theory is developed in its full range, since they designate different sides of, or points of view for, all ethical action.

An action must have an end, which consists in the valuable thing that is striven for. The concept of it is the concept of *the good*. Every end stands as a good, and this concept is in its generality common to all practical sciences, to political economy and jurisprudence as well as to ethics. (Cf. III, 1–14). The whole character and direction of an ethics are determined by the ends that are taken as its basis from the first, and therefore the greatest difficulties in every ethical discussion arise when the dispute comes to concern the fundamental ends (the fundamental values, the motives of valuation). (Cf. III, 12–13). What acquires value and can therefore become an end depends on the need and striving of life, especially of the life of the soul, and will be different at the different stages of life. (Cf. I, 4; III, 13. 21).

The concept of end already implies the presupposition of a certain distance between what is striven for and the given state. What is immediately given as valuable need not be set up as an end, except insofar as it is a matter of preserving it in the future. Now when the factor of distance is especially stressed, the difficulties of attaining the end being sharpened, the concept of *duty* arises. Bringing about what is acknowledged as a good then becomes a conscious task; man feels himself bound to work for it and to push back opposing tendencies. The presupposition of this is that man wishes to hold fast to coherence and agreement with himself, to remain identical with himself, true to himself through the changing moments and circumstances. Only then will he maintain the conviction of the validity of the acknowledged value beyond the moment of acknowledgment. From the point of view of self-preservation it becomes a duty to [156]

¹⁾*Lettres écrites à un provincial*. VII.

subordinate the satisfaction of the moment to the assertion of the more comprehensive values of life; from the point of view of the race it becomes a duty to subordinate the purely individual interests to the common ones. (Cf. III, 5—7. 9—10).

The concept of duty concerns especially the single actions that stand before self-reflection as a necessary consequence of the acknowledged end. If, on the other hand, the weight is laid on the abiding qualities of character that by their nature will lead to endeavors to realize the end, the concept of virtue arises. Between duty and virtue there is in ethics a difference similar to that between emotion and disposition in psychology. (Cf. *Psyкологи* VI E, 5). Duty presupposes a concentration of the ethical feeling on a single point, with a conscious effort at the single moment; virtue presupposes a lasting mood and striving, without the consistency with which the single action follows from the acknowledged end needing to be an object of full consciousness. Just as the transition from the immediate feeling of value to the feeling of duty takes place through an increasing stress on the factor of distance, so the transition from duty to virtue takes place through increasing practice in the moods and endeavors that the acknowledged end calls forth, until at last the single action proceeds from an involuntary need.

The concepts of duty and virtue spring as a direct consequence from the concept of the good. The concept of right, on the other hand, is an indirect consequence of it. Ethically justified is everything that does not conflict with or hinder the fundamental value that my highest end presupposes, and therefore does not conflict with any duty or virtue either. I am within my good ethical right wherever my conscience can make no objection, and where I therefore also demand that others shall acknowledge my conduct. If this acknowledgment is not forthcoming, I confidently appeal from the imperfect conscience to a perfect conscience, which I hope will develop and which I strive to have developed in them. The ethically justified is the free unfolding of life, the free use of the powers. Life does not exist for the sake of conscience, but conscience for the sake of life; [157] therefore conscience upholds me in my conduct when this does not injure the values of life. First and foremost the fundamental value itself stands as justified, subject only to the condition that it is to be realized in a way agreeing with its own nature. (Cf. VII, 5). — The ethically justified is not merely of a negative nature. It is wrong to call it the permissible. That would imply that it is merely tolerated. But where life has unfolded freely, without conscience needing to intervene regulatively, there the goal toward which all ethical development strives has already been reached. It is of decisive importance that the domain free from conscience be not narrowed. Ethics here points beyond itself, to an order of things where it itself need not exist. Since it is a duty to work toward such

an order of things, it is also a duty to assert one's right where it coincides with the right of life itself. It is here right that grounds duty. The ethically justified springs from the same source as the concepts of duty and virtue, but nearer the spring of the source than these. —

The character of every ethics is determined by the relation in which these four fundamental concepts stand to one another. They are so closely connected that one will always, in a more or less natural way, be able to find one's way from any one of them as a point of departure to the other three. They state the most important formal points of view from which every action and every relation can be regarded in an ethical respect. It will of course be of decisive importance for the characterization of an ethical theory which of these concepts it takes as its point of departure. If one would ground ethics on experience, there can, however, be no doubt that the concept of the good must be the first concept of ethics. An action, a striving and a valuation necessarily presuppose an end, and an end in turn presupposes an immediate value. This point of departure was accordingly taken by *Greek ethics*, and its significance for all time rests not least on this. In sharp opposition to this Kant would take the concept of duty as the basis and determine the other fundamental ethical concepts from it. Only in an artificial way could he derive special ends by this road¹⁾; the chief end for him became the will of duty [158] itself, as he expressed it in his famous proposition: "Nothing can be conceived in the world or outside the world that could be called good without limitation, except solely the good will." To the question when, then, a will is good, Kant answers: when it is in agreement with the nature of a rational being, and therefore in its principles the same in every rational being. In this way duty itself becomes the highest good. Virtue consists for Kant in the energy with which man practices his duty (*die Stärke des Menschen in Befolgung seiner Pflicht*. *Tugendlehre* § IX). There are therefore many duties, but only one virtue and one good. — Against Kant SCHLEIERMACHER stressed that one cannot will and act without having an end. (See above III, 1). He showed more closely in a series of interesting essays (which are found in the second volume of his philosophical writings) how the concepts of the good, duty and virtue lead over into one another. In his own ethics he took the concept of the end as the basis and derived the two other fundamental concepts from it. (*Philosophische Sittenlehre*. § 113–121). The concept of right he does not set up in this connection. He has, however, indirectly prepared it through his criticism of the concept of the permissible, which — as he aptly shows — belongs to jurisprudence, not to ethics, and comes into ethics only when one confuses this with jurisprudence²⁾.

¹⁾Cf. below VIII, 6, and *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². II. p. 81–84.

²⁾*Ueber den Begriff des Erlaubten*. (*Werke zur Philos.* II.) p. 443–445.

In the same direction as SCHLEIERMACHER utilitarianism, and in general all ethics of welfare, must of course go. — The third fundamental concept, virtue or the ethical quality of character, is taken as the basis in modern times in HERBART's ethics³⁾. Ethics here becomes first and foremost a description of qualities, a setting up of models. Besides [159] HERBART, *Swedish idealism* and, with us, F. C. SIBBERN's moral philosophy also go in this direction¹⁾. The difficulty of carrying it through lies in this, that the value of a quality of character can be grounded only by its containing a tendency to work in the direction of a valuable goal. The concept of virtue, like the concept of duty, depends on the concept of the good.

When in the year 1896 I lectured in Zurich on the doctrine of ethical principles, I kept essentially to the concept of end and discussed the problems contained in it. Since the concept of duty arises only where a relation of distance enters between value and reality, and since the value of duty depends on the value of the end, I did not speak of it in particular. In a discussion held after the end of the lectures it was objected against me that the concept of duty was missing from my account. I answered: "The concept of duty does not belong to the doctrine of principles. For duty first arises when what is acknowledged in principle is to be held fast and carried through in reality. I admire Kant's portrayal of the consciousness of duty, which presents this significant side of ethical life in great, fundamental features. But Kant went wrong in conceiving the concept of duty purely formally and not as conditioned by real ends. His psychological explanation is not as good as his psychological description. But every ethical standpoint can take up [160] Kant's description of the consciousness of duty, as soon as the question is how the ends and principles set by the will are to be held fast and carried through in the struggle of life." —

The four concepts spoken of will come into application again and again in the particular questions within special ethics. But it would not be expedient to take them as the basis for the division of ethics. They are purely formal concepts, and the same

³⁾Cf. *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². II. p. 254 f.

¹⁾*Biberg* criticized Schleiermacher's doctrine of the three fundamental concepts and demanded that the concept of virtue be taken as the basis, because it states the source of ethical action (*fons actionis*), while the concept of duty states the single action (*actio*) that derives from this source, and the good the result that arises through the action (*opus morale*). (Cf. Axel Nyblæus: *Den filosofiska forskningen i Sverige*. III, 2. p. 228). "All morality," says *Boström* (*Föreläsningar i Etiken*. Ed. Ribbing. p. 70), "rests on the will as principle or point of departure... It can be regarded 1) as resting; as a constitution, but at the same time the ground of activity; 2) as becoming; whereby it has the idea as its law; 3) as having come to be or attained, or as the highest good." — F. C. Sibbern takes the doctrine of the disposition (the fundamental virtues) as the basis, because it depends on the way in which man is fitted into the great whole of life. Then follows the doctrine of ends and last the doctrine of duties. *Moralphilosophie som Retsindigheds- og Tilbørighedslære*. p. 20.

real content would recur under all four points of view. Besides, the relation between them depends in each single case on individual and historical conditions. What has immediate value for the one man has perhaps for the other only mediate value and therefore requires a special effort if it is to be held fast: what is a good for the former becomes a duty for the latter. Perhaps in a third the character is so developed that a striving to assert what is valuable is released without effort.

Instead of the purely formal division that might be built on the fundamental concepts spoken of, it is more expedient to follow a more real division¹⁾. *The ethical world* extends from the moment to mankind. What fills the moments is valued from the point of view of the whole of the individual life, what fills the individual's life is valued also from the point of view of society, and every larger or smaller society is valued in the end from the point of view of mankind. The most far-reaching opposition here will be that between the single individual and society. The different kinds of society present common features, and they all consist of individuals as their ultimate elements. The question then becomes that of the relation between *individual and social ethics*. Does the one of these comprise the other, or do they stand side by side with equal right?

2. If we look first *historically* at the relation between individual and society, we do not find at earlier stages of development the individual as the bearer of special duties and rights. It is regarded only as a social element. The weight that at different times and among different peoples is laid on individual virtues such as self-control, moderation and the like finds its explanation in this, that these were qualities the tribe needed at the given time. The admiration felt for the individual virtues is thus originally due to their social significance. Primitive ethics is social ethics, and individual ethics develops out of it. As regards Greece, the philosophical schools represent the development of an individual, in part an individualistic, ethics. Increasing weight is laid on harmony in the individual's own nature, on the individual's disposition and character, and society is at last regarded as a merely external means for the individual's self-development. In the Christian idea of the single soul that is to be saved at any price there lies the same pointing toward the single personality. The modern endeavors at emancipation set the individual more and more free over against the social forms, and regard what goes on in it and with it as what is really decisive. And yet it will appear that social ethics is always presupposed by individual ethics, not merely historically but also conceptually.

3. One might think that *individual ethics* must be *ethics proper*, since it is, after all, always single, definite individuals that we have to do with in the ethical domain. Ethical

¹⁾On formal and real differences of value see *Den menneskelige Tanke*. p. 241—248. Cf. above IV, 1.

judgments concern willing and acting, and it is always single, definite individuals that will and act. A society acts only insofar as the single individuals act. And each of these acting individuals seems in the end to have to do only with itself. It is to act according to its own conscience; it cannot directly enter into what goes on within others; it has only to see to it, then, that it does not itself suffer harm to its soul; and when everyone does so, all will be well with society!

This way of looking at things has exercised great influence. It comes forth, as already touched upon, first in Greek philosophy. It was especially the Cynics and the Stoics who maintained such a regard for self, a higher self-preservation, as the most important thing in the ethical respect. In this respect they are the forerunners of Christianity. In [162] our modern time S. KIERKEGAARD is the great representative of the ethics of the single individual. Under his influence the same line of thought is found in HEEGAARD's book "Om Intolerance," where the need for intercourse with others is even characterized as a need "to see, hear, enjoy, or to be admired, flattered and worshipped." In HENRIK IBSEN's "A Doll's House" the same tendency comes out when Nora, by virtue of the principle that we have duties to ourselves before duties to others, withdraws from her very nearest relations — in order to become a human being!

This conception, for all its one-sidedness, has proceeded from a significant ethical line of thought. The single personalities are the living material in which the ethical has its reality. But it does not follow that the whole of existence, society and all other individuals are to be made means to the single person's self-development. That would bring with it an isolation, a one-sided absorption in oneself, that would easily pass over into egoism. There is just as much an ascetic egoism as there is an enjoying or a power-seeking egoism. The single person loses the capacity for self-surrender. The gaze is fixed on one's own welfare, not on the great common welfare of which one's own is a part.

Anxious ideas are entertained here about what the self or the personality can bear and needs. One thinks one can preserve oneself only by keeping one's attention uninterruptedly directed on oneself. But a self is not so fragile a thing. It becomes fragile precisely through much care for itself. A sound and vigorous self is reached by brisk and vigorous work on real tasks, and a large and comprehensive self is reached only when one works on common tasks, when one makes oneself one with something greater than the self. Only through self-forgetfulness does the self grow and develop. By living in others and in something other than itself the individual acquires new and vigorous impulses for its own individual life too. It is raised above its original narrow circle and

filled with a richer content. Everything a man lives in and for through sympathy is an enrichment and widening of his personality. It is here at every point both end and means. H. C. ØRSTED's maxim: "Forget your self, but do not lose it!" aptly expresses what is at stake here. For the sake of individual ethics itself, then, it must not be made the only [163] ethics.

The overvaluation of individual ethics is connected with an abstract way of thinking that draws man out of the definite, historically given relations and thinks it has the true man only in the being thus isolated. But I am not *first* a man in general, and *then* a man in these special relations. I am not *first* a man, and then a Dane, a citizen, the father of a family, etc. Individualism comes forth naturally in times when the historically given conditions of life lose their absolute authority and do not stand as the only possible and justified ones. It then has the great significance of nourishing a consciousness of freedom that can become a fruitful source of new development. But not only does it bring with it, as I have sought to show, great misgivings from the standpoint of individual ethics itself; — it will not be possible from such a way of looking at things to ground a conception of human social life by which this becomes more than a mere means. Its interests and tasks could at most become exercises for the single individuals, exercises that in and for themselves could just as well be exchanged for others.

An entirely different kind of individualism appears in the most recent times, especially in literary and aesthetic form. Fear of leveling and uniformity and of the spiritual tyranny of the crowd has especially worked to call it forth, and it appears as a cult of the strange, the solitary, the desert-like, the willful, the daring. In the practical domain this leads to a cult of "the superman," and the superman is thought of especially as the superior power that is raised not only above prejudices and customs, but also above the oppositions within which the life of the mass moves. What seems especially to awaken admiration of the imagined superman is the contempt he is able, from his standpoint, to feel for the great crowd. It is this factor of distance ("das Pathos der Distanz") that is placed in the foreground. With it there is then often bound up the longing and admiration that the weak and sick naturally feel for great strength and great health. These different tendencies can be shown in FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE. Thus he demands (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse*. Aphor. 258) of a ruling class that it should not ground its value on the function it performs in society, but that "its fundamental conviction should be that society does not exist for the sake of society, but only as a substructure and foundation on which a select kind of beings is able to raise itself to its higher task and in general to a higher

being.”¹⁾ Yet the problem of the relation between individual and social ethics comes back within that select kind of beings, namely in the question of their relation to one another and to the society they form. Of one of the supermen Nietzsche most admired, Napoleon, it has been said that he could not bear proud souls. That became his nemesis. Many of Nietzsche’s followers escape this nemesis for good reasons. There betrays itself in them, on the whole, a fairly disinterested feeling, insofar as they themselves seem very far from occupying the high station from which the great contempt could be motivated.

In a more philosophical way individualism appears in idealistic anarchism, as it is taught, for example, by the German writer BRUNO WILLE. Bruno WILLE’s book *Die Philosophie der Befreiung durch das reine Mittel* (Berlin 1894) gives an interesting and instructive account of this standpoint. It is demanded here that individuality shall develop from within, and that all ideals shall be self-created. Protest is made against all spiritual and physical compulsion, and such compulsion Wille finds also in moral influence on the part of others. Since he conceives conscience as a merely external, social product, he declares that the free man of reason must be without conscience.

[165] Bruno Wille builds on a thought that has also played a significant part in the history of Danish thought²⁾. The personality must itself produce — or produce anew — the truth that is to be truth for it. Ethical judgments must spring from the single person’s own experience and conviction; otherwise they are only an echo of the judgments of those around him. Everyone is to be his own inner judge, his own authority. All influence from without is to aim at producing the capacity for ethical independence. But what idealistic anarchism overlooks is the pedagogical significance that imitation and obedience, in general the relation of authority, can have. The single person needs help from others in order to become free and independent. This help can very often best be given by another way than by moral judgment. Direct moralizing often hinders the awakening of self-activity, since the ethical valuation is conveyed to the individual wholly finished and formulated instead of being produced by it. Yet direct moralizing really is a “pure means” (cf. VII, 5) when it aims at awakening self-knowledge and the impulse to development. This awakening may often be painful; but there are pains that are necessary transitions to a higher stage.

In vain will one strive to reach the highest by the way of isolation. Not only does the single person receive his education in society, but his content and his tasks too he receives only by devotion to the life of the race. Only here does he come to share in

¹⁾I cannot here discuss whether in such utterances we have Nietzsche’s real fundamental thought. On this I must refer to my work *Moderne Filosofer* (1904).

²⁾See my book *Søren Kierkegaard som Filosof*. Copenhagen 1892. p. 22–27; 98–107.

the higher ends with which he can grow. In the cult of contempt to which aesthetic individualism in the most recent times is inclined, the impossibility of isolation comes to light through a peculiar nemesis. When it is what Nietzsche has called *the pathos of distance* that determines the essential content this standpoint acquires, then it leads precisely to dependence on the great crowd; for there must be someone one can despise, someone from whom one can feel oneself at a distance. The exalted station is used essentially to look down from it on those who have not reached it. One forgets that true spiritual power and superiority show themselves in the capacity to carry not merely one's own life but the lives of many others. There is, says SPINOZA, no way in which a man can better show his strength of mind than by developing others to live according to their own free knowledge.

4. As a counterpart to this conception there appears the one that demands *complete* [166] *giving up of oneself* and regards *self-forgetfulness as the only virtue*. Within modern philosophical ethics such a standpoint has been asserted by J. G. FICHTE and A. Comte. True life consists, according to Fichte, in sacrificing oneself for the race: "There is only one virtue, to forget oneself as a person, and only one vice, to think of oneself... He who at all thinks of himself as a person and desires life, existence and enjoyment otherwise than in and for the race, is — by whatever good deeds he may otherwise seek in other fields to hide his deformity — nevertheless at bottom a common, small, bad and therefore unblessed man"¹⁾. Comte designates by the word altruism, which he introduced²⁾, complete absorption in others, the absolute opposite of egoism. Comte declares, to be sure, that altruism does not suppress self-assertion; but the latter's justification is to rest only on its being sanctified by working in the service of the former: both duty and happiness consist in *vivre pour autrui*³⁾.

This conception too was called forth by definite historical conditions, in the case of Fichte and Comte by the opposition to the individualism and the morality of happiness of the 18th century. In its way it starts, like the individualistic one, from a sharper opposition between regard for self and regard for others than need exist according to the real relations. From the principle of welfare it follows that the single person is only one among many; but it follows also that the single person really is one among the many. Everyone counts, and the giver is not to blot himself out for the sake of the receiver, any more than the receiver is to be made a mere means to the development of good qualities

¹⁾*Die Grundzüge des gegenwärtigen Zeitalters*. Berlin 1806. p. 70 f.

²⁾From *alter* (the other, i.e. the neighbor), as egoism from *ego* (I).

³⁾*Politique positive*. IV. p. 45—49. — There is on this point a certain opposition between Comte's earlier and his later standpoint (*Den nyere Filosofis Historie*² II. p. 346 f. and 357), which forms an analogy to the opposition between Fichte's two stages (ib. 142 f. and 151 f.).

in the giver. Only isolated self-satisfaction, entangled in itself, conflicts with the principle [167] of welfare. If the impulse to self-preservation, self-assertion and self-development were of evil, our inmost nature would be evil, and all ethics would then be self-contradictory and impossible.

We gain powers and means to work for what is different from ourselves and greater than ourselves only by preserving and developing our own being. If ethics condemns the instinct of self-preservation, it condemns its own means. Precisely when one takes one's stand on the ground of altruism, it becomes a special task for the single individual to strengthen and develop his powers and faculties. Self-assertion and self-development work in the same direction as altruism. Indeed, as SPENCER remarks, the happiness that can radiate from a sound and fresh individual over others is often worth more than that which one can consciously and with great sacrifice prepare for them. "Though our ethical reasonings take little account of it, it is yet evident that since happiness and sorrow are infectious, the care for self that leads to health and high spirits is a benefaction to others"¹⁾. And this holds not least of the higher, ideal development of the personality through work for interests that perhaps do not directly benefit others, as for example in artistic and scientific endeavors.

In another respect too ethics, by taking absolute altruism as its basis, would come into contradiction with itself. All sacrifice for others aims, after all, at supporting their self-preservation, self-assertion and self-development, and how can these be justified in the receivers if they are not so in the givers? Absolute sacrifice for others can even have a harmful influence on them. He who constantly receives sacrifices on the part of others easily becomes an egoist, if he does not go quite to sleep without knowing what is going on. He is made a passive being, who takes what is given without entering into what is sacrificed for him. His capacity for work is weakened, he becomes a parasite, not an independent, self-active being. The right sacrifice must be the one that robs neither [168] giver nor receiver of their independence, but makes them both independent members of the kingdom of personalities.

Such standpoints as Fichte's and Comte's come near to conceiving society or the race as a mystical whole that has an existence apart from the single individuals. A similar tendency appears in HEGEL¹⁾ and in the most recent times in WUNDT and Paul CARUS. In WUNDT's conception²⁾ "the public good" does not consist in the sum of welfare of as many single persons as possible, and general progress does not consist in the progress

¹⁾*Data of Ethics*. London 1879. p. 194.

¹⁾See *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*² II. p. 181.

²⁾Wundt: *Ethik. Eine Untersuchung der Thatfachen und Gesetze des sittlichen Lebens*.³ II. p. 116.

of as many individuals as possible. For every individual is a creature of a day: "However richly blessed and however perfect the individual existence may be, it is yet only a drop in the ocean of life. What can individual happiness and individual pain signify for the world?" And Carus³⁾ designates social life as "superindividual"; the end of ethics is according to him "neither the welfare of the self nor that of other individuals, but welfare for the superindividual interests."

If the concept of society is to be usable scientifically, it must be so in such a way that at every point one can decide what group of individuals it represents. The great significance of this concept rests on its expressing the common and abiding interests of the individuals existing simultaneously and successively, as opposed to the interests of single individuals or to the interests of a small group or a single generation. The ethical consideration leads (at the standpoint where we have taken our stand here) to regarding human actions not merely with regard to the welfare of the single person or of a limited circle or age, but with regard to the welfare of society or of the whole race, so far as we [169] can trace its conditions. But as soon as it proves impossible to convert the concept of a society into the concept of a group of individuals living under certain definite conditions, that concept gives us no ethical instruction; no ethical norms can be derived from it. Mysticism steps into the place of thought.

Such a mysticism may have its significance. It may prove impossible to form a clear concept of the great mass of human interests in which an action or an ordinance of life may under certain conditions intervene in a decisive way. Expressions such as society and race designate very well what is unconcluded and cannot be surveyed in many of these series of effects. And they designate also the possibilities or dispositions, the potential energy, that human work can bring about and accumulate, and which perhaps only in distant times can be converted into actual values that are felt by real, personal beings. But when one declares such a conversion impossible or unnecessary, one gets stuck in mysticism. A welfare that is not at some stage or other the welfare of definite individuals is a self-contradiction. And an action or an ordinance of life that does not at some point of time or other lead to welfare for definite individuals has no ethical value. A possibility that can never become reality is an impossibility.

The single individual is only a drop in the ocean. And the ocean does not exist for the sake of the single drop alone. But what is an ocean that does not consist of drops?

³⁾P. Carus: *The Ethical Problem*. Chicago 1890. p. III cf. p. 33, 38, 40. — Cf. the discussion between Carus and me in *The Monist*. July 1891. I cannot see that Carus by his closer explanations robs his idea of its unclearness, so long as he (like Wundt) denies that in ethics one must always think of a sum of individuals (of greater or less extent, perhaps of an extent that cannot be surveyed) when one wishes to operate with the concept of society.

And will not the whole ocean be clear when each single drop is clear? And only then is it perfectly clear.

Just as there are those who cannot see the forest for the trees, so there are those who cannot see the trees for the forest. In ethics this shows itself in human striving being regarded as a means to superhuman ends. Every ethics that will not give up the possibility of progressive verification must hold fast that society is always represented by definite individuals. It need not therefore overlook that ethical activity, like all manifestation of force, is connected with the whole process of the world.

[170] 5. One might try to take a middle road and set *individual and social ethics side by side as two independent domains*. So BENTHAM and STUART MILL assume that there is a domain where the individual rules alone, and another where social regards rule. MILL even holds that such faults as concern only ourselves and have no influence on the welfare of others are not really “moral” faults. Foolish conduct, bad taste, the dominion of low and sensual impulses, lack of personal dignity and of self-respect may, according to MILL, be present without the interests of others being in the least touched thereby. No one, Mill holds, is in the least responsible to his fellow men for his self-development, “since it is not for the sake of the good of society that one is to answer for it”¹⁾.

What Mill combats is the intervention of state power and of public opinion (the “moral police”) in the individual’s inmost concerns. He fears spiritual tyranny and unhealthy compulsion if one starts from the assumption that there is nothing in a man’s conduct that concerns him alone. But he mixes up two things here. It is one thing that the individual through and through, even in his inmost being and with all his qualities, must be regarded, and regard himself, as a member of the race, and that his willing and acting are therefore subject to an ethical valuation whose standard is given in the principle of the general welfare, — quite another thing *who* in the single case is to appear as the proclaimer and enforcer of the ethical judgment. Ethically regarded, everyone stands and falls first and foremost before his own inner tribunal in conscience, and ethics is a doctrine of what judgments this inner tribunal must consistently pass. The degree in which a man develops his faculties and powers must above all else fall under this

[171] tribunal. A. S. ØRSTED has rightly said that worse than committing a breach of the right of property is squandering, through self-interest, vanity or sluggish inactivity, the strength with which we could work in the service of progress¹⁾. It is not therefore said

¹⁾*Om Friheden*. Danish transl. p. 141 f. — Bentham’s statements about “private ethics” (*Principles of Morals and Legislation*. XVII, 3, 20) are not quite clear, and there appears in him a tendency to subordinate social ethics wholly to individual ethics. Cf. above III, 16. — In some Danish writers of the most recent times (Starcke and Bang) a dualistic theory similar to Mill’s has appeared. See above III, 21.

¹⁾*Om Grænserne mellem Teori og Praxis i Sædelæren*. (Eunomia. Første Del. Copenhagen 1815). p. 105.

that it is expedient to allow other men a right to meddle in the single person's inner ethical household. One can grant the one and deny the other. Mill, on the other hand, denies the ethical significance of self-development because he fears thereby to give others the right to penetrate into the individual's private conduct. But he could reach his goal, namely the assertion of individual freedom against social pressure and moral police, without excluding self-development from the ethical domain. Nothing is more questionable than the great misunderstanding that ethics and public opinion are the same, and that a relation ceases to be subject to ethical judgment because no external authority has the right to call it to account²⁾.

There is nothing at all in the free development of the individual that cannot acquire ethical significance. What appears in the single person's inner life may perhaps be the first germ of great social processes. Every individual development can produce new forms and models; the lonely paths the single person walks may later become highroads. The energy, the fidelity and the wisdom he uses to seek out and clear these paths may become of decisive significance. It is not possible to separate the self-development and the inner household of single persons from the life of society and of the whole race. Even in play, in art, in faith and in the free life of mood of the single person the ethical is potentially present. Just as in external nature there is only apparently an absolute rest, while energy is always present, though often in so-called potential form, so there is in human life no point that may not possibly be subject to an ethical judgment. Some [172] have particularly wished to maintain the erotic relation and religion as private matters. This has no doubt been done for tactical reasons, namely in order not to be molested by morality in aesthetics, and in order to be able to move in social policy without colliding with ecclesiastical faith. In reality both the sexual relation and the religious relation are of very great ethical significance. Precisely in these domains qualities such as courage, fidelity, honesty and love of truth have the greatest value; precisely here baseness of disposition, wavering and timidity can become fateful. And the mere establishing of the presence of such qualities is, after all, an ethical judgment.

6. The inner relation between individual and social ethics is really given with the setting up of the principle of welfare itself. When the foundation of valuation is universal and disinterested sympathy, and the standard the general welfare, it follows that individual ethics must be subordinate to social ethics, without therefore vanishing in relation to it. The full grounding of the individual virtues, duties and rights can be reached only by regarding the individual in the social milieu, as a member of the struggling and striving

²⁾In his excellent work *The Utilitarians* (III, p. 286–299) *Leslie Stephen* has, in a direction similar to mine, criticized Mill's doctrine of the boundary between individual and social ethics.

race, whose inheritance it has received in its nature and in its external conditions of life, and whose development it is to carry further so far as it is able. Through taking part in the life and work of the race it will develop its own being.

The closer determination of the relation between individual and social ethics can be won with the help of some propositions that can be derived from the general principle of welfare.

The simplest form in which this principle appears is that the infliction of pain must always be grounded, while the production of pleasure and joy is justified in itself. The application of this proposition is simple and easy only in the very simplest cases, but on closer consideration one will find the proposition as the ultimate presupposition in composite cases too. The more remarkable is it that the proposition has been found questionable; it really says only what everyone — with the exception of the absolute ascetics, if there are any — must grant. Even the ascetics have as a rule regarded pain as a means of penance and practice, not as an end in and for itself.

[173] In this simple proposition, on closer psychological consideration, another very important proposition can be found enclosed.

In pain there makes itself known a hindering or a dissolution of life. This is clear in bodily pain, e.g. the pain of wounds, toothache, the pains of stone, cancer. Pain here answers to a transitional stage between unhindered, undivided life and the complete hindering and dissolution that comes with death. A Greek writer has said that if man were an absolutely simple being, he would not be able to feel pain: for then no dissolution could take place. But the converse holds too: only because the elements of life are always in the most intimate unity and coherence in the living being and do not form a mere aggregate, only for that reason can pain be felt. This holds for the life of the soul as well as for bodily life. Spiritual pain too expresses a hindering or a dissolution. Grief at a loss appears now as a hindering, the thought of the irrevocability of what is lost displacing all other thoughts, now as a dissolution, the opposition between the value of what is lost and the loss threatening to burst consciousness. Doubt is a state of pain, consciousness being drawn in opposite directions by conflicting possibilities and tendencies. The pain of remorse is conditioned by the violent opposition between our acknowledged ideal and the thought of our actual willing and acting. On the other hand everything that furthers the unity and harmony of the life of consciousness is bound up with the feeling of pleasure. Our life of consciousness involuntarily strives to overcome the sufferings and pains that cannot be removed by summoning higher, comprehensive powers. A new feeling forms, in which the bitterness is taken up as an element in a more composite or

mixed feeling. Most of our so-called higher feelings have this composite character. But at all stages our life of feeling stands as the expression of the advance or decline of our life. The difference between the feelings rests in this respect on the more or less central position they occupy within the whole of our life¹⁾.

By virtue of this close connection between feeling and the individual's being as a whole, the principle of welfare leads directly over to *the principle of the free personality*, i.e. to the maxim that no personal being may be treated and regarded merely *as a means*, but must always at the same time be an end. In personal beings we have, after all, the central places to which the effects of our actions propagate themselves, and where their most important significance appears. At these points in the world the value of life is felt, — and the value of life exists (as actual value) only when it is felt. An injury or a hindering here will therefore necessarily diminish the value of life, and if no suffering is felt at the hindering because this produces dullness, then that is precisely the greatest injury to the principle of welfare, since the very capacity to feel value is abolished. — The principle of welfare presupposes that we are able to transport ourselves to the strange central places and to consider what influence the actions that are to be judged exert there. On this capacity, after all, rests also the possibility of sympathy proper.

This principle, which thus follows from the principle of welfare, was set up by IMMANUEL KANT with the help of an entirely different grounding, which it will be of interest to consider. Since Kant regards the ethical law as purely formal and a priori, he cannot really derive definite ends for ethical action from it. Every end that was to be set would lead beyond the pure form of the law. And yet Kant sees that every action must have an end. The difficulty that thereby arises he thinks he solves in the following way. Since the human personality has the capacity to subject itself with freedom and inwardness to a universal law, such a personality stands as an absolute end and ought never to be degraded by being treated as a mere means. It is the ethical in its inwardness and sublimity that is man's patent of nobility, which under no circumstances may be taken from him by treating him as a mere means. In *Kritik der praktischen Vernunft* (Kehrbach's ed. p. 106) Kant expresses himself on this as follows: "In the whole world everything one wills, and over which one has power, can also be used *merely as a means*; only man, and with him every rational being, is *an end in itself*." For by virtue of the autonomy of its freedom it is the subject of the moral law, which is holy. Precisely on account of this autonomy of freedom every will, even the single individual's own will directed upon itself, is limited by the condition of agreement with the autonomy of the [175]

¹⁾Cf. on the psychological points of view used here my *Psychologi* VI B, C and D.

rational being, — namely so limited that this being cannot be subjected to any purpose that is not possible according to a law that could spring from its own will, — thus so that it is never treated merely as a means, but at the same time as that which is itself an end.”

It is Kant’s merit to have deepened the concept of personality, since he stresses at once the inwardness and the universality of personal life. The personality is an inner world that follows its own law and yet can stand in connection with the great world. But the question is whether Kant has here applied this significant thought in a justified way. Personal beings we learn to know only by experience, and only by experience — through the interaction that social life brings with it — do we learn to put ourselves in their place and to feel how life takes shape in them. But from the purely formal law neither the capacity for this nor the interest in it can be derived; no definite content whatever can be derived from it. Perhaps that principle of personality stands as all the more significant for having developed on the ground of real life and of history, even before we can assign it its systematic place in ethics. That it follows directly from the principle of welfare there can be no doubt.

It was further a one-sidedness in Kant that the concept of personality was restricted to the strictly moral. In all spiritual fields and in all relations of life the personality can appear, and the law of its working can spring from itself. Everywhere — not only in the moral field — self-activity is the mark of personality; it carries on the struggle for life in its own way, from its own center. In the rhythm of pleasure and pain there expresses [176] itself at all stages of life the favoring or the hindering of this activity, perhaps awakened from without, but determined by an inner law.

But although Kant’s grounding cannot be acknowledged, it is nevertheless a great merit he has earned by setting up the principle of the free personality. And even if one grants the validity of the grounding he has attempted, it is of no slight importance that the important proposition can be reached by different roads. Both according to Kant’s grounding and according to the one I have attempted, a personal being stands both as an end and as a means. On this rests the significance of the free development of the personality.

Freedom is an *end*: for the unhindered unfolding of faculties and powers is a good, since it is bound up with the most inward satisfaction, while the feeling of compulsion and hindrance is a feeling of pain. Of freedom we ask: *why not?* Of compulsion we ask: *why?* The burden of proof lies on those who would use compulsion. Only as a means and preparation for the free unfolding of the powers can compulsion and barriers be justified, as for example when the boundless unfolding of one individual would make

the development of one or more other individuals impossible.

But freedom is also a *means*: the free unfolding of individuals produces new possibilities and leads to the discovery of new directions for the life of the whole race. The new always begins at single points and then spreads to larger circles. Personal beings are not merely the central places where the value of life is felt, but also the places from which the movements of life ever anew go out. Through freedom new centers of independent activity are created, and since the race consists of personal centers, the life of the race too thereby becomes richer and more vigorous. Herein lies the great significance of the modern movements of emancipation: that the slave, the peasant, the worker and woman come to stand as free and independent members of the race can only make its life richer and more fruitful. Emancipation is demanded by society's own interest. This thought STUART MILL enjoins precisely in his book *Om Friheden* (p. 115–119), in remarkable contradiction to his assertion of individual self-development as indifferent in the moral respect. He demands the protection of the independence and originality of [177] single personalities, because the impulse to everything wise and noble comes from single individuals, and because the spiritual dominion of the masses would lead to general mediocrity. Remarkably enough, at the same time as the work named, an analogous thought came forth in CHARLES DARWIN's doctrine of the development of organic life through the new means and ways for the struggle for existence that individual variations make possible. Only where such variations appear (from one cause or another), only there can the natural selection exercised by the conditions of life come to work. Both biologically and sociologically, then, the free unfolding of the nature of single individuals proves to be a significant means of progress.

We can here throw light from a new side on the relation between motive and action. As we have seen (III, 18), valuation consistently goes back from the action to the motive, because it must be the main thing to hit the source from which the action springs. We started there from the practical significance of valuation and of valuing judgments. Here we can supplement this consideration with the help of the principle of the free personality. For the inner life of a personal being ought not — by virtue of this principle — to be made a mere means to the production of external effects. It must not be a mere wheel in a machine. Even where the individual is regarded as a member of a larger whole, its action is to spring from its peculiar being, from its inner disposition. Only then can the action be called perfect, when it at once springs from personal peculiarity and intervenes in the great whole in a furthering and happiness-bringing way. The duties and virtues that society demands of the single person are to be at the same time means and forms of the

individual's own development.

It is the great pedagogical (or perhaps better: psychological) art, which there may be occasion to practice both on the part of single individuals and on the part of the power of society: to call forth motives that make self-activity possible. If by compulsion one would understand every intervention on the part of others, such a motive-awakening activity [178] would be a compulsion, even if it were exercised ever so indirectly and Socratically. It is more natural, however, to understand by compulsion merely an external influence that calls forth pain or fear (cf. V, 2 c). And the motive-awakening intervention does not necessarily presuppose compulsion in this narrower sense of the word. A responsibility follows with all such intervention; but when it consists in compulsion proper, it needs a quite special justification. There is much to learn here from the theoretical anarchists, who reject all authority and all spiritual and physical compulsion. When one asks how such an anarchist can bring up his children, he will answer that he seeks indirectly to awaken the involuntary feelings that in his opinion make up the ethical foundation, so that the children come to do what is right without command and without compulsion. He will thus try to carry through what Rousseau called "negative education." The question (which the anarchist settles rather quickly) is how far all motive-awakening influence can take place in this way, and in how high a degree compulsion proper can be restricted. But here we have to do only with the general principle, that is, with the distribution of the burden of proof. —

But here the question arises again whether in every single individual there is the same possibility of the arising of motives for the actions that must be demanded on the part of society. When one does not dogmatically start from the assumption that all men are wholly alike in the respect named, there arises here, as shown earlier (see IV, 2), the unavoidable demand for the individualization of the ethical law. The ethical law cannot then be completely given by a determination of "the conditions of social life," regardless of how the single individuals are placed with regard to satisfying these conditions. Or rather: when one does not start from a purely external relation between individual and society, one cannot fix the conditions of social life without including among them the peculiarities of the single individuals in qualitative and quantitative respect. The condition of a sound social life is, after all, first and foremost that there be a harmonious relation between the development of the single persons and the demands of [179] the whole. And such a relation presupposes in turn that the task set the single person answers to the qualitative and quantitative presuppositions he brings with him. Since society consists of all the single persons, this is not an external demand made on it. Only

there is a real society present where the single person can at every point be both end and means. A conflict between the demand of society and individual nature therefore points to an imperfection in society itself, not merely — or not always — in the individual.

Not only the usual moral sermon overlooks this. But every conception that lets the ethical come to man “from without” — whether one builds on the principle of authority, or on a conception of the race as something other and more than an organic whole of individuals, or on public opinion as the sum of all ethics — every such conception must of course reject this consideration. One thereby cuts oneself off from treating some of the deepest-lying personal problems. An illusory and purely formal conclusion of the theory is bought by setting aside tasks that can, to be sure, only be solved approximately, but which it is nevertheless of great importance to hold fast. As at its first foundation (the motive of valuation), so too in the consistent carrying through of its principles ethics stands before the irrational (to use an analogy taken from arithmetic). There can here be question only of finding as many decimals as possible. —

Only by the consideration carried through here can there be a harmonious relation between individual and social ethics. They point mutually to one another, the individual being regarded as an organic member of society, and society as an organic whole of individuals. We set out individual ethics first because it presents the simplest relations; but we constantly hold fast to the social point of view as the one lying at the foundation, just as in social ethics we shall always take as the basis the point of view that the highest end and the best means of social life is the free unfolding of the peculiar powers of the single individuals.

INDIVIDUAL ETHICS

IX.

THE DIVISION OF INDIVIDUAL ETHICS.

1. The relation fixed above between individual and social ethics leads naturally to the division that must be followed within individual ethics.

Since from the very first we regard the individual as a member of society, and within society as both end and means, two tendencies appear in personal life that must be acknowledged and furthered: self-assertion and devotion.

The single individual is an end, since it is the very representative of society; in its life the life of society stirs, and by injury to it the life of society is injured. It is one of the end points in which development runs out. The more it is able to assert itself and to unfold its faculties and impulses, so that life stirs in it with full strength and harmony, the higher a stage is reached — not merely for the single person himself, but for society. Society consists of individuals, and its life must therefore be the fuller and more vigorous the more each single person is able to develop what lies in his nature. The single person is a little world whose existence and development is an end valid in itself. *Self-assertion* — in its different forms: self-preservation, self-control and independence — thereby comes forward as an essential virtue. It is a duty the single person has at once toward himself and toward society. Regard for self and regard for society here go so immediately into one that it may become indifferent which of the points of view one stresses. No appeal [184] to a conscious interest in society or to the abstract principle of welfare is needed to show that self-assertion must be regarded as valuable by others too than by him who practices it. A vigorous and harmonious unfolding of the personality is the object of immediate sympathy and admiration. As HUME¹⁾ already remarked, it is still harder to explain from egoistic interest the admiration in others for the virtues that benefit an individual himself than it is to explain the acknowledgment of social virtues in this way. We do not necessarily regard others' self-assertion as a mere means. It is an unnecessary detour to take when Hobbes²⁾ explains the abhorrence of drunkenness by its easily leading to breaches of the peace and in general making it impossible to rely on the individual. At the sight of a lack of self-control in others we feel immediately a flaw in the vigorous and harmonious self-unfolding of which we wish others' conduct of life to give us a picture. We recognize that where such a picture meets us, there at this point of the world the highest has been reached. The tacit presupposition, of course, lies at the basis that the

¹⁾*Enquiry concerning the Principles of Morals* VI, 1. Cf. *Treatise* III, 3, 1.

²⁾*De cive* III, 25.

strength and harmony of the single person do not conflict with the conditions under which others can strive to reach a similar goal for their part, but are perhaps even a means to it. There is, after all, as developed earlier (VIII, 5), hardly anything within individual development, even in its freest peculiarity, that cannot become of social significance; in all self-assertion a potential social ethics is present. But in acknowledging self-assertion as an end ethics points beyond itself. If ethics exists for the sake of life, and not life for the sake of ethics, there will be a limiting point where the validity of the norms ceases, because the immediate unfolding of life needs no justification. Where this limiting point [185] lies, and how near one is to it in the single case, may be difficult to decide when doubt arises. But immediate self-assertion has value as an end, not merely as a means; about this there can be no doubt on the whole point of view that is adopted here.

Since the individual, however, is always only one among many, and since the interests of the life of society make up a larger whole than the sum of the interests of his isolated life, *devotion* may come into opposition to self-assertion. Devotion to a larger circle of interests may bring with it a widening of interest that hinders the individual harmony for which self-assertion strives. Self-assertion has to do with the individual's own little world and regards it as a closed whole, but devotion demands that this little world be brought into connection with a larger world, and this may bring with it a provisional disturbance of the inner harmony of the little world. It is not said, after all, that the ordering of the little world fits without more ado into the great order of the world. Closing off and widening may stand in opposition, even in conflict, with one another. Therefore self-assertion and devotion must be regarded as two different tendencies in character, two different virtues, and we find accordingly that different weight has been laid on them in the history of ethics.

Yet it is not necessary that they come into conflict with one another. The need for unity and continuity that already expresses itself in self-assertion, insofar as the single personality is regarded as a closed whole, can lead beyond the individual totality and appear as a need for connection with a more comprehensive whole. The single person can perhaps gain coherence within his own little world only by attaching his interest to something lasting, something ever advancing, something that cannot be surveyed. He can perhaps be true to himself only by being true to something greater than himself. In this way devotion would be the continuation of self-assertion.

It follows from this, too, that it would be wrong to set up devotion as the passive virtue in opposition to self-assertion as the active one. Sympathy, the feeling that leads immediately to devotion, is not a tendency to passive sinking down that would form

an opposition to the energetic impulse of self-preservation. In the most recent times there has been proclaimed the right of the stronger, egoistic ruthlessness, as the highest thing, as the mark of character of “the superman,” and it has then been regarded as a slave revolt that love of mankind was proclaimed as an ethical principle. In opposition to this assertion, made by NIETZSCHE, it must be maintained that sympathy or love of mankind, where it is genuine and original, is precisely an expression of strength, of spiritual power. It presupposes that not all energy is consumed in the service of one’s own purely individual needs, but that there is a surplus that makes it possible to feel pleasure or pain at others’ fate, even if this does not intervene in one’s own individually closed existence. The mind then has a greater fullness at its disposal than in isolated self-assertion. On account of this surplus fullness of strength and interest the individual has in genuine sympathy a true superiority. Its conduct in devotion is determined from within and is independent of others’ hatred or love, of their contempt or admiration. It is — to use an image of MARCUS AURELIUS — like the pure and strong spring that lets its stream well forth even if one throws dirt and stones into it; it washes them away, and its purity is not changed thereby. [186]

Already *primitive Christianity* described love as a power that is independent of whether others love us or not. The love that is only “reactive,” called forth only by others’ services, it declares insufficient. True love makes no distinctions, comprises all — just as the sun and rain of heaven fall to the share of all. Love bears all things, endures all things, overcomes all things! The long-suffering of love lets it endure in spite of the greatest resistance. (The Gospel of Matthew V. — 1 *Corinthians* XIII. — *De imitatione Christi* III, 5).

In modern times this conception of sympathy as an expression of strength is found in Spinoza and Rousseau. For Spinoza the spiritual strength that makes up the essence of virtue appears partly as self-assertion or courage of life (*animositas*), partly as high-mindedness (*generositas*), and the high-minded man seeks to help others and to join them to himself in friendship, for “souls are conquered not by arms, but by love and high-mindedness.” Rousseau explains love of others from the overflowing strength of self-assertion, which involuntarily spreads and comprises others, provided only they resemble us, because it is too great for its own needs. The difference between ourselves and others is not heeded; the fullness of life goes beyond all barriers. “La force d’une âme expansive m’identifie avec mon semblable!” Love is, as Rousseau expresses himself, a consequence of love of oneself (*amour de soi*), which he distinguishes from self-love (*amour propre*). Self-love sets barriers, since man compares himself with others and [187]

separates himself from them. But thereby we become precisely dependent on others, which we are not in love. Later a similar conception has been put forward by JOUFFROY and other French philosophers, especially Guyau, to whom KRAPOTKIN attaches himself¹⁾.

There is of course a soft and passive kind of feeling that also goes under the name of sympathy and love. And there is a sentimentality that enjoys one's own supposedly great sympathy, just as another kind of sentimentality enjoys one's own supposedly great pains. But these forms may not be regarded as typical, and the last-named is even rather a kind of egoistic self-enjoyment. —

A characteristic difference between self-assertion and devotion consists in this, that in the former the individual stands as an end and yet works as a means, since society is strengthened and developed by the self-assertion of its single members, — in the latter the individual works as a means and yet becomes an end, since its personal life becomes richer and fuller by getting a larger field to work in. This difference also shows the inner connection between them. If we conceive *justice* in the way indicated earlier (III, 9), we can find in it the harmonious unity of self-assertion and devotion, of the tendency to close [188] oneself off in oneself and to open oneself to a larger connection. As regards psychological origin, justice may have its root in self-assertion, namely when this is bound up with the acknowledgment of others' equal entitlement, an acknowledgment that is perhaps first extorted by power and authority, but which through displacement of motive can pass into the individual's flesh and blood. But it may also have its root in devotion, namely when this is bound up with an understanding of the peculiarity and significance of the single personalities (one's own personality too). Self-assertion and devotion are each by itself more elementary tendencies. Justice is the more comprehensive tendency that sets the crown on the development of ethical character. Justice presupposes that the individual asserts and develops himself not merely without hindering the development of others, but in such a way that this is thereby furthered, — and that the individual devotes himself to comprehensive interests of life in such a way that his own personality is thereby developed and asserted¹⁾.

Not only self-assertion and devotion are here in harmony, but also knowledge and feeling. A great end stands before thought, and this seeks by the way of experience and inquiry the means to realize it. It is a great work of distribution that is to be done in the

¹⁾Cf. my *Psykologi*. VI C, 3. 7. — *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². I p. 326; 494 f. — Jean Jacques Rousseau *og hans Filosofi*², p. 101—105. On Jouffroy see Bouillier: *Du plaisir et de la douleur*. Paris 1877. p. 169 f. — Guyau: *Esquisse d'une Morale sans obligation ni sanction*. Paris 1885. — Krapotkin: *Anarkistisk Moral*. (Danish transl. in "Proletaren" 1896). — Cf. also William James: *Varieties of belief*. p. 279—284.

¹⁾Already in Greek ethics justice appears in close connection with love of mankind. Cf. Aristotle: *Ethica Nic.* VIII, 1. 13. 14. Cicero: *De finibus*. V, 23, 65.

service of the race, and the distribution is determined by a clear understanding of the need and welfare of the single personalities. —

Individual ethics, according to this whole consideration, is naturally divided into the doctrine of self-assertion and the doctrine of devotion. When these two tendencies are depicted in such a way that a harmonious union between them becomes possible, the chief ethical virtue, justice, will thereby also have been depicted.

2. In the different individuals these tendencies play a different part. There are natures that achieve the highest they are capable of without the ethical feeling stirring in them as a special feeling beside the others. Self-assertion and devotion unfold in them without special motives and without conscious effort. The possibility of such ethical Aladdin- [189] natures cannot be denied. There may be those in whom such an Aladdin-nature is present only as regards some, not as regards all, tasks and relations. As easily and unconsciously as they solve some of the ethical tasks, so much reflection and effort must they apply to others. But there are also natures for whom it is of the very greatest importance that the ethical feeling be awakened in them and come to speak a decisive word in the single cases. The immediate impulse to self-assertion and to devotion either does not stir strongly enough in them, or else there is not the right relation between the two tendencies. — It is of ethical-social significance that such differences exist. A larger and richer work is thereby made possible than if all came with the same conditions. Both the multiplicity itself and the relations of opposition it makes possible work to release and to develop.

In the systematic exposition, of course, all these individual differences cannot be exhausted. We must confine ourselves to giving an ordered and grounded account of the most important of the qualities of character that the principle of welfare demands.

X.

THE PERSONAL FOUNDATION OF THE ETHICAL LIFE.

1. For various reasons it has been denied that preparation and practice have any value whatever in the ethical respect.

The reaction against the ascetic line of thought has especially contributed to this assertion. Asceticism — by which is here understood freely chosen effort and suffering that serves merely for practice, not for the attainment of demonstrable ends — might, it is held, be consistent at the standpoint of Neoplatonism or of medieval Christianity. For the [190] Neoplatonists the task was to free the soul from the impurity it had incurred by entering

the earthly world. From the strict Christian standpoint abstinence, mortification and self-humiliation were sacrifices of atonement to an angry God. But where such views no longer prevail, can asceticism there be granted any justification and significance?

With the transition to a new view of life there is easily bound up an inclination, for the sake of a superficial “consistency,” to throw away everything to which value was attributed at the earlier standpoint. What has developed historically under the influence of certain motives may very well keep its value, because these motives fall away and must be replaced by others. (Cf. I, 4). Every ethical standpoint must make demands for bearing effort and suffering, and practice will therefore always be necessary. It is, to be sure, a maxim of great importance that all infliction of pain must be justified, while the production of pleasure has its provisional justification in itself. But where one strives toward a distant and comprehensive end, much preparation and many privations may become necessary. Every serious view of life will therefore be able to learn from the heroes of asceticism. These too, after all, really regarded suffering and privation as a good only because they were thereby strengthened and practiced for attaining the great and distant goal they craved. Their fault was that they set the goal in another existence, whose conditions were to be *wholly* different from those of the present life, so that the goal could not be reached through positive work in the given world. Their asceticism rested on a distrust of natural life and its powers. But precisely at a standpoint where one does not get the rules for one’s conduct through supernatural revelation or mystical promptings, but where weight is laid on the independent authority of human thought and feeling, precisely there great demands are made on the individual’s powers, and it becomes of decisive importance that these powers be exercised, so that the foundation of the ethical life may become firm and secure. There are, besides, natures that in the [191] ethical respect know only an Either—Or, either strict discipline or complete slackness. They can keep themselves up only by submitting to a thoroughgoing discipline. The great spread of the temperance movement shows that there are not a few such natures. Often these commit the error of believing that what is necessary for them must be a law for all.

It has been objected that it is a sign of imperfection when actions are undertaken merely for practice, since means and end then fall apart. Such things may, it is said, be necessary when one wishes to acquire mechanical skills; but the ethical life is to be the life of the whole personality. Such things may also suit the standpoint of mystical and supranaturalistic asceticism, where one shunned real life and exercised the powers of the soul in solitude, so that one perhaps even found something especially meritorious in the

insignificance of the tasks, as when Egyptian monks watered sticks that were planted in sand.

This objection rightly starts from the assumption that life itself is the best school of all, even if it is the most troublesome and the most costly. It is inadmissible to withdraw from its demands in order to work on oneself in solitude. One cannot step out of the ranks to become a proper human being and then begin again. All true education takes place through interaction with real conditions. What the art of self-education can do here is to choose precisely the tasks and the relations that are suited to exercise and strengthen the powers before one proceeds to greater works. One ought always to exercise one's powers on something that has real significance. The definite calling that is chosen will be the natural school of character. At first imitation and the mechanical performance of prescribed functions are perhaps the highest one can attain; but through repetition and practice dispositions and aptitudes may be trained that make it possible to perform the work of one's calling with freedom and supported by one's own strength. Then a virtue answering to the calling has formed. But it is not at all times that the real tasks lay claim to all our strength. The time can then be used to prepare oneself for the possibilities. Practice then becomes like a game or an art. In art we have to do not with life itself but with a reflection of it, and yet art and life have the same content; the use of the powers in art can therefore be a preparation for their use in life. Besides, the domain of possibilities is greater than that of reality. In external action often only a slight part of personal life gets occasion for development and formation. On the stage of the inner life, in the clash of moods and thoughts and through the interaction of budding motives, an essential part of the work on the development of character often takes place. SCHLEIERMACHER has particularly expressed this in his "Monologues" (chap. 4). "From how many sides," he asks, "would man not remain undetermined and unformed if his inner acting aimed only at what actually befalls him from without?... I know that my outer life will never be able to present and complete my inner being from all sides... I live in quiet concealment — and yet on the world's great stage, rich in deeds!" Later S. KIERKEGAARD expressed a similar thought: "Only he who is formed by possibility is formed according to his infinity." He adds that the real situations are not so clear and unconditional as the possibilities can be thought, and that the test through possibilities can therefore be the stricter; but he also has an eye for how easy it is to deceive oneself when one is tested merely by possibilities. That the possibilities can also suck the strength out of the will is a side of the matter on which he does not dwell¹⁾.

¹⁾Søren Kierkegaard *som Filosof*, p. 50–51.

2. The development of all spiritual faculties can serve to fortify and develop the ethical feeling. The *strength*, *range* and *purity* of conscience depend not merely on an education of the life of feeling, but also on the development of knowledge and of the will. At the standpoint of the free conscience, after all, it is not merely a matter of blind obedience, of the command being heard in consciousness and the action following mechanically. The free conscience seeks to set its tasks itself and to see their justification. It is not only the philosopher who turns testingly against the traditional and instinctively approved rules; the task may be set for anyone to tear himself loose from what has [193] hitherto held and try untrodden ways. The clarity and consistency of knowledge let the single person catch sight of the cases in which from weakness or egoism he evades carrying through his own acknowledged law, and it also teaches him to find holes and unmotivated barriers in the current morality. What he has thus recognized in the calm and bright times, it is then a matter of holding fast in the dark and agitated moments; only through an exertion of the will can fidelity to oneself and to the truth one has recognized be preserved.

Strength and *range* conscience acquires only where thought and imagination are alive and active. Thought must follow actions in their effects, which often branch out into many relations, and imagination must give vivid images of these effects. Narrowness and prejudice often come not from a lack in the life of feeling, but from a lack of imagination or of logical consistency. Mere knowledge is of course not enough; it must be practiced and made a constant thought, that is, a thought that by virtue of the laws of the connection of ideas asserts itself again easily and quickly where there is use for it. It thereby becomes a part of our real self, of the circle of thoughts and feelings that forms the center of gravity of our spiritual nature, and to which we always return, however much momentary influences and promptings draw us away from it. Neither the development of ideas nor that of feelings takes place wholly without our self-activity, and once attention has been awakened, many occasions will present themselves for intervening regulatively. — One thing shall only be especially stressed. It is not only theological ethics that has its books of edification. There can be books one seeks out ever anew in order to strengthen one's thoughts and one's feeling. Newspaper reading and entertaining reading ought not to be all the spiritual food one gets, if one does not wish to weaken one's inner life. What each will choose here depends on his character and turn of mind; but no one can do without the collectedness and concentration that serious reading brings with it. We are thereby led into a realm of ideas and possibilities from which we can go with widened and strengthened feeling to the practical tasks.

As regards the purity of conscience, self-examination is of the greatest importance, [194] so that we may become clear about our own motives and learn to know our powers. Self-knowledge always has its limits, since much of what moves within us comes forth only very indistinctly before clear consciousness. There may, besides, lie possibilities and aptitudes in our individuality that have not yet made themselves felt either inwardly or outwardly. We can therefore never be sure that the center of our consciousness is also the center of our individuality¹⁾. But as regards the conscious motives, — what we have really thought, felt and resolved, — we must be able to get clear. There is, no doubt, in most people an inclination to self-deception, to wish to look better in one's own eyes than one really is, to embellish for oneself the purity of one's motives and the seriousness of one's resolves. But it is of decisive importance that one be honest with oneself and learn to tear apart the illusions in which one so easily spins oneself. This inner truth is the condition of every vigorous and sound activity. On a lie no lasting building can be erected. — Self-deception occurs especially easily in such fields where no exact rules can be set up, and ethical problems very quickly become so intricate that no general principle can untie the knot for us. Even if we are not in doubt about the quality of what is right, insoluble doubts may arise as to what degree and what range our activity is to have. If only those were right who hold that one has done one's duty when one has done what "society" requires, and that it is not a duty to earn "merit"! But there are those whose inner spectator is not so easily satisfied, and in whom the fear of self-deception in fixing "the quantum satis of manly will" will therefore always stir anew.

Modern civilized life has an outward-turned tendency, easily leads to an unhealthy self-forgetfulness. Absorbed as one easily becomes by the changing multiplicity of external events and circumstances, one comes to regard what goes on within oneself as [195] indifferent. That outer world one regards as the real reality, the inner experiences as a fleeting reflection of it. But the real life is always the inner life; it is that which gives the outer its significance. From it, besides, forces can go out that can intervene to change the outer world; but such forces are not fostered when one lets oneself drift with the stream. Every personal inner being is one of the spiritual hearths in the world, and the task is to keep the fire pure and vigorous. There can be a kind of spiritual suicide that consists precisely in letting the fire on the inner hearth go out from torpor. The ideal is let go, no motive of valuation stirs, and in the end not even instinct holds one up. In suicide of this kind not even a splash is heard, as from one who drowns himself. SIBBERN has rightly described conscience as a spiritual impulse of self-preservation, the expression of a kind

¹⁾*Psychologi* VII B, 5 a.

of care for oneself. One shows care for oneself here by not lowering the demands one makes on oneself. The level of the self must not be lowered.

Self-knowledge may sometimes be made very difficult by the composite in human character and the sporadic in human development. Different, even mutually conflicting motives and tendencies may press forward; now the one tendency prevails, now the other, — and in which of them, then, is man to recognize his real I? What stirs in us in the enthusiastic, the “best” moments may be most different from what comes forth in the evil times, and yet both belong to our I. Or we judge and act rightly and surely in some relations, while in other relations we let ourselves be blindly led by selfish passions. Here the charge of hypocrisy lies so near that popular morality does not care to undertake, nor indeed understands how to undertake, any thorough psychological inquiry — and still less understands how to hold back its judgment. In such problematic states there often expresses itself a fermentation out of which a clear and harmonious character can later develop. But there are also natures that are and remain problematic, or in whom [196] the conflict between the elements of the soul at last bursts the unity of character¹⁾.

3. But there can also be question of asceticism in a narrower sense, of hardening and of practicing the capacity to endure effort and suffering. Among savage and warlike peoples a great part of education, self-education too, consists in the development of hardiness, the capacity to bear cold, hunger and physical pain. In civilized life such physical hardening is no doubt less necessary, but many of the drawbacks of civilized life surely stem from one's having lost sight of it too much. Physical hygiene is for a great part also a school for the will. The self-conquest and patience that must be applied for the benefit of physical health can benefit spiritual health.

But there is also a direct spiritual hardening. There can be inner cold, darkness and impotence just as well as outer. Even without a definite external cause heavy and dark times may come, when nothing will succeed, when hardly a train of thought can be held fast, and when everything loses its luster and its freshness for us. Even the hold one otherwise has in the inner sanction of conscience may fail. One then easily reaches for external means to keep oneself up, to comfort or to stimulate oneself²⁾, and with that the first step to decay is often taken. Where it is purely physical states of depression that set in, it may of course be entirely right to use external means. But it may often be the only right thing to offer resistance, to put one's will into keeping oneself up, in order not to

¹⁾Cf. *Jean Jacques Rousseau og hans Filosofi*. p. 11. — *Joseph Butler* has a series of interesting remarks on self-deception (Sermon X).

²⁾“When a man begins to grow lukewarm, he fears a slight effort and willingly accepts external comfort.” *De imitatione Christi*. II, 4, 3.

come to suffer from spiritual softness. It may, as an old mystic says, be necessary “to do without all comfort.” The will is thereby exercised in standing on its own feet.

Among the dark and anxious thoughts that in such times may haunt us, one likes in [197] modern times to count also the thought of death. In antiquity this was not so common. It has become common only since Christian theology specially sought to sharpen the fear of death, “like the mothers who rule their children by making them believe that the darkness is full of ghosts that seize the disobedient”¹⁾. In opposition to the predominant place and significance that theological ethics gave to the thought of death, SPINOZA declared that the free man, that is, the man who is guided by right knowledge, thinks of nothing less than of death; his inquiry is a *meditatio vitae*, has life as its object, not death²⁾. It is not thoughtlessness that is recommended here. Thoughtlessness can often cover a secret fear. No serious view of life can avoid struggling with the thought of death. But the difference between theological and philosophical ethics shows itself here in a characteristic way. For theological ethics the whole of life is a preparation for another life. We live in front of a curtain behind which true life is hidden, and everything we do and leave undone is in the end to serve to make us ready when the curtain is at last drawn aside. The thought of death therefore becomes here an all-deciding, a guiding thought. Philosophical ethics does not build on assumptions about what lies beyond experience, but maintains that life must first and foremost have its end, its value, in itself. We attribute value to life not because it is a preparation for another life that we do not know, but because it contains in itself something that is beautiful and good, something that deserves that one let oneself be filled by it and strike a blow for it. We live on realities, not on possibilities. Death is the limit of life, and he is best prepared to approach this limit who has really *lived*, that is, who has had a share in the best in the life we know.

About the realm of possibilities that begins where our world of experience ends, views will probably always differ. A scientific decision cannot be conceived. We stand [198] here before one of the open questions, and everyone may here, on his own account, have his faith or his hope. What philosophy here draws our attention to is merely the fact that all the features and qualities with which the images we can form of another world are furnished are taken from the world of experience, only that they are imagined in far higher degrees and freed from all imperfections. If one did not know from experience something that was true, good and beautiful, one would not be able to form the idea of an absolute truth and goodness, a complete blessedness. But then the true, the good

¹⁾Lecky: *History of European Morals from Augustus to Charlemagne*. I, p. 221 f.

²⁾Ethica IV, 67.

and the beautiful in the world of experience are a common ground where we can all meet, whether we assume another world or not. It is a fact that a life can be lived that is devoted to work in the service of the true and the good without any need being felt to believe in another existence. And no really ethical quality can be named that would become possible only through such a faith. Even if faith in another existence is a personal necessity for the single person, he has nevertheless no right to make it an ethical necessity for all.

The counterpart to the struggle against the dark possibilities is the thought of the shining models. Such personalities, in whom spiritual life stirs with strength and harmony, self-assertion and devotion working together at every single point, stand as models for those who must struggle laboriously to rise above what drags them down, or to hold together what threatens to dissolve in strife. An apparent paradox may arise here from the fact that the personalities who stand as models have not always themselves won perfection through toil and struggle. Energy and harmony may have been gifts of nature, and yet they can serve as signs that show the direction and strengthen hope. They show us what possibilities lie in human nature. Had those personalities had their hands full struggling within themselves, their lives would perhaps not have presented us with the picture of strength and harmony that now strengthens and guides us. In [199] Greek antiquity SOCRATES stood, with his wonderful harmony and energetic clarity of mind, as the great model. Powers that otherwise so easily come into greater or less opposition to one another, — thought and will, — were in him, so far as one can see, united in an original unity. It was this original strength of character in SOCRATES that made Socratic philosophy so one-sidedly intellectualistic and lay at the basis of the doctrine that virtue is knowledge. He did not know from his own experience the difference between knowing and willing¹⁾. But what made his philosophy so enigmatic in its one-sidedness has precisely made him a great model. Later, when Greek philosophy in NEOPLATONISM acquired a mystical-religious character, and virtue was conceived as a striving to become like God, the proposition was enjoined with particular emphasis that what becomes virtue in the copy is not virtue in the model; for as absolute being God can have no virtue²⁾. And in *the Christian Church* Christ was set up as the model, although according to the doctrine of the Church he was by his nature the sinless one. There is this truth in it, that development in the ethical field, as in the organic field, is made

¹⁾Karl Joël: *Der echte und xenophontische Sokrates*, Berlin 1893. I. p. 256. — The well-known passage in the “Phaedrus” where Plato has Socrates say that he does not know whether he is a simple and gentle or a manifold and flaming being must be put to Plato’s account; it was he, not Socrates, who first distinguished different parts of the soul. Cf. Aristotle: *Magna Moralia*. c. 1. Joël op. cit. p. 277.

²⁾Plotinus: *Ennead*. I, 2, 2. Cf. already Plato: *Theaetetus* p. 176 B.

possible by involuntary variations presenting new possibilities and leading into new directions. Already at low human stages of development not only the physically superior but also the spiritually superior will be able to come to stand as models for imitation. There has revealed itself in them, in a happy and natural form, a feature of character that is felt in its value, and that one believes will enrich life if it can be propagated further. Ethical Aladdins have been the lights on the often dark road of ethical development. The involuntary always precedes the voluntary, and the qualities that were raised to virtues had first to reveal themselves involuntarily before ethical selection could take [200] place. The impulse to imitate, admiration and reverence have exercised this selection, together with which the strict discipline on the part of ruling authorities and of social opinion has constantly worked; yet an interaction has taken place, since the holders of power and popular opinion could not escape the influence of the models either. FICHTE, GOETHE and CARLYLE have pointed to the great significance of personal models. "The good," says GOETHE in a conversation with Eckermann (1 April 1827), "is no product of human reflection, but is inborn, innate beautiful nature. More or less it is innate in all men, but in a high degree in certain quite preeminently gifted spirits. These have revealed their divine inner being through great deeds or teachings, and this has then, through the beauty of its appearance, won men's love and mightily led to reverence and imitation. But through experience and wisdom the value of the morally beautiful and good could come to consciousness, the bad proving in its consequences to be something that disturbed the happiness of the single person and of the whole, while the noble and right showed itself as something that brought about and secured particular and general happiness." There lies a great biological and ethical truth in these words of Goethe¹⁾ — a truth that is not diminished by our having to leave the cause of the spontaneous variations (what Goethe calls the innate or inborn in the eminent men) standing as a problem.

What no moral law and no ethical deduction can give, the great models give in living and vivid forms. Without a relation to such models the personal foundation of the ethical cannot develop into inwardness and firmness. Which models are chosen will depend on the need and circumstances of the choosing individuality. Perhaps the same model will not be able to guide us through the whole of life, just as it is not the same stars that guide the seafarer in the northern and the southern hemisphere. There is a constant [201] interaction between the ethical models and experience, as Goethe has seen so clearly.

4. History shows that ethical striving, in single persons as in society, in every period

¹⁾Cf. my *Etiske Undersøgelser*. p. 72. 82 f. — On Fichte and Carlyle see *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². II. p. 151. 385; cf. also p. 358 (Comte's positivist calendar).

and in every people, aims at calling forth and developing certain qualities of character that are then regarded as virtues. An ethical standpoint is designated not merely by the foundation of feeling that determines valuation, nor merely by the objective standard that is applied, or by the motives of action that are demanded, but also by the qualities of character that are admired and favored. A virtue, like a duty, can be grounded in different ways; but it is of special interest, both practical and theoretical, to see which virtues are particularly brought forward at different times.

It was *the Greeks* who first (in European mankind) set up an individual ethics. Early there formed a series of qualities that the Greek people admired and demanded. First in the series came to stand the four chief virtues, wisdom, courage, self-control and justice. PLATO (*Republic* Book 4, p. 427 E) takes it as given that goodness consists in these four qualities, and then tries, partly by a psychological, partly by a sociological way, to show that all virtue can be traced back to these four, later so-called cardinal virtues (from *cardo*, a door-hinge: thus the qualities on which everything turns). The remarkable thing now is that PLATO's psychological derivation is wholly independent of his sociological derivation. It was thus his conviction that the single individual in and for itself has a task to solve. This task consisted for Plato in making oneself a personal work of art, within which the different faculties and promptings work harmoniously together. The weight laid in the whole of Greek ethics, not merely among the philosophers, on harmony, limitation and moderation becomes properly intelligible only when we remember that Greek culture had as its historical presupposition a passionate and chaotic past. There were titanic forces that had to be formed before Olympian calm and loftiness could come to prevail. The different cardinal virtues express, each from its side, the ideal thus won.

[202] Wisdom lets thought be the guiding power, courage holds up personal dignity against external resistance and inner slackening, self-control brings it about that the sensual impulses are limited without being killed, and justice stands as the expression of the interplay of all the elements of the soul: it designates the state of the soul in which each single part of the soul exercises its own function without hindering the others'; it is thus a harmony of the soul. Although ARISTOTLE did not take up this doctrine of the four chief virtues, he nevertheless conceived virtue as an individual harmony that the single person, in and for himself, apart from his relation to society, strives to realize. Classical Greek ethics ended at this point in the great problem whether the demands society makes on the individual, and those the individual makes on itself for its full development, can be brought into agreement. Plato's and ARISTOTLE's individual ethics suited, besides, only those who could live for their personal development independently of material

labor. And for both Plato and Aristotle there was a virtue that in the end stood above all and threatened to burst the inner personal harmony: in the capacity for thinking and inquiry, especially for speculative contemplation, the great Greek philosophers saw man's real patent of nobility. Theoretical wisdom became for them the highest.

The four cardinal virtues nevertheless went on following ethical thought on its way. The Stoic PANAETIUS took them up (in the 2nd century B.C.), without its being clearly seen how he brought them into connection with his doctrine of love of mankind, and from him in turn CICERO got them and rendered them in his well-known work "on duties" (*De officiis*). If a certain displacement probably took place already in the classical Greek list of virtues when it passed over from Platonism to Stoicism, then a displacement quite certainly took place when it passed from the Greek thinkers into the hands of the Roman rhetor. The citizen's feeling of honor and patriotism came to play a particularly great part; *honestum*, what a good citizen is to fulfill, stepped into the place of "the beautiful," social duty into the place of personal harmony. Only in political conduct, not in private life, could greatness of soul be shown according to the Roman conception.

In *primitive Christianity*, as we have already seen (II, 4), love of mankind is crossed [203] by the ecstatic expectation. In close connection with this last motive stands the relation to God in faith and obedience as the condition of the soul's blessedness. And just as in Plato and Aristotle wisdom tended to raise itself above personal harmony, so within Christian ethics faith has a constant tendency to displace love from precedence among the virtues. Consistently, the more Christian ethics stressed the principle of authority, the obedience of faith had to become the highest virtue, — just as the first and highest sin was pride and arrogance (VI, 1). When *the Church Fathers* traced all virtue back to love, they usually meant by it love of God, which is one with faith. And since we can learn to know God only with the help of the Church, the proposition: "Without faith no virtue!" is soon replaced by the proposition: "Outside the Church no virtue!" The virtues of the heathen were then to be regarded only as splendid vices: for it is pride and conceit to wish to practice virtue for its own sake!¹⁾

Nevertheless on the side of the Church one felt in the field of ethics, as in that of dogmatics, a need to take up elements and forms from Greek thought. In AMBROSE's work *De officiis ministrorum*, which became the Middle Ages' handbook of ethics, Plato's and Panaetius's old division of the virtues was transferred, with Cicero as the intermediate link, onto ecclesiastical ground. This could not of course happen without various reinterpretations and displacements. In place of the individual harmony that Plato called

¹⁾Augustine: *De civitate dei* XIX. 25. — Cf., for the rest, De Wette: *Lærebog i den christelige Sædelære og sammes Historie*. Danish transl. § 148. 156. 171.

justice there steps living love of mankind, which leads to devotion — in place of wisdom there steps faith, obedience to authority, — courage shows itself especially as patience, and in place of self-control purity is set²⁾. Later AUGUSTINE tried to show that the four [204] traditional virtues appear in the Christian as four different forms under which love of God expresses itself¹⁾. In a more external way ancient and Christian ethics were combined in the Middle Ages, for example in Thomas Aquinas, the three “theological” virtues, faith, hope and love, being placed above the four “philosophical” virtues. But in spite of all reinterpretation and revaluation it is a sign of the continuity of ethical development that one has for so long been able to use, and still sometimes²⁾ to this day thinks one can use, the old Greek fourfold division of the ethically valuable qualities of character.

With *the Renaissance* vigorous self-assertion comes forth as an individual tendency that is cultivated and admired. Joy of life, power and enjoyment of a more or less ideal kind are placed in the first rank. In philosophical theory, in a whole series of thinkers from the 16th to the 19th century, *loftiness of mind* (*sublimitas*)³⁾, *courage of life* (*animositas*) and *high-mindedness* (*generositas*) come to stand as the greatest virtues. They are derived from the impulse of self-preservation and regarded as its highest and noblest forms. Telesio, Bruno, Campanella, Descartes and Spinoza are especially to be named here. Kant and Fichte join this series in their doctrine of the ethical qualities, since for Kant personal dignity asserted with strength of soul, as opposed to servility, for Fichte unconditional self-activity, as opposed to inertia, stood as the highest in the domain of character. In this valuation of character the reaction is at work against Christian ethics' [205] tendency to make obedience and humility the highest virtues.

In another series of thinkers the memory of the Stoic doctrine of love of mankind works together with the command of love of Christianity, so often displaced by faith, to lay the chief weight on *fellow-feeling* and the *feeling of humanity* as grounded in human nature itself and as qualities of character of the highest value. This tendency is represented by Shaftesbury, Hutcheson, Hume, Adam Smith, Comte, Schopenhauer and Herbert Spencer.

²⁾An interesting comparison between Panaetius, Cicero and Ambrose is given by R. Thamin: *St. Ambroise et la morale chrétienne au 4e siècle*. Paris 1895.

¹⁾*De moribus ecclesiae catholicae*. c. 15; 25. — Augustine refers to “the Book of Wisdom” (VIII, 7), where the four virtues are named.

²⁾Victor Cathrein: *Philos. mor.* p. 98—111. — S. Alexander: *Moral Order and Progress*. 2. ed. London 1891. p. 250 f. — P. Natorp: *Grundlinien einer Theorie der Willensbildung* (Archiv für system. Philos. 1895).

³⁾This concept had its model in a concept that occurs under different names in *Plato*, *Aristotle* and the Stoics, without properly finding its place in their division of the virtues. Cf. *Plato: Republic* Book 6, p. 486 A (διανοίας μεγαλοπρέπεια, loftiness of mind). *Aristotle: Eth. Nic.* IV. 7 (μεγαλοψυχία, having a great soul). *Seneca: Dialogi* I, 4—6; II, 11. 14 (magnanimitas). Both Aristotle and Seneca regard this quality as the highest.

For this last tendency it is evidently easiest to get a natural connection between individual and social ethics. In strength of mind and loftiness of mind the individual stood as free and independent, borne by the consciousness of having the conditions of its life predominantly in itself. A chief feature especially stressed in these virtues is that they lead to despising external honor in the consciousness of inner worth. As in the ancient doctrine of harmony, the individual stands here separated from society. In high-mindedness, as Descartes and Spinoza depict it, it is nevertheless an essential element that the individual has the consciousness of belonging to a larger whole whose interest is preferred to the purely individual ones. It is the great horizon, reaching beyond the individual personality, that conditions high-mindedness. But for that very reason this forms the transition to the qualities of character on which the other series of philosophers laid the chief weight. And it presupposes them. To high-mindedness one comes only by walking not only the ways of self-assertion but also those of devotion. The assertion of personal dignity described by Kant is conditioned not only by man's having the law for his action within himself, but also by this inner law of his being universal, holding for all rational beings. Nor is this tendency of character, then, psychologically and historically possible except when the individual is able to feel solidarity with a larger whole.

As we have sought to show earlier (see IX, 1), self-assertion and devotion do not necessarily stand in conflict with one another. They express two tendencies in human nature whose mutual relation may be most different in the different individuals, but [206] which may very well stand in a harmonious relation to one another, and which must both enter as elements into the perfect character. Devotion develops and widens the individual's being, and self-assertion fits it to fill its place in the whole to which it belongs. The Platonic concept of justice as personal harmony we can take up to express the inner connection, the higher unity of self-assertion and devotion. The ancient concept of harmony must be widened and deepened with the help of the ethical experiences expressed in the valuations of character of Stoicism, Christianity, the Renaissance and modern humanity. But such an alteration of the content of the concept is very well possible without bursting its frame. Our ethics is Greek ethics, which later ethical development, through its manifold fluctuations, has been able to alter and correct, but which can never be displaced so long as there is to exist anything that can rightly be called human ethics.

By a special inquiry into self-assertion and devotion each by itself we shall show the possibility and necessity of uniting them in harmonious cooperation and thereby of working for the realization of the highest human quality of character. It is, to be sure,

only an indirect description of justice that is reached by examining how self-assertion and devotion each from its side find their completion in it. But the question is whether it is possible to get further, if the ideal is not to become an abstraction floating in the air. In each single case justice develops either predominantly out of self-assertion or predominantly out of devotion. It thereby gets its different timbre in the different personalities. Over against this richness an ideal depiction of the higher unity of the two directions in our nature, which stand in constant tension, would acquire a dull tone. It is better, then, that we sharpen the problem and keep to the different roads by which development can approach the highest quality of character. Perhaps the time will come when it becomes possible for an ethicist to give a more perfect and more positive description of it.

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